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When God Bless America Replaces Thy Kingdom Come
How Patriotism Became Our Practical Savior

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Unless otherwise noted, all Scripture quotations are from the English
Standard Version (ESV).

*For every pastor who has been afraid to say what needs to
be said, and for every believer who suspects something has
gone wrong but cannot name it.*

*And for the crucified King who refuses to be anyone's
mascot.*

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INTRODUCTION

Not Persecuted—Seduced

"The church can survive decline. It cannot survive idolatry."

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The Disease Beneath the Symptoms

The crisis facing American Christianity is not primarily numerical. It is not, at its core, about attendance decline, shrinking affiliation, or the rise of the religious "nones." Those trends matter, but they are symptoms, not the disease. The church has survived under Nero, under Soviet communism, under Mao. It has endured regimes that imprisoned pastors and burned Bibles. It will survive declining membership rolls.

American Christianity is not being persecuted. It is being seduced.

And seduction is far more dangerous than persecution.

Persecution clarifies allegiance. It forces a choice. It strips away ambiguity. It makes the church decide whether Jesus is worth losing everything for. Seduction does the opposite. Seduction confuses allegiance. Seduction tells you that you can keep Jesus and keep power, keep worship and keep control, keep the cross and keep the sword. Seduction lets you keep everything.

We are not watching the church get crushed by the state. We are watching parts of the church crawl into bed with it.

And the Bible has a word for this.

The prophets called it *zanah*.

In the book of Hosea, God accuses Israel not of atheism—but of adultery. Israel still worshiped. They still sacrificed. They still

gathered in the temple. They still said the right words about covenant faithfulness. But when fear rose—when Assyria threatened, when political uncertainty came—they ran to foreign alliances for protection. They looked to treaties, chariots, and kings to secure what God had promised to secure.

And God said:

"You have played the whore... you have forgotten Me." —Hosea 2:5; 8:9

That Hebrew word—*zanah*—is not polite. It is visceral, relational language. It is the language of betrayal, of divided loyalty, of a spouse who keeps the marriage vows on paper while giving the heart away elsewhere.

Israel did not stop believing in God.

They simply stopped believing He was enough.

They kept Yahweh—but added chariots. They kept worship—but trusted Egypt. They kept the temple—but relied on treaties.

That was the betrayal. Not rejection. Relocated trust.

Why Seduction Is Deadlier Than Persecution

And that is why seduction is more dangerous than persecution.

Persecution forces you to choose. Seduction allows you to keep everything—God and power, worship and control, faith and legislation—until one becomes ultimate.

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the Lord our God." —Psalm 20:7

Chariots were not evil. Horses were not immoral. Political alliances were not automatically sinful. They were simply not ultimate.

The problem was not political engagement. The problem was dependence.

And when dependence shifts, worship follows.

So when parts of the American church begin to look to political leaders as protectors of Christianity... when legislation feels like salvation... when national survival feels like Kingdom survival... we are not merely being engaged citizens. We are flirting with zannah.

And the terrifying thing about zannah is that it feels necessary. It feels wise. It feels protective. It feels like "responsible leadership." It feels like "loving our children." It feels like "standing for truth." It rarely feels like idolatry while you are doing it.

That is the seduction.

What Happened to Us

In the span of a single decade, political polarization in America has not merely intensified; it has corroded the basic conditions that make civic life possible. Ten years ago we disagreed. Now we despise.

When citizens stop viewing political opponents as neighbors and start viewing them as threats—when disagreement becomes hatred—politics stops being a forum for rigorous discussion and becomes a battlefield for survival. And once politics becomes survival, integrity becomes optional. Anything becomes permissible. Fear turns ethics into strategy.

The church has not simply observed this shift. The church has absorbed it.

And if the church absorbs that mindset instead of confronting it, we are not being prophetic. We are being disciplined by fear.

That is what fear does. Fear does not patiently reason its way to conclusions. Fear does not wait for careful theological reflection. Fear reads one headline and reorganizes the soul.

When people feel like the world they grew up in is falling apart, they do not say, "Let's gather for careful reflection." They panic.

They want protection. They want someone strong. They want someone who looks like he can fix it.

And Christians do the same thing.

When we see culture shifting, when we feel like we are losing ground, when we think morality is collapsing, our first instinct should be to fall on our faces before God. But often it is not. We start looking for power. For someone bold. Someone loud. Someone who promises to take it back.

Something big enough. Strong enough. Decisive enough.

That instinct is not new. It is the same instinct that shaped first-century Israel. Many in Israel did not reject Jesus because they hated God. They rejected Him because He was not the kind of Messiah they wanted. They wanted someone to take the nation back to God through strength, sovereignty, and political restoration. They wanted Rome pushed out. They wanted national revival. They wanted visible victory.

Instead, Jesus came announcing something far more unsettling. He said He would not take the nation back to God by force, but that He would bring God back to the nation through repentance. Not by seizing a throne, but by carrying a cross. Not by crushing Rome, but by exposing the deeper bondage—the bondage of sin in all men.

They wanted a sword. He brought a towel.

They wanted a liberator who would secure the borders. He came as a Savior who would confront the heart.

And when the Messiah did not align with their political expectations, many chose the strongman over the Servant.

That preference did not feel like apostasy. It felt patriotic. It felt responsible. It felt necessary. And that is precisely what made it so dangerous.

No one stood up and said, "We reject God." They simply

preferred a different version of how God should work.

We are not consciously rejecting Jesus. We are simply preferring a different kind of Messiah. Sovereignty without surrender. Victory without repentance. Power without a cross.

When that shift happens, rejection does not come in the form of atheism. It comes in the form of substitution. We keep the "faith," but we adjust the center. We say "Jesus is Lord," but we look for security elsewhere. We preach the cross, but we trust the sword. We quote Scripture, but we are governed by fear.

And that is when we are most vulnerable.

The Theological Root: What Actually Preserves the Church?

Before we rush to condemn political engagement altogether, we need to be careful. Christianity has never taught withdrawal from public life. That claim is historically ignorant and theologically lazy.

Augustine wrote *The City of God* in the shadow of Rome's collapse. But notice what he does. He does not say, "Politics doesn't matter." He says politics matters precisely because it is not ultimate. He refuses the story Rome told about itself—that Rome was the guarantor of order, the savior of civilization, the meaning of history. Augustine is doing something more subversive than withdrawal; he is relativizing the earthly city.

He is not shrinking civic life into irrelevance. He is putting civic life in its place. He is telling Christians that the stability of Rome is not the stability of the Kingdom, that the fate of an empire is not the fate of the church, and that when Christians confuse the two, they do not become faithful citizens—they become anxious idolaters.

Augustine's argument is devastating because it denies the emotional center of imperial religion—the belief that Rome must endure or the world falls apart. Augustine said no. Rome can fall. The world can shake. History can humiliate your nation. And the Kingdom of God remains.

That is the issue in America. We are struggling to accept that our earthly city is penultimate. We keep acting as if the survival of the nation is the survival of the church.

Aquinas developed a sophisticated account of natural law and governance, insisting political authority has a legitimate role within God's ordering of creation. Calvin worked to shape civic structures in Geneva. Abraham Kuyper insisted Christ lays claim to every square inch of existence—including politics.

So yes: political engagement is not foreign to Christianity. But neither is political relativization.

The church has always engaged power. It has simply refused to worship it. And that is the difference.

The issue is not whether Christians vote, advocate, or participate in public life. The issue is ultimacy—what emotional and theological weight we attach to those activities.

When we celebrate election results like resurrection... when we panic at election losses like the tomb is still sealed... when we talk about legislation as if it can redeem a nation's soul... that reveals something. It reveals that we have attached hope to something that cannot carry it.

Politics was never meant to bear the weight of salvation. And when we put that weight on it, we do not merely distort politics. We distort Christ. Because now Jesus is not the Savior; He is the mascot of our national project. And that is not Christianity.

The Shape of What Follows

This book is written for people who love Jesus and are confused. It is written for pastors who feel caught between their pulpit and the political temperature of their congregation. It is written for young adults who watched their parents' faith become indistinguishable from a voting record and walked away. It is written for skeptics who suspect the church has lost its way but want to see if anyone inside

will say so honestly.

I am not writing as a political commentator. I am writing as a pastor. My concern is not which party wins. My concern is whether the church of Jesus Christ is worshiping the right God.

By the time you finish this book, my hope is that you will be able to do five things. First, recognize how fear and power can quietly rewrite doctrine. Second, learn to "relativize" politics without withdrawing from neighbor-love. Third, recover the early Christian confession—"Jesus is Lord"—as politically disruptive rather than partisan. Fourth, embrace a cross-shaped theology of power. And fifth, rebuild discipleship, conscience, and witness for a post-Christian age.

This is not a book about who to vote for. It is a book about who to worship.

And the first step toward answering that question honestly is admitting we may have gotten it wrong.

So here is the diagnostic question I want you to hold in your mind through every chapter that follows:

What do you think preserves the church?

If your honest answer involves courts, legislatures, cultural influence, or political victory more than prayer, holiness, sacrificial love, and courageous witness—then this book is for you.

Not because you are a bad person.

But because you may have been seduced.

And seduction does not announce itself. It simply rearranges your affections until the idol feels indistinguishable from the God.

Key Takeaways

- The primary threat to American Christianity is not persecution but seduction—the quiet relocation of trust from God to political power.
- The Hebrew word *zanah* describes not atheism but spiritual

adultery: keeping God while making something else ultimate. • Seduction is more dangerous than persecution because it does not require you to stop believing—only to start supplementing. • First-century Israel rejected Jesus not because they hated God but because He was not the kind of Messiah they wanted—sovereignty without surrender, power without a cross. • Augustine relativized the earthly city without dismissing it; the church has always engaged power while refusing to worship it. • The diagnostic question for every believer is not "Are you political?" but "Where is your ultimate trust?" • Fear is the accelerant that turns legitimate political engagement into functional idolatry. • This book is not a call to political withdrawal but to theological honesty about what we actually worship when we are afraid.

Reflection Questions

1\ When was the last time a political loss felt like a spiritual crisis to you? What does that reveal about where your hope is placed? 2\ Can you name a moment when fear—not conviction—drove your political engagement? 3\ If you could not vote, could not lobby, and had no political influence, what would your faith look like? Would anything essential change? 4\ Who or what do you functionally trust to preserve the church in America? 5\ How would your emotional life change if you genuinely believed that no election could threaten the Kingdom of God? 6\ Do you find it easier to talk about your political views or your prayer life? What does the imbalance reveal?

Practices

- Personal: Spend one week reading the news without forming an opinion about what God "needs" to happen. Simply pray: "Lord, You are sovereign." Notice what feelings arise.
- Personal: Write down your three deepest fears about America's future. Then ask: "Does the gospel address these fears, or do I need politics to address them?"
- Family: At your next family meal, ask each person: "What do you think is the biggest threat to the church?" Listen without correcting. Notice what assumptions emerge.
- Church: Ask your pastor or small group leader: "How do we talk about politics in a way that demonstrates that Jesus—not any party—is our ultimate hope?"

Sources & Notes

Hosea 2; 8:9—The prophetic accusation of Israel's spiritual adultery (zanah) and her "hired lovers." Psalm 20:7—The trust contrast between chariots and the name of the Lord. Matthew 4:8–10—Satan's temptation of political power offered to Jesus in the wilderness. Augustine, *The City of God*, especially Books XIV–XIX—On the two cities and the relativization of earthly power. Tim Keller, *Counterfeit Gods* (Dutton, 2009)—On how good things become ultimate things and the nature of functional idolatry. John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, I.xi.8—The human heart as a "perpetual factory of idols." Abraham Kuyper, *Lectures on Calvinism* (1898)—"Every square inch" and the scope of Christ's lordship over public life. Os Guinness, *The Last Christian on Earth* (Regal, 2010)—On the church's vulnerability to cultural seduction rather than overt persecution.

CHAPTER ONE

Zanah: When You Keep the Vows and Give Away the Heart

"Israel did not stop believing in God. They simply stopped believing He was enough."

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The Language God Chose

Of all the metaphors God could have used to describe Israel's unfaithfulness, He chose the most intimate and devastating one available: marriage.

Not contract law. Not military desertion. Not commercial fraud. Marriage.

The entire book of Hosea is structured around this metaphor. God tells the prophet Hosea to marry a woman named Gomer—a woman who will be unfaithful to him—as a living parable of what Israel has done to God. The relationship between Hosea and Gomer becomes a prophetic mirror of the relationship between Yahweh and His people. Every act of adultery, every wandering, every return—it is all there, written in the flesh of a real marriage so that Israel cannot look away.

What makes this metaphor so searing is what it implies about the nature of the betrayal. A business partner who breaks a contract is frustrating. A soldier who deserts the army is dangerous. But a spouse who sleeps with someone else while still coming home for dinner, while still saying "I love you," while still occupying the same house and sharing the same table—that is a particular kind of devastation.

It is the devastation of closeness without faithfulness. Of presence without loyalty. Of saying the right words while your heart belongs somewhere else.

That is zanah.

The Hebrew word appears dozens of times in the prophetic literature, and it is almost always translated with sexual language: "playing the whore," "prostituting oneself," "committing adultery." The prophets are not being crude for shock value. They are being precise. They are saying that what Israel has done to Yahweh is not casual negligence or mild forgetfulness. It is relational betrayal of the most intimate kind—the kind that can only happen between two parties who are supposed to be bound to each other in exclusive, covenant love.

And this is the word—not a political term, not a policy label, not an academic category—that best describes what is happening in parts of the American church today. Not atheism. Not apostasy in the classical sense of walking away from the faith entirely. But a quiet, respectable, fear-driven relocation of the heart's deepest trust from God to political power.

The vows are still spoken. The heart has moved.

What Zanah Is Not

This is where we need to slow down, because most people—including most churchgoers—assume that the opposite of faithfulness is atheism. If you are unfaithful to God, you must have stopped believing in Him. If you have wandered from the Lord, you must have rejected His existence. The assumption is that spiritual betrayal looks like a conscious decision to walk out the door, slam it shut, and never come back.

But zanah is not atheism.

It is not the abandonment of faith. It is the supplementation of faith.

Israel kept worshiping. They kept the temple open. They kept the festivals on the calendar. They kept the prayers in their mouths. They kept the language of covenant on their lips. They did not deny Yahweh. They did not tear down the altars or burn the scrolls or declare that God was dead.

They simply decided that Yahweh, by Himself, was not enough to guarantee their security.

So they added. They added alliances with Egypt. They added treaties with Assyria. They added the military resources of foreign nations. They added the gods of surrounding peoples—not because they loved those gods, not because they found those religions intellectually compelling, but because they feared their enemies. And fear always demands more insurance than faith alone provides.

Listen to how God describes this in Hosea:

"For they have gone up to Assyria, a wild donkey wandering alone; Ephraim has hired lovers. Though they hire allies among the nations, I will soon gather them up." —Hosea 8:9–10

"Hired lovers."

That phrase should arrest us. God is not describing a nation that has abandoned religion. He is describing a nation that has kept religion while simultaneously pursuing security through political alliances. The temple is still open. The sacrifices continue. The priests are still employed. But the trust—the deep, functional, emotional trust that determines how a people actually live—has shifted.

Israel has not divorced Yahweh. Israel has brought another partner into the covenant bed and called it "strategy."

This is the anatomy of *zanah*: you do not throw God away. You simply add insurance. You do not deny the covenant. You supplement it. You do not leave the marriage. You bring someone else into the bed and tell yourself it is for the good of the family.

And God's response is not indifference. It is not theological detachment. It is the white-hot grief of a betrayed spouse who has given everything and watched it treated as insufficient.

Why Prophets Use Marital Language

The covenant between God and Israel was not a business arrangement. It was not a political contract with terms and penalties, like a treaty between two nations of equal standing. It was a personal bond patterned on the most intimate human relationship available—marriage. When God brought Israel out of Egypt, He did not merely free a labor force. He wed a bride.

Jeremiah captures this with heartbreaking beauty:

"I remember the devotion of your youth, your love as a bride, how you followed me in the wilderness, in a land not sown." —Jeremiah 2:2

God remembers the early days—when Israel trusted Him in the desert with nothing. No armies. No treaties. No chariots. No backup plan. Just manna falling from the sky each morning and a pillar of cloud leading through the wilderness. That was the honeymoon.

And it was beautiful. Not because the desert was comfortable, but because the dependence was total. Israel had no one to lean on but God, and God proved sufficient. Every time. The water came from the rock. The bread came from heaven. The enemies were defeated not by superior military strategy but by divine intervention. Israel learned, in those early years, what it meant to have God as their only security. And they thrived.

And then came the land.

And with the land came prosperity. And with prosperity came options. And with options came the quiet, reasonable, gradual migration of trust from the God who provided to the means by which provision came. The harvests were bountiful, so they began to credit the soil instead of the Sower. The borders were secure, so they began

to trust the walls instead of the Wall-Builder. The economy was stable, so they began to rely on trade networks instead of the Provider who made trade possible.

It is the oldest spiritual pattern in the world. Dependence breeds intimacy. Prosperity breeds independence. Independence breeds forgetfulness. And forgetfulness breeds betrayal.

Deuteronomy 8 warned about this pattern with almost eerie precision:

"Take care lest you forget the Lord your God... lest, when you have eaten and are full and have built good houses and live in them, and when your herds and flocks multiply and your silver and gold is multiplied... then your heart be lifted up, and you forget the Lord your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt." — Deuteronomy 8:11–14

The warning is not against prosperity itself. It is against the spiritual amnesia that prosperity produces. When life is comfortable, we forget who made it so. When the chariots are plentiful, we forget who we used to cry out to when we had none.

The prophets use marital language because nothing else captures the offense. This is not a policy dispute between a government and its advisor. This is a God who created, rescued, sustained, fed, defended, and covenanted with a people—only to watch them hand their security to another while still singing His worship songs on Saturday morning.

That is not a doctrinal error. That is heartbreak. And the marital metaphor is the only container large enough to hold the grief.

Translate to Today: Jesus Plus the Strongman

Now here is where this stops being ancient history and starts being an examination of the American church.

What does zanah look like in twenty-first-century Christianity?

It looks like a church that still preaches the gospel on Sunday but spends the rest of the week convinced that political power is what will actually preserve the faith. It looks like believers who pray fervently but whose emotional stability rises and falls not with their relationship with God but with their party's electoral prospects. It looks like a Christianity that claims Jesus is Lord but acts as if the nation's future depends on the right president occupying the right office at the right time.

It looks like Jesus plus the strongman.

This is not a caricature. I have sat in rooms with sincere, Bible-believing Christians who speak about political leaders with a reverence and desperation that they do not bring to prayer meetings. I have watched congregations weep over election results with more visible emotion than they show during communion. I have heard pastors describe political losses as though the tomb were still sealed—as though Christ had not risen, as though the Spirit had not been poured out, as though the gates of hell had somehow prevailed.

I have watched Christian social media accounts erupt with praise for a political figure using language that should be reserved for the Messiah: "Sent by God." "Chosen for this moment." "Our only hope." "The one who will save us."

None of these people would say they worship a politician. That is the whole point.

Zanah does not require conscious idolatry. It only requires relocated trust. It only requires that something besides God becomes the thing you cannot imagine living without. It does not require a formal declaration of apostasy. It only requires that your functional hope—the thing that actually governs your emotions, your decisions, your fears, and your sense of security—has quietly migrated from the throne of Christ to the platform of a political movement.

Ask yourself: When you think about the future of the church in America, what comes to mind first? Is it the sovereignty of God, the

power of the Holy Spirit, the faithfulness of Christ to build His church? Or is it the next election, the composition of the Supreme Court, the outcome of a culture war, the legislative agenda of your preferred party?

I am not asking whether those political realities matter. They do. Policies have consequences. Laws shape cultures. Justice requires engagement.

I am asking which one is ultimate in your emotional life.

Because whatever is ultimate in your emotional life is functionally your god.

And if that god is anything other than Jesus—if the thing you cannot imagine living without, the thing whose loss would devastate you beyond recovery, the thing that occupies the center of your hope—is a political outcome rather than the risen Christ, then you have not necessarily abandoned the faith.

You may have committed *zanah*.

And you may not even know it yet. Because the whole point of *zanah* is that it happens while you are still going to church.

Answering the Objection: "Isn't This Judging Motives?"

At this point, someone will push back: "You cannot see my heart. You do not know why I care about politics. You do not know whether my concern is idolatrous or simply responsible. Stop judging my motives."

That is a fair instinct. And Jesus does warn against reckless, hypocritical judgment. He tells us to take the log out of our own eye before examining the speck in someone else's.

But Jesus also says, "By their fruits you will know them" (Matthew 7:20). And the prophets did not hesitate to name *zanah* when they saw it—not because they could read hearts with omniscient precision, but because the behavioral evidence was

overwhelming. You do not need to be omniscient to notice when a marriage is in trouble. The signs are visible to anyone willing to look.

When a person says they trust God but panics at every political development, that is evidence.

When a church preaches grace but excuses cruelty in leaders because those leaders protect Christian interests, that is evidence.

When believers cannot distinguish between a threat to their nation and a threat to their faith, that is evidence.

When the emotional temperature of a congregation is set not by the preaching of Scripture but by the latest political headline, that is evidence.

When Christians can tolerate almost any moral failure in a leader as long as that leader delivers the right policy outcomes, that is evidence.

I am not claiming the ability to read anyone's heart. I am saying that the prophetic tradition—the tradition of Hosea, Jeremiah, Isaiah, and Ezekiel—gives us the categories to name what we see. And what we see, in too many corners of the American church, looks remarkably like what Hosea described: a people who keep the worship and give away the trust.

The question is not "Are you political?"

The question is: "When you are afraid, where do you run first?"

If the honest answer is not "to God," then something has shifted. And the first step toward repentance is admitting the shift has happened.

How to Spot Relocated Trust in Your Emotional Reactions

Idolatry is notoriously difficult to detect in yourself because it always feels rational. No one thinks they are worshiping an idol. They think they are being realistic. Responsible. Wise. Strategic. The idol never introduces itself as an idol. It introduces itself as the

obvious and necessary thing to do given the circumstances.

But there are diagnostic markers—not designed to condemn, but to invite honest self-examination. Consider these carefully:

Your emotional stability tracks with political outcomes more than spiritual disciplines. If an election result can ruin your week but a missed prayer time barely registers, something has shifted. If you spend more time reading political commentary than reading Scripture, and if the commentary produces more emotion in you than the Scripture does, your heart is telling you where your functional trust resides.

You defend behavior in your preferred leaders that you would condemn in your opponents. This is perhaps the most visible symptom of *zanah* in American Christianity. It is the moral double standard that reveals tribal loyalty has replaced principled conviction. When your side's leader lies, it is "strategy." When the other side's leader lies, it is "corruption." When your side's leader is cruel, it is "strength." When the other side's leader is cruel, it is "tyranny." This inconsistency is not merely hypocrisy. It is the fruit of idolatry. When the idol is your tribe, you will protect the tribe's representatives regardless of their character, because the idol demands protection.

You cannot imagine the church thriving without political power. If the thought of Christianity without cultural influence, legal privilege, or political access fills you with dread rather than historical awareness—the early church had none of those things and turned the world upside down—you have attached the church's survival to something other than Christ. The church was born in a manger, grew under persecution, and conquered the Roman Empire not through political control but through the power of a resurrection. If you have forgotten that, political power has replaced the Holy Spirit as your functional source of confidence.

You treat criticism of your political position as an attack on your faith. When political allegiance and spiritual identity become fused, any critique of the former feels like blasphemy against the latter. If

someone can question your preferred candidate and you experience it as an assault on the gospel, the fusion has already happened. Your politics and your faith have become so entangled that you can no longer tell where one ends and the other begins.

You use apocalyptic language for political events. If every election is "the most important in history," if every cultural shift is "the end of Christianity," if every political opponent is "evil" in an ontological rather than moral sense—the eschatological temperature of your language reveals that politics has become your horizon of hope. When the next election feels more decisive than the return of Christ, your eschatology has been quietly rewritten by your political commitments.

Your prayer life has been colonized by political anxiety. If most of your prayers are about elections, policies, and political enemies rather than about your own sanctification, the needs of your neighbor, and the advance of the gospel—your anxiety has reshaped your communion with God. Prayer has become a form of political lobbying directed at heaven rather than an act of surrender to the God who is sovereign over all nations.

None of these markers are unforgivable. All of them are diagnostic. And they all point to the same underlying condition: trust has been relocated from God to a political project, and the relocation happened so gradually that it felt like faithfulness.

That is the genius of seduction. It does not come as a stranger knocking at the door with a competing religion. It comes dressed as wisdom, wrapped in urgency, and speaking the language of responsibility. It says, "Of course you still believe in God. But be practical."

And "be practical" is the phrase that has undone more spiritual faithfulness than any atheist argument ever conceived.

The God Who Runs Toward the Unfaithful

But here is where the story turns. Because if Hosea only

contained accusation, it would be unbearable. If it were only diagnosis without remedy, it would drive us to despair. But Hosea does not end with the accusation of adultery.

It ends with the most extraordinary invitation in the Old Testament.

After all the indictments—after the graphic language of betrayal, after the exposure of every alliance and every false lover, after the naming of every idol and every misplaced trust—God does something that no one in the ancient world would have expected a betrayed spouse to do.

He asks them to come home.

"Return, O Israel, to the Lord your God, for you have stumbled because of your iniquity. Take with you words and return to the Lord; say to him, 'Take away all iniquity; accept what is good, and we will pay with bulls the vows of our lips. Assyria shall not save us; we will not ride on horses; and we will say no more, 'Our God,' to the work of our hands. In you the orphan finds mercy.'" —Hosea 14:1–3

Read that repentance carefully. Notice its structure.

First: "Take away all iniquity." This is a confession that the problem is real. Not exaggerated. Not merely a matter of perception. Real iniquity—real unfaithfulness—that requires real forgiveness.

Second: "Assyria shall not save us." This is the renunciation of the false savior. It is the explicit naming of the political alliance that had functioned as a substitute for God's protection. It is Israel saying, out loud, what they had been refusing to admit: "We looked to Assyria for what only You can provide."

Third: "We will not ride on horses." This is the renunciation of military self-sufficiency. It is the admission that the chariots and horses—the instruments of political and military power—had become objects of trust rather than tools of stewardship.

Fourth: "We will say no more, 'Our God,' to the work of our

hands." This is the deepest level of repentance. It is the admission that the things they had built—the alliances, the systems, the structures of human power—had been elevated to divine status in their hearts. They had called the idol "God." And now they are refusing to do so any longer.

That is the repentance this book calls for. Not withdrawal from public life. Not cynical disengagement. Not the abandonment of civic responsibility. But the radical, uncomfortable, soul-level honesty of admitting that we have given our hearts to something other than God—and the courageous act of taking them back.

And look at how God responds:

"I will heal their apostasy; I will love them freely, for my anger has turned from them. I will be like the dew to Israel; he shall blossom like the lily; he shall take root like the trees of Lebanon." — Hosea 14:4–5

"I will heal their apostasy." Not "I will punish their apostasy." Not "I will reluctantly tolerate their return." Heal. The word is restorative. It implies that the unfaithfulness was a wound—a wound in the soul of Israel and a wound in the heart of God—and that God's response to the returning spouse is not grudging acceptance but extravagant healing.

"I will love them freely." The Hebrew word translated "freely" carries the sense of generosity, spontaneity, and abundance. God's love for the returning unfaithful is not measured, not cautious, not conditioned on a probationary period. It is free. Lavish. Unreserved.

This is the gospel before the gospel had a name.

This is a God who watches His bride walk away, names the betrayal with devastating honesty, and then—when the bride turns around—runs toward her.

If that sounds familiar, it should. It is the same God who, centuries later, told a story about a father who saw his prodigal son

coming from a long way off and ran to meet him (Luke 15:20). It is the same God who, on a cross, looked at the people who had nailed Him there and said, "Father, forgive them" (Luke 23:34). It is the same God who, in the risen Christ, appeared to Peter—the disciple who had denied Him three times—and said not "Explain yourself" but "Do you love me?" (John 21:15–17).

The God of Hosea is not a God who waits at the end of a long road of self-improvement for His people to earn their way back. He is a God who meets them in their mess, heals what is broken, and loves them back to life.

That is the God we are called to return to. Not a taskmaster. Not a cold judge. Not a distant sovereign. A jealous Lover who refuses to share His bride but who will not stop pursuing her even when she wanders.

The Way Back Begins Here

The way back begins with naming the idol.

And the idol's name is not "politics." Politics is not the problem. The idol's name is relocated trust. The idol is whatever you cannot imagine living without that is not God. It is the thing that, if taken away, would cause your faith to collapse—because your faith was secretly resting on it rather than on Christ.

For some of us, the idol is a political party. For some, it is a political leader. For some, it is the cultural influence of Christianity. For some, it is the comfort of being in the majority. For some, it is the sense that "our country" and "our faith" are the same thing. For some, it is the feeling of power itself—the intoxicating sensation that we are in control, that we can shape the future, that we can win.

Name it. Be specific. Do not generalize. Do not say, "I trust God too much in politics"—that is too vague to repent of. Say what it actually is. Say, "I have treated this leader as if he were anointed by God in a way that no politician is." Say, "I have attached the survival of my faith to the survival of my political party." Say, "I have been

more afraid of losing an election than I am of losing my integrity."

Name it. Confess it. And return.

Because the God of Hosea is waiting. Not with folded arms and a lecture. With open arms and a feast.

And the road home is shorter than you think.

It begins with one sentence:

"Assyria shall not save us."

Whatever your Assyria is—name it. Lay it down. And come home.

Because the God who named the adultery is the same God who heals it. And He is not finished with you. He is not finished with the American church. And He has no intention of sharing His bride with a political idol—no matter how respectable that idol may appear.

Key Takeaways

- Zannah is not atheism—it is spiritual adultery: keeping God while relocating trust to something else. The vows remain; the heart has moved.
- God chose marital language because the covenant is intimate, personal, and exclusive—and betrayal within intimacy is the deepest wound.
- Israel did not stop worshipping; they supplemented worship with political alliances driven by fear. They "hired lovers" while keeping the temple open.
- The oldest spiritual pattern is: dependence breeds intimacy, prosperity breeds independence, independence breeds forgetfulness, forgetfulness breeds betrayal.
- Modern zannah looks like Christians who claim Jesus is Lord but whose emotional stability, moral standards, and deepest hopes are functionally attached to political outcomes.
- The diagnostic question is not "Are you political?" but "When you are afraid, where do you run first?"
- Biblical repentance from zannah is not withdrawal from public life but the explicit renunciation of political trust as ultimate: "Assyria shall not save us."
- The God who accuses Israel of adultery is the same God who invites them home—and promises to heal their apostasy freely, lavishly, and without condition.

Reflection Questions

1\ In what areas of your life do you keep the language of faith while functionally trusting something else for your security? 2\ When political events go badly for your preferred side, does your emotional response look more like disappointment or despair? What does the intensity reveal about where your hope is actually placed? 3\ Can you think of a specific time when fear—not conviction, not principle, not love of neighbor—drove you to defend a political position or leader you might otherwise have questioned? 4\ What would it look like for you to say, with Hosea 14, "Assyria shall not save us"? What is your specific "Assyria"—the political reality you have functionally trusted to do what only God can do? 5\ How might the church's public witness change if believers genuinely believed that Jesus—not political power—preserves the church? 6\ Which of the diagnostic markers in this chapter do you recognize in yourself? What would it look like to begin addressing them honestly?

Practices

- Personal: This week, before reading any political news, spend five minutes in prayer asking God to be your first source of security. Notice how this changes your emotional reaction to the headlines.
- Personal: Write a letter to God—not a prayer, a letter—confessing the specific ways you have supplemented your trust in Him with political trust. Be honest. Be detailed. Do not spiritualize it.
- Family: Read Hosea 14:1–5 aloud together and discuss: What are the "chariots" and "Assyrias" our family tends to trust instead of God? How does fear shape our family's relationship with politics?
- Church: Invite your small group or Sunday school class to discuss one question: "What does relocated trust look like in our congregation, and how would we know if it were happening to us?"

Sources & Notes

Hosea 1–3—The prophetic marriage of Hosea and Gomer as a parable of God's relationship with Israel. Hosea 8:9–10—"Ephraim has hired lovers"—the accusation of political alliances as spiritual adultery. Hosea 14:1–5—The invitation to return and the promise of

free, healing love. Jeremiah 2:1–13—God's memory of Israel's early faithfulness contrasted with present betrayal. Deuteronomy 8:11–18—The warning against forgetting God in prosperity. James 4:4—"You adulterous people! Do you not know that friendship with the world is enmity with God?" Tim Keller, *Counterfeit Gods* (Dutton, 2009)—Foundational work on how good things become ultimate things. John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, I.xi.8—The human mind as a "perpetual factory of idols." G. K. Beale, *We Become What We Worship* (IVP Academic, 2008)—On how idolatry reshapes the worshiper into the image of what they worship.

CHAPTER TWO

Chariots Aren't Evil—But They Aren't Ultimate

"When legitimate goods become ultimate goods, they become idols."

'&

The Good Gift That Becomes a God Substitute

Every idol begins as a gift.

This is the thing most people miss about idolatry, and it is the reason the Bible's warnings about it are so persistently ignored. We imagine idols as obviously evil things—golden calves, pagan statues, demonic rituals. We picture idolatry as something primitive and absurd, something no sophisticated modern person would fall into. And because we picture it that way, we never see it coming.

But the most dangerous idols are not evil things. They are good things that have been inflated beyond their design capacity.

Money is a gift. It provides for families, funds ministries, builds hospitals, feeds the hungry. Sex is a gift. It binds marriages, produces new life, expresses the deepest human intimacy. Work is a gift. It cultivates creation, serves neighbors, exercises the stewardship mandate that God gave humanity in the garden. Family is a gift. Friendship is a gift. Health is a gift. Even politics—the ordering of common life for the common good—is a gift from the God who cares about justice, order, and human flourishing.

None of these things are evil. All of them become destructive when they are treated as ultimate.

Tim Keller articulated this pattern with a clarity that has shaped a

generation of theological thinking. In *Counterfeit Gods*, he argued that an idol is not typically a bad thing. It is a good thing that has been made into an ultimate thing. It is a gift that has been promoted to a position that only the Giver should occupy. When a good thing becomes a god thing, it becomes a destructive thing—not because its nature has changed, but because its position has.

John Calvin said it first, and more bluntly: the human heart is a perpetual factory of idols. We do not need pagan temples to manufacture false gods. We carry the factory with us. And the raw material we use is almost always something good—something God gave us to enjoy, to steward, to use in His service—that we have quietly, imperceptibly, desperately elevated to the place where only God belongs.

This distinction matters enormously when we talk about politics.

Because the moment someone raises concerns about the church's relationship to political power, the instinctive response is: "Are you saying politics is evil? Are you saying Christians shouldn't be involved? Are you saying we should just let the world burn?"

No.

I am saying that political engagement is a good gift. Voting is a good gift. Advocacy, legislation, civic participation, the pursuit of justice through governmental structures—these are legitimate and even necessary expressions of neighbor-love. A Christian who ignores politics is not holier than one who engages; in many cases, they are simply less compassionate. The Samaritan did not walk past the beaten man and call it "spiritual detachment." He got involved. He spent money. He used the systems available to him to help.

The question has never been whether Christians should engage politically.

The question is what weight that engagement carries in the life of the soul.

And that question—the question of weight—is where everything turns.

The Biblical Architecture: Psalm 20 and the Trust Distinction

Psalm 20 is a royal psalm—a prayer offered for the king of Israel as he prepares for battle. It is not a pacifist text. It does not condemn military action. It does not pretend that warfare is irrelevant or that national defense is unspiritual. It takes seriously the reality that kings go to war, that nations face enemies, and that the survival of a people sometimes depends on the courage and competence of its leaders.

But in the middle of this very practical, very political prayer, the psalmist draws a line that echoes through the rest of Scripture:

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the Lord our God. They collapse and fall, but we rise and stand upright." —Psalm 20:7–8

This verse is one of the most important sentences in the Old Testament for understanding the relationship between faith and politics. And it is important precisely because of what it does not say.

It does not say, "Chariots are evil." It does not say, "Only fools use horses." It does not condemn military preparedness as inherently faithless or suggest that Israel should disband its army and wait for miraculous intervention. The psalm is being prayed for a king who is about to fight. The psalmist is not naive about the realities of power.

What the psalmist does is draw a distinction between using and trusting. Chariots can be used. Horses can be ridden. Military resources can be deployed. Political structures can be engaged. But none of these things can be trusted—not in the way that God is trusted, not as the foundation of hope, not as the thing that in the end determines whether you stand or fall.

That distinction—between use and trust, between engagement and dependence, between the tool and the savior—is the theological key to this entire book.

You can use political structures without trusting them. You can vote without worshipping the outcome. You can advocate for justice without believing that justice depends entirely on your advocacy succeeding. You can engage the political process with passion, intelligence, and conviction without making the political process the foundation of your hope.

But the moment you cross from engagement to dependence—from using the chariot to trusting the chariot, from participating in politics to being emotionally sustained by politics—something has shifted in your soul. And that shift is precisely what the psalmist warns against.

Because notice how the verse ends: "They collapse and fall, but we rise and stand upright." The people who trust chariots eventually discover that chariots are not ultimate. Chariots break. Horses stumble. Armies lose. Political movements fail. Every human structure eventually proves insufficient. And when it does, the people who built their hope on it collapse with it.

But the people who trusted in the name of the Lord? They stand. Not because they were passive. Not because they did nothing. But because their standing was never dependent on the chariot in the first place.

That is the freedom the gospel offers to politically engaged Christians: you can participate fully without being destroyed by the outcome. You can care deeply without being consumed. You can engage the process without being defined by the results.

But that freedom is only available to people who have made the trust distinction. And making the trust distinction requires a kind of spiritual honesty that most of us find deeply uncomfortable.

Isaiah's Warning: The Egyptian Alliance

Isaiah 31 provides an even more pointed illustration of the trust distinction—and one that carries a devastating irony.

The historical situation is this: the kingdom of Judah faces military threat from Assyria, the superpower of the north. Assyria has already conquered the northern kingdom of Israel. Judah is next. The political establishment in Jerusalem, understandably terrified, wants to form a military alliance with Egypt—the superpower of the south. It is a classic balance-of-power strategy. Egypt has chariots. Egypt has a massive, professional army. Egypt can provide the military counterweight that tiny Judah cannot muster on its own.

From a purely strategic perspective, the alliance makes sense. It is the kind of decision any reasonable political advisor would recommend. It is pragmatic, realistic, and "responsible."

And God condemns it.

"Woe to those who go down to Egypt for help and rely on horses, who trust in chariots because they are many and in horsemen because they are very strong, but do not look to the Holy One of Israel or consult the Lord!" —Isaiah 31:1

The accusation is specific: they "do not look to the Holy One of Israel or consult the Lord." The problem is not that Egypt exists. The problem is not that military alliances are available. The problem is the direction of the gaze. The posture of the heart. The location of trust.

Judah has not consulted God. They have not prayed. They have not sought divine guidance. They have assessed the political situation with their own wisdom, identified the most powerful ally available, and made their decision based on calculation rather than faith. They have looked at the problem with entirely human eyes and reached an entirely human conclusion.

And there is a devastating irony in this particular text that we must not miss.

Egypt is where Israel was enslaved.

Egypt is where God demonstrated His power to save—through

plagues, through the parting of the sea, through the destruction of Pharaoh's army. Egypt is where the chariots of the most powerful nation on earth were drowned in the waters of the Red Sea while Israel walked through on dry ground.

And now, generations later, Israel is running back to Egypt's chariots for protection.

They have forgotten the Exodus. They have forgotten what God did. They have forgotten who saved them from the very power they are now running to for help.

Does that pattern sound familiar?

The American church was forged in a tradition that insisted on the sufficiency of Christ, the power of the Holy Spirit, and the sovereignty of God over nations. The great revivals that shaped American Protestantism were not produced by legislative action. They were produced by prayer, preaching, and the mysterious work of the Spirit. The church grew not because it had political access but because it had spiritual authority.

And now, in our anxiety, in our fear of cultural decline and moral collapse, we are running to the very power structures we were never meant to depend on—as though God's arm is too short to save without Washington's help. As though the Spirit who raised Christ from the dead needs a congressional majority to do His work.

We have forgotten our Exodus. And we are running back to Egypt.

Fear: The Accelerant That Makes the Idol Feel Necessary

Here is the crucial pastoral insight that holds this chapter together: good things do not become ultimate things in a vacuum. The accelerant is almost always fear.

No one sits down in a quiet moment of reflection and calmly, rationally decides, "I am going to make politics my functional savior." That is not how idolatry works. Idolatry happens under pressure. It happens in the dark. It happens when the ground shifts

beneath you and everything you value feels like it is under threat. It happens when you watch the news and your stomach tightens and your thoughts race and your blood pressure spikes and you think, with every fiber of your being, "Something has to be done."

That phrase—"something has to be done"—is not wrong in itself. Christians should respond to injustice, should act in the face of evil, should work for the good of their neighbors and communities. The instinct to act is a gift from God.

But fear corrupts the instinct. Fear takes the legitimate desire to act and transforms it into a desperate need to control. Fear says not merely "something should be done" but "everything depends on what we do next." Fear removes God from the equation and puts the entire weight of the future on human shoulders—specifically, on the shoulders of whoever promises to carry it.

Fear does not patiently reason its way to conclusions. Fear does not wait for careful theological reflection. Fear does not pause to ask, "What does Scripture say about this?" or "What does the history of the church teach us about moments like this?" Fear reads one headline and reorganizes the soul. It takes the hierarchy of your affections—God first, then everything else in its proper order—and scrambles it in an instant.

And once fear has reorganized the soul, the idol does not feel like an idol. It feels like the only reasonable option.

This is why fear-driven Christianity is so spiritually dangerous. Not because the fears are always irrational—some of them are legitimate. Moral decline is real. Cultural hostility to Christianity is real. Legal threats to religious liberty are real. The erosion of institutions that once supported family life, community cohesion, and moral formation is real.

But fear bypasses the spiritual discernment that would normally prevent a good thing from becoming an ultimate thing. Under normal circumstances, a healthy Christian can distinguish between caring

about an election and worshipping the outcome. But when fear enters the picture—when the stakes feel existential, when the threat feels total, when the enemy feels overwhelming—that distinction collapses.

When you are afraid, your threshold for idolatry drops dramatically. Suddenly the chariot does not look like a useful tool. It looks like the only thing standing between you and destruction. And once something feels like the only thing standing between you and destruction, it has become your functional savior—whether you call it that or not.

That is how political engagement crosses the line into political idolatry. Not through a conscious decision to worship power. Not through an explicit renunciation of faith. But through the gradual, fear-driven elevation of political outcomes into objects of ultimate concern—so that winning feels like salvation and losing feels like damnation.

And the terrifying thing is that the whole process feels responsible. It feels like stewardship. It feels like "being realistic." It feels like what any good Christian parent, any good pastor, any good citizen would do.

Fear always makes the idol feel necessary. That is its most powerful trick.

1 Samuel 8: When Israel Wanted a King Like the Nations

The pattern we are describing is older than Hosea. It is older than Isaiah. It goes back to one of the most instructive and haunting passages in the entire Old Testament: the moment when the people of Israel demanded a king.

The context matters. Samuel, the last and greatest of the judges, is aging. His sons, Joel and Abijah, have been appointed as judges after him, but they are corrupt—taking bribes, perverting justice, failing to walk in their father's ways. Meanwhile, the Philistines remain a constant military threat. The nation feels vulnerable, leaderless, and afraid.

And so the elders of Israel come to Samuel with a request that carries the weight of a theological revolution:

"Appoint for us a king to judge us like all the nations." —1 Samuel 8:5

"Like all the nations."

That phrase is the key to understanding everything that follows. Israel was not meant to be like the nations. Israel was meant to be set apart—a people whose king was invisible, whose protector was divine, whose security came not from military might or political institutions but from the covenant faithfulness of God Himself. Their distinctiveness—their strangeness, their refusal to organize themselves the way other nations did—was supposed to be their witness to the world that there was a God who could be trusted.

And now they want to be like everyone else. They want a visible king. A human protector. A leader they can see, touch, follow, and point to when the Philistines come.

Samuel is distressed. He prays. And God's response is stunning:

"Obey the voice of the people in all that they say to you, for they have not rejected you, but they have rejected me from being king over them. According to all the deeds that they have done, from the day I brought them up out of Egypt even to this day, forsaking me and serving other gods, so they are also doing to you." —1 Samuel 8:7–8

Notice: God does not say the request is merely pragmatically unwise. He does not say, "This is a bad political strategy." He says it is a spiritual rejection. The desire for a visible, powerful, human protector—even if that protector is imperfect, even if the request is driven by legitimate fear of legitimate enemies—is itself a rejection of God's invisible kingship.

This is extraordinary. Israel is not asking for a pagan deity. They are not building a golden calf. They are asking for a political institution—a monarchy, like the other nations have. And God

identifies this request as idolatry. Not because monarchy is inherently evil—God will later establish the Davidic monarchy and call it a covenant blessing. But because the motivation behind the request is fear-driven replacement of divine trust with human security.

God tells Samuel to warn them. And the warning is detailed and devastating:

"These will be the ways of the king who will reign over you: he will take your sons and appoint them to his chariots and to be his horsemen... He will take your daughters to be perfumers and cooks and bakers. He will take the best of your fields and vineyards and olive orchards... He will take the tenth of your flocks, and you shall be his slaves." —1 Samuel 8:11–17

The king they are demanding will take. Their sons. Their daughters. Their land. Their wealth. Their freedom. The protector will become the predator. The savior will become the enslaver. The power they trust will eventually consume them.

And then the most devastating line of all:

"And in that day you will cry out because of your king, whom you have chosen for yourselves, but the Lord will not answer you in that day." —1 Samuel 8:18

God grants the request. He gives them Saul. And the experiment unfolds exactly as warned. Saul is tall, impressive, initially successful—and in the end a disaster. He is consumed by jealousy, paranoia, and disobedience. He consults a medium instead of God. He sacrifices what is sacred for what is expedient. He becomes everything God said a fear-chosen king would become.

The pattern is consistent throughout Scripture, and it should terrify every American Christian who has ever thought, "If we just get the right person in office, everything will be okay."

When God's people demand political power as their security, God sometimes gives it to them—not as a blessing, but as a judgment. He

lets them have what they asked for. And what they asked for eventually devours them.

That should make us pause. Not because political participation is wrong. But because the spirit in which we pursue political solutions—the fear, the desperation, the sense that everything depends on this leader or this election—may reveal that we have already made the request Israel made. And God may already be granting it.

Answering the Objection: "Are You Saying Christians Shouldn't Be Involved?"

Let me be as clear as I can, because this objection is the most common one I hear, and it deserves a thorough and honest answer.

No. I am not saying Christians should withdraw from political life.

Christianity has never been a quietist religion. The claim that Christians should retreat from public engagement is neither historically accurate nor biblically supported. It is, in fact, a failure of love. If you see injustice and do nothing because you are worried about "mixing faith and politics," you have not achieved spiritual purity. You have abandoned your neighbor.

Abraham Kuyper, the Dutch Reformed theologian who also served as prime minister of the Netherlands, insisted that Christ lays claim to every square inch of existence—including politics. Kuyper saw no conflict between serious Christian conviction and vigorous political participation. He believed that precisely because Jesus is Lord, Christians have a responsibility to bring the implications of that lordship into every sphere of public life.

Augustine engaged the political philosophy of his day at the highest intellectual level. His *City of God* is not a call to political disengagement. It is a massive, sophisticated work of political theology that insists earthly politics matters—while simultaneously insisting that it is not ultimate. Augustine did not withdraw from Rome. He engaged Rome while relativizing Rome.

Calvin worked to shape civic structures in Geneva. The Reformers did not hide in monasteries and wait for the Second Coming. They built schools, shaped laws, reformed institutions, and insisted that the gospel had public implications.

So the question has never been whether Christians should be involved in politics. The historical and theological consensus is clear: they should.

But—and this is where the conversation must become painfully, uncomfortably honest—none of those great theologians made political power the functional center of their hope.

Kuyper did not believe the church's survival depended on his political success. When his party lost elections, he did not treat it as a crisis of faith. Augustine did not panic when Rome fell. He wrote *The City of God* specifically to argue that the fall of an earthly empire is not the fall of the Kingdom of God. Calvin did not treat Geneva's government as the guarantor of the gospel. He knew the gospel would outlast Geneva.

They engaged politics without worshiping it. They used the chariot without trusting it. They participated in civic life without making civic life ultimate. They held political convictions with deep seriousness and loose hands. They cared about outcomes without being defined by them.

That is the model. And it is a model that requires a level of spiritual maturity, theological clarity, and faith that does not require visible results to remain steady.

The question is not whether we are involved. The question is whether we can be involved without being consumed. Whether we can care about politics without making politics the load-bearing wall of our spiritual house. Whether we can use the chariot without kneeling before it.

If we can—if our engagement is driven by love rather than fear, by conviction rather than desperation, by hope in Christ rather than

hope in a candidate—then political engagement is an expression of faithfulness.

If we cannot—if every election feels like the apocalypse, if every political loss feels like a spiritual crisis, if our engagement is driven more by terror than by love of neighbor—then something has shifted. And the shift needs to be named before it can be healed.

A Good Gift / God Substitute Diagnostic

As a practical tool for discernment—something you can return to regularly, not just once—consider these diagnostic questions about any good thing in your life. They apply to money, career, relationships, reputation, and family. But for the purposes of this book, apply them specifically to your political engagement.

If this were taken away, would I lose my sense of security? Not "would I be disappointed"—that is normal. But would I feel existentially unsafe? Would my confidence in God's goodness collapse? If the loss of a political outcome would shake your faith in God, that outcome has been carrying weight that only God should carry.

Do I defend this with more passion than I defend the character of Christ? If you will argue for hours about a political leader but fall silent when Christ's name is mocked—if you will confront a coworker over a policy disagreement but not over a blasphemous joke—your passion reveals your priority.

Does this good thing require me to compromise my integrity to maintain it? This is perhaps the sharpest question. If supporting your political project requires you to excuse dishonesty, cruelty, sexual misconduct, corruption, or the dehumanization of people made in God's image—then the project has demanded a sacrifice that only an idol requires. God never asks you to sin in order to serve Him. Only idols make that demand.

Do I spend more emotional energy on this than on my relationship with God? Measure it honestly. Not in theory—in

practice. How much time this week did you spend reading political commentary? How much time in prayer? How much time arguing on social media? How much time in Scripture? The allocation of your emotional energy is the most honest map of your actual priorities.

Would I be willing to lose this for the sake of faithfulness to Jesus? This is the ultimate test. Every good thing should be held with open hands. If you could not imagine remaining faithful to Christ if your political project failed—if the thought of political loss makes following Jesus feel pointless or impossible—then the political project has replaced Christ as the non-negotiable center of your life.

Has my political engagement made me more like Jesus or less? Look at the fruit. Has your involvement in politics made you more patient, more kind, more generous, more truthful, more humble? Or has it made you angrier, more contemptuous, more tribal, more willing to dehumanize people who disagree with you? The fruit reveals the root. If your political engagement is producing the fruit of the Spirit, it is being held properly. If it is producing rage, contempt, and self-righteousness, something has gone wrong at the root level.

These questions are not designed to produce guilt. They are designed to produce clarity. And clarity—the ability to see yourself honestly, without defensiveness or rationalization—is the first gift of repentance.

Holding the Chariot Loosely

So what does it look like to engage politically without making politics ultimate? What does it look like to use the chariot without trusting it?

It looks like a Christian who votes with conviction and then sleeps well regardless of the outcome—not because they do not care, but because their security does not depend on winning.

It looks like a believer who advocates passionately for justice but does not demonize people who disagree—because they know that the image of God in their opponent is more fundamental than the policy

difference between them.

It looks like a church that engages the political process but refuses to let the political process set the emotional temperature of its worship—because the resurrection of Jesus Christ, not the latest poll numbers, determines the mood of the people of God.

It looks like a pastor who speaks prophetically about public issues but refuses to endorse candidates or align the church with a party—because the church's prophetic voice depends on its independence from every political faction.

It looks like a community of believers who can disagree politically within the same congregation without treating each other as enemies—because they know that baptism is a deeper bond than voter registration.

It looks like the early church, which paid taxes to Caesar, prayed for rulers it did not choose, served neighbors it could not control, and refused to grant any earthly power the status of Lord—because that title was taken.

This is not disengagement. It is the most engaged and most free form of political participation available. It is engagement that is liberated from fear, because the person who is not afraid of losing cannot be manipulated by the threat of loss. It is engagement that is liberated from desperation, because the person whose hope is in Christ does not need the next election to vindicate their faith.

The chariot is a useful tool. Use it well. Use it wisely. Use it in service of your neighbor and the common good.

But do not trust it. Do not worship it. Do not let anyone convince you that the chariot is what stands between you and destruction.

Because the One who stands between you and destruction is not riding a chariot. He is hanging on a cross. And three days later, He will be standing in a garden, having defeated every power that has ever claimed ultimacy—including the ones you are tempted to trust

right now.

Trust Him. And hold the chariot loosely.

Key Takeaways

- Every idol begins as a gift—not an evil thing but a good thing elevated beyond its design capacity. Political engagement is a good gift that becomes destructive only when treated as ultimate.
- The trust distinction in Psalm 20 is the theological key: you can use chariots without trusting them, engage politics without worshipping outcomes.
- Isaiah's warning about the Egyptian alliance carries a devastating irony: Israel ran back to the chariots of the very nation God had delivered them from. The American church risks the same pattern.
- Fear is the accelerant that transforms good gifts into god substitutes. Under pressure, the chariot stops looking like a tool and starts looking like the only thing between you and destruction.
- Israel's demand for a king "like the nations" was not pragmatically foolish—it was spiritually idolatrous. God identified it as a rejection of His kingship and granted it as a judgment.
- The great Christian political theologians—Kuyper, Augustine, Calvin—engaged politics vigorously without making politics the functional center of their hope. That is the model.
- The "Good Gift / God Substitute" diagnostic reveals where trust has been relocated by examining emotional stability, moral consistency, and willingness to lose.
- Holding the chariot loosely means engaging politics with conviction and freedom—free from fear, free from desperation, and free from the need to win in order to maintain faith.

Reflection Questions

- 1\ Think of a political issue you care deeply about. Is your engagement driven more by love for your neighbor or by fear of losing something you value?
- 2\ Can you name a specific time when a political outcome felt like salvation—when winning felt like resurrection and losing felt like death? What does that reveal about the weight you are placing on politics?
- 3\ Apply the "Good Gift / God Substitute" diagnostic to your political engagement. Which question is most uncomfortable? What does the discomfort reveal?
- 4\ What would change in your spiritual life if you genuinely, deeply believed that no election result could threaten the Kingdom of God?

5\ Are there political positions you hold that you have never examined theologically—positions you inherited from your tribe rather than derived from Scripture? What would it look like to examine them honestly? 6\ Has your political engagement over the past five years made you more like Jesus or less? Be specific about the evidence.

Practices

- Personal: Take the "Good Gift / God Substitute" diagnostic and apply it to your three strongest political convictions. Write down your answers. Do not rationalize. Be honest with yourself and with God.
- Personal: Fast from political media for one full week—no news, no commentary, no social media arguments. Replace the time with prayer, Scripture reading, and silence. At the end of the week, journal what you noticed about your anxiety, your peace, and your relationship with God.
- Family: At a family dinner this week, ask: "What are the good gifts in our life that might be in danger of becoming ultimate? Where have we started trusting the chariot instead of God?" Let everyone answer without judgment.
- Church: Propose a small group study, Sunday school series, or sermon series on idolatry—one that explicitly includes political idolatry on both the right and the left. If your church is unwilling to address political idolatry, ask yourself why.

Sources & Notes

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CHAPTER THREE

The Messiah You Want vs. the Messiah You Need

"They wanted a sword. He brought a towel."

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The Crowd That Tried to Make Jesus King

In the sixth chapter of John's Gospel, something extraordinary happens—something that reveals, more clearly than almost any other moment in the New Testament, the distance between what people want from God and what God actually came to do.

Jesus has just performed one of His most famous miracles. With five loaves of bread and two fish, He has fed five thousand men—plus women and children. The crowd is astonished. They have seen supernatural power on display. They have tasted provision that defies the laws of economics and agriculture. And they reach a conclusion that feels inevitable:

"When the people saw the sign that he had done, they said, 'This is indeed the Prophet who is to come into the world!'" —John 6:14

They are referencing the prophecy in Deuteronomy 18, where Moses promises that God will raise up a prophet like himself—a new liberator, a new lawgiver, a new leader who will do for Israel what Moses did. And they believe they have found Him. Here is a man with the power to feed armies, heal the sick, command nature, and—presumably—drive out the Romans and restore Israel to its former glory.

The crowd is ready to make Him king. Not metaphorically. Not in

some spiritualized, internal sense. Literally. They want to take Him by force and put Him on a throne.

And then John records one of the most startling verses in the Gospels:

"Perceiving then that they were about to come and take him by force to make him king, Jesus withdrew again to the mountain by himself." —John 6:15

Jesus ran from the crown.

Let that sink in. The crowd is offering Him exactly what any political messiah would want: popular support, enthusiastic followers, a mandate to rule. And Jesus does not accept it. He does not negotiate terms. He does not say, "Let me think about it." He withdraws. He leaves. He climbs a mountain alone.

Not because He was not a king. He was—and is—the King of Kings.

Not because He lacked authority. He possessed all authority in heaven and on earth.

But because the crowd wanted the wrong kind of king. They wanted a messiah who would use supernatural power to solve their political problems. They wanted sovereignty without surrender. Victory without repentance. A throne without a cross. National restoration without personal transformation.

And Jesus knew that if He accepted the crown on their terms, He would become exactly what the devil had offered Him in the wilderness—a ruler of earthly kingdoms who had bypassed the way of suffering, a savior who delivered political freedom while leaving the soul in bondage.

The crowd was not wrong to want a king. They were wrong about what kind of king they needed.

And that mistake—wanting the right thing in the wrong way,

wanting God's power deployed according to human expectations—is not a first-century problem. It is a perennial problem. It is our problem.

The Wilderness Temptation: The Shortcut That Never Stops Being Offered

To understand why Jesus withdrew from the crown, we need to go back to the beginning of His public ministry and the temptation in the wilderness. Because the temptation the crowd is offering in John 6 is the same temptation Satan offered in Matthew 4. The packaging is different. The substance is identical.

Matthew records three temptations. The first is about provision: turn stones into bread. The second is about spectacle: throw yourself off the temple and let the angels catch you. The third is the one that matters most for our purposes, because it is explicitly political:

"Again, the devil took him to a very high mountain and showed him all the kingdoms of the world and their glory. And he said to him, 'All these I will give you, if you will fall down and worship me.'" —Matthew 4:8–9

Read this carefully. What Satan is offering is not merely temptation to personal sin. It is a theological proposition. It is a competing vision of how the world gets fixed.

Satan is saying: You want to save the world? Here it is. All the kingdoms. All the power. All the political authority. You can have it—right now. No cross. No suffering. No slow, patient, agonizing work of redemption through death and resurrection. No thirty years of obscurity followed by three years of rejection followed by a humiliating public execution. Skip all of that. Take the shortcut. I will give you what you want—just worship me.

And Jesus said no.

"Then Jesus said to him, 'Be gone, Satan! For it is written, "You shall worship the Lord your God and him only shall you serve."'" —

Matthew 4:10

Jesus did not refuse because political authority is evil. He will later tell His disciples that all authority in heaven and on earth has been given to Him (Matthew 28:18). He did not refuse because He was uninterested in the kingdoms of the world. He came precisely to redeem them.

He refused because political authority obtained through compromise with evil—even for good ends, even for redemptive purposes, even to "save the world"—is a betrayal of the Father's plan. The shortcut is always a betrayal. The means matter. The method of conquest matters. And God's method is not coercion, not power brokering, not political maneuvering. God's method is a cross.

That temptation did not end in the wilderness. It followed Jesus throughout His entire public ministry. Every time the crowd wanted to crown Him. Every time the disciples argued about who would sit at His right and left hand in the coming kingdom. Every time zealots tried to recruit Him for their cause. Every time the people expected a military Messiah who would throw off Roman oppression and restore Israel to national greatness.

The temptation was always the same: bypass the cross, take the shortcut, use power to accomplish what only suffering can achieve.

And Jesus refused. Every single time.

Now here is the question for the American church: Are we refusing it? Or are we accepting the very deal Jesus turned down?

When we align the church with political power in exchange for protection, influence, and cultural dominance—when we accept the bargain of "all these kingdoms, if you will just support me"—are we following Jesus, or are we accepting the offer He rejected?

The question is not comfortable. But it is inescapable.

The Kind of Messiah They Rejected

To understand the first-century rejection of Jesus, we need to understand the first-century expectation. Because the people who rejected Jesus were not godless pagans. Many of them were devout, Scripture-reading, synagogue-attending, prayer-praying believers. They loved God. They believed His promises. They were waiting for the Messiah with genuine hope.

They just had a very specific idea of what the Messiah would do.

The dominant messianic expectation in first-century Judaism was political. The Messiah would be a new David—a warrior king who would restore Israel's political sovereignty, drive out the occupying Romans, reestablish the Davidic throne in Jerusalem, and inaugurate an era of national greatness under God's visible rule. This was not a fringe hope. It was the mainstream expectation, rooted in real biblical texts and reinforced by centuries of foreign occupation, humiliation, and longing for deliverance.

The promises to David in 2 Samuel 7. The victory songs of the psalms. The prophetic visions of a restored kingdom in Isaiah, Ezekiel, and Daniel. The expectation of a "Son of Man" who would receive dominion and an everlasting kingdom. All of these texts were in their Bibles, and all of them could be read—and were read—as predictions of a politically triumphant Messiah.

What they missed—or what they chose not to see—was the other thread.

The thread of the Suffering Servant in Isaiah 52–53, who would be "despised and rejected by men," who would bear the iniquities of the people, who would be "like a lamb that is led to the slaughter."

The thread of the humble king in Zechariah 9:9, who would come "riding on a donkey, on a colt, the foal of a donkey"—not on a war horse, not in a chariot, not at the head of an army, but on the most humble animal available.

The thread of the shepherd struck down in Zechariah 13:7, whose death would scatter the sheep before God's refining work could begin.

The thread of the psalmist in Psalm 22, who cries out, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?"—a psalm that reads like a detailed preview of crucifixion written centuries before crucifixion was invented.

All of these texts were in their Scriptures. But the political messiah was so much more appealing—so much more satisfying to the national ego, so much more aligned with the desire for visible victory—that the suffering thread was minimized, spiritualized, or simply ignored.

When Jesus arrived, He was not what they expected.

He did not raise an army. He did not storm Herod's palace. He did not negotiate with Rome. He did not organize a political movement. Instead, He washed feet. He touched lepers. He ate with tax collectors and prostitutes. He welcomed children. He confronted the religious establishment. He wept over Jerusalem. He told parables about seeds and soil instead of strategy and siege warfare.

He announced that the Kingdom of God was at hand—and then defined that Kingdom in ways that baffled, disturbed, and eventually infuriated everyone who heard Him.

The Kingdom belongs to the poor in spirit. The meek. The mourners. The peacemakers. The persecuted. Not the powerful, the triumphant, the well-connected, the politically astute.

No wonder they were confused. No wonder many of them eventually turned away. No wonder, when the choice was laid before them between Jesus and Barabbas—between the suffering servant and the violent revolutionary—the crowd chose Barabbas.

They chose the strongman over the servant. And they have not stopped choosing.

The Triumphal Entry That Wasn't

Luke 19 records what the church has traditionally called the "Triumphal Entry"—Jesus' arrival in Jerusalem on what we celebrate

as Palm Sunday. It is one of the most misunderstood moments in the Gospels, and the misunderstanding reveals everything about the distance between human expectations and divine intention.

The scene looks triumphant. The crowd is ecstatic. They are shouting, "Blessed is the King who comes in the name of the Lord! Peace in heaven and glory in the highest!" They are throwing their cloaks on the road—a gesture of royal honor. The atmosphere is electric with expectation. This is the moment. The Messiah is finally going to take His throne. Jerusalem will be restored. Rome will be humbled. God's people will be free.

But look at what Jesus does as He approaches the city:

"And when he drew near and saw the city, he wept over it, saying, 'Would that you, even you, had known on this day the things that make for peace! But now they are hidden from your eyes. For the days will come when your enemies will set up a barricade around you and surround you and hem you in on every side and tear you down to the ground, you and your children within you. And they will not leave one stone upon another in you, because you did not know the time of your visitation.'" —Luke 19:41–44

The crowd is celebrating. Jesus is weeping.

They think He is coming to conquer. He knows He is coming to die.

They believe this entry will lead to a throne. It will lead to a cross.

They are shouting about glory. He is grieving about destruction—because He knows that within a generation, Rome will do exactly what He describes: surround the city, tear it down, and leave not one stone upon another. The very political catastrophe the crowd hopes the Messiah will prevent is the catastrophe Jesus sees coming precisely because they have rejected His kind of messiahship.

And the reason He weeps is contained in that devastating phrase: they do not know "the things that make for peace."

They think peace comes through military victory and political restoration. Jesus knows peace comes through repentance, reconciliation, and the self-giving love of God poured out on a cross. They want the peace that comes from defeating your enemies. He offers the peace that comes from loving them. They want the peace of power. He brings the peace of surrender.

The distance between what the crowd wanted and what Jesus came to do is the same distance that exists today between what many American Christians expect from political power and what God actually provides through the gospel.

We keep looking for a triumphal entry—a moment when our side wins, our values prevail, our enemies are humbled, and the kingdom feels like it has arrived.

God keeps offering a crucifixion.

And we keep being confused about why He won't fight the way we want Him to.

Mark 8: The Rebuke That Defines Everything

If there is one passage in the Gospels that exposes the spiritual danger of wanting the wrong kind of Messiah, it is Mark 8:27–38. This passage is the hinge of Mark's entire Gospel, and its implications for the American church are staggering.

The scene begins with a question. Jesus asks His disciples: "Who do people say that I am?" They offer various answers—John the Baptist, Elijah, one of the prophets. Then Jesus makes it personal: "But who do you say that I am?"

Peter answers with the confession that defines Christianity: "You are the Christ." The Messiah. The anointed one. The King we have been waiting for.

It is the right answer. And everything that follows reveals how catastrophically Peter misunderstands what it means.

Because immediately after Peter's confession, Jesus begins to explain what kind of Christ He will be:

"And he began to teach them that the Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected by the elders and the chief priests and the scribes and be killed, and after three days rise again. And he said this plainly." —Mark 8:31–32

Suffer. Be rejected. Be killed. Rise again. That is the messianic program. That is the plan. Not political conquest. Not military victory. Not cultural dominance. Suffering, rejection, death, and resurrection.

Peter cannot accept it.

"And Peter took him aside and began to rebuke him." —Mark 8:32

Let the audacity of this sink in. Peter has just confessed Jesus as the Christ—the anointed king of Israel, the one sent by God to save the world—and within sixty seconds, he is rebuking Him. Correcting Him. Telling God's Messiah that God's plan is wrong.

Peter is not rejecting Jesus. He is editing Jesus. He is keeping the title "Christ" while insisting on a different job description. He wants a Messiah who wins through strength, who conquers through power, who restores Israel through political and military triumph. A suffering Messiah is a contradiction in terms. A crucified King is an absurdity. A Savior who dies is no savior at all.

And Jesus' response is the most devastating rebuke in the entire Bible:

"But turning and seeing his disciples, he rebuked Peter and said, 'Get behind me, Satan! For you are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man.'" —Mark 8:33

Jesus calls Peter "Satan."

Not an enemy. A disciple. Not someone who denies Christ. Someone who confesses Christ—and then tries to edit the kind of

Christ he is willing to follow.

And the reason for the rebuke is not that Peter is stupid or that his concern is trivial. The reason is that Peter is promoting a theology of power that is satanic in origin. The desire for a Messiah who wins through strength rather than suffering, who conquers through force rather than sacrifice, who delivers the nation through political triumph rather than personal transformation—that desire is not merely mistaken. It is the same offer Satan made in the wilderness. It is the same temptation Jesus has already rejected. And now it is coming from inside the inner circle.

The application to our moment should be unmistakable.

When the American church confesses "Jesus is Lord" but then insists that the way forward is through political power, cultural dominance, legislative control, and the defeat of enemies through coercion rather than love—we are doing exactly what Peter did.

We are confessing the right Christ and demanding the wrong mission.

We are saying "You are the Messiah" and then rebuking Him when His plan does not look like what we wanted.

And Jesus' response has not changed. It is the same today as it was on the road to Caesarea Philippi: "You are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man."

Answering the Objection: "But Jesus Confronts Evil—What About Justice?"

This is an important objection, and it deserves more than a dismissive wave. Because the portrait of Jesus I am painting—a Jesus who rejects political power, who suffers rather than conquers, who dies rather than fights—can be misread as a portrait of passivity. And Jesus is not passive.

Jesus overturns tables in the temple. He calls the Pharisees "whitewashed tombs" and "brood of vipers." He speaks truth to the

face of every power structure He encounters—religious, political, economic. He does not avoid conflict. He walks into it. He does not tolerate injustice. He names it.

So the objection is fair: if Jesus confronts evil, why can't we use political power to confront evil too?

The answer is not that Christians should never use political tools to pursue justice. As we established in the previous chapter, political engagement is a legitimate expression of neighbor-love. Laws matter. Policies matter. The vulnerable need protection, and sometimes that protection comes through legislation, courts, and governmental action.

The answer is in how Jesus confronts evil—and what He refuses to do in the process.

Jesus confronts evil without seizing political control. He speaks truth to Pilate without negotiating for a position in the Roman government. He rebukes the Pharisees without organizing a competing religious party. He cleanses the temple without establishing a permanent enforcement mechanism. His confrontation of evil is fierce, direct, and prophetic—but it is never coercive. It never depends on having the political power to enforce compliance.

Jesus confronts evil without dehumanizing His enemies. He calls the Pharisees hypocrites, but He also weeps over Jerusalem. He rebukes Peter, but He also restores him. He is arrested by soldiers, but He heals the ear of the one Peter struck. The confrontation of evil in the Gospels never slides into the contempt, cruelty, or dehumanization that characterizes so much of our political engagement. Jesus can name sin without destroying the sinner. That is a skill the church has largely forgotten.

Jesus confronts evil by absorbing it rather than retaliating against it. This is the heart of the matter. On the cross, Jesus does not defeat evil by exercising superior force. He defeats evil by taking it into Himself, bearing its full weight, and refusing to let it reproduce through Him. He breaks the cycle of violence not by winning the

fight but by refusing to fight on evil's terms. "When he was reviled, he did not revile in return; when he suffered, he did not threaten, but continued entrusting himself to him who judges justly" (1 Peter 2:23).

And the resurrection that follows is God's vindication of that path—not the path of the sword, but the path of self-giving love. The resurrection does not come through military revolt. It comes through dying and being raised. The victory is real. The kingdom is established. Evil is defeated. But the method of defeat is sacrifice, not coercion.

So when we insist that the church needs political power to accomplish justice, we are implicitly saying something about the cross: we are saying it was not enough. We are saying God's strategy of conquering through suffering is insufficient and needs to be supplemented by the strategies of the world. We are saying what Peter said—"Surely this cannot be the plan"—and receiving the same rebuke.

Justice in the way of Jesus does not bypass suffering. It passes through it. And any vision of justice that requires the church to become cruel, manipulative, dishonest, or power-hungry in order to achieve its goals has already departed from the way of Christ—no matter how righteous the cause.

Cross-Shaped Courage and Non-Anxious Presence

So what does this mean practically? If the church is not supposed to seize political power to impose righteousness, and if the church is not supposed to withdraw into passivity and irrelevance—what is the church supposed to do?

The answer is cross-shaped courage. And it looks like nothing the world expects.

A cross-shaped church does not need to win every culture war to maintain its identity. Its identity is not derived from cultural dominance but from union with Christ. A cross-shaped church can lose every political battle and still be the church. It can be

marginalized, ridiculed, legally constrained, and culturally irrelevant—and still proclaim the resurrection with authority and joy.

Why? Because its confidence was never in its cultural position. Its confidence was in a tomb that is empty.

A cross-shaped church is free—genuinely, radically free—from the tyranny of outcomes. It can work for justice without being destroyed by injustice. It can advocate for truth without being devastated when truth is rejected. It can engage the political process without being defined by the political results. Its future is secured not by electoral victories but by the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead.

This is not passivity. It is the most active and most dangerous thing the church can be. Because a church that is not afraid of losing is a church that cannot be controlled. A church that does not need political power is a church that can speak truth to political power without flinching, without hedging, without calculating the political cost.

The reason so many churches cannot speak truth right now is precisely that they are afraid of losing—losing access, losing influence, losing protection, losing tax exemptions, losing cultural centrality, losing the seat at the table. They have become dependent on the chariot. And the chariot's owner always demands cooperation in exchange for rides.

But a church that has already died—a church that has taken up its cross and followed Jesus into death and resurrection—has nothing left to lose. And a church with nothing left to lose is the most powerful force on earth. Not powerful in the way Rome was powerful. Powerful in the way the resurrection is powerful: an authority that does not come from the sword but from the empty tomb.

Edwin Friedman, the family systems therapist, coined a phrase that has become invaluable for understanding leadership in anxious times: "non-anxious presence." The idea is that in a system flooded

with anxiety—a family, an organization, a nation—the most transforming thing a leader can do is refuse to be governed by the anxiety. Not to ignore it. Not to dismiss it. But to be present in the middle of it without being controlled by it.

That is what the church is called to be in America right now: a non-anxious presence. Not indifferent to the crises around us. Not naive about the real threats and real suffering in our culture. But refusing to let anxiety set the agenda. Refusing to let fear rewrite our theology. Refusing to let the temperature of the political moment determine the posture of the people of God.

The anxious church grasps for power. The non-anxious church extends open hands.

The anxious church demonizes its enemies. The non-anxious church prays for them.

The anxious church measures its health by political influence. The non-anxious church measures its health by faithfulness to Christ.

The anxious church asks, "Are we winning?" The non-anxious church asks, "Are we faithful?"

Cross-shaped courage means being willing to lose the chariot in order to keep the King. It means choosing the towel over the sword, the cross over the throne, the way of Jesus over the way of the world—even when the way of the world looks like it is winning and the way of Jesus looks like it is losing.

Because the way of Jesus always looks like it is losing right up until Sunday morning. And then everything changes.

Which Messiah Are You Following?

Let me close this chapter with a question that is meant to be uncomfortable.

Which Messiah are you actually following?

Not which Messiah do you say you follow. Not which Messiah

appears on your doctrinal statement or your church's website. Which Messiah governs your actual behavior, your actual emotional life, your actual response to the political moment you are living in?

If the Messiah you are following promises political victory, cultural dominance, and the defeat of your enemies through the exercise of power—that is not Jesus. That is the messiah the crowd wanted. That is the messiah Peter demanded. That is the messiah Satan offered in the wilderness.

If the Messiah you are following calls you to suffer for righteousness rather than seize power for convenience; to love your enemies rather than destroy them; to speak truth without cruelty; to pursue justice without becoming unjust in the process; to hold political engagement with open hands and ultimate trust in closed hands around the cross—that is the Jesus of the Gospels. That is the Messiah who was rejected, crucified, and raised on the third day.

The first messiah fills arenas. The second fills tombs—and then empties them.

The first messiah offers you the kingdoms of the world. The second offers you a cross—and then, through the cross, gives you the universe.

The first messiah makes you feel powerful. The second makes you free.

The question is not whether you believe in Jesus. The question is which Jesus you believe in. And the answer is revealed not by your theology but by your behavior—by what you are willing to lose, what you are willing to suffer, and who you become when you do not get what you want.

If losing a political battle destroys your faith, your faith was in the wrong messiah.

If being marginalized makes you cruel, you have been following the wrong king.

If the only future you can imagine for the church requires political power, you have been worshiping at the wrong throne.

The true Messiah does not need your political project to succeed. He needs your faithfulness. And faithfulness looks like a cross—not a crown.

At least, not yet.

Key Takeaways

- The crowd in John 6 wanted to make Jesus king by force; He withdrew because they wanted sovereignty without surrender, power without a cross.
- Satan's wilderness temptation was a theological proposition: political authority without suffering. Jesus refused the shortcut because the means of victory matter to God.
- First-century Israel rejected Jesus not because they hated God but because He did not match their expectation of a politically triumphant Messiah.
- The "Triumphal Entry" reveals the distance between human expectation and divine intention: the crowd celebrated while Jesus wept, because they did not know the things that make for peace.
- Peter's rebuke of Jesus and Jesus' response ("Get behind me, Satan") reveals that demanding a theology of power over suffering is satanic in origin—even when it comes from a sincere disciple.
- Jesus confronts evil fiercely but never coercively—He absorbs evil on the cross rather than retaliating, and the resurrection vindicates this path.
- Cross-shaped courage means the church is free from the tyranny of outcomes, able to speak truth without fear because its future is secured by resurrection, not elections.
- The question is not whether you believe in Jesus but which Jesus you believe in—the one who offers a crown without a cross, or the one who offers a cross that leads to a crown.

Reflection Questions

1\ What kind of Messiah do you actually want—honestly? One who suffers alongside you and calls you to sacrifice, or one who delivers political victory and cultural dominance? 2\ When was the last time you were genuinely uncomfortable with the way Jesus does things? What does that discomfort reveal about the messiah you are functionally following? 3\ How would your church's ministry change

if political influence were completely removed tomorrow? Would the mission survive? Would your people know how to be the church without cultural power? 4\ Can you distinguish, in your own life, between confronting injustice and seizing control? Where have you confused the two? Where have you called coercion "justice"? 5\ What would "cross-shaped courage" look like in your specific context this week—in your family, your workplace, your church, your social media presence? 6\ If losing the next election would destroy your confidence in God, what does that reveal about which messiah you have been trusting?

Practices

- Personal: Read John 6:1–21 slowly and imagine yourself in the crowd. Be honest: would you have tried to make Jesus king? Would you have been frustrated when He withdrew? What does your answer reveal about your expectations of God?
- Personal: Identify one area of your life where you have been trying to get God to act like the Messiah you want rather than the Messiah He is. Write it down. Surrender it in prayer. Ask God for the grace to accept His plan instead of demanding your own.
- Family: Read Mark 8:31–38 together at a family meal. Discuss two questions: What does it mean to "take up your cross" in our family's current circumstances? And: Are there ways our family has been following a "power messiah" instead of the suffering servant?
- Church: Challenge your congregation or small group to articulate the church's mission in terms that do not depend on political outcomes. What remains when political power is removed? Is that enough? If it is not, why not?

Sources & Notes

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CHAPTER FOUR

"Jesus Is Lord"—The Most Dangerous Sentence in the Empire

"To confess 'Jesus is Lord' was not a private spiritual sentiment. It was a public act of political defiance."

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The Sentence That Could Kill You

In the modern American church, the phrase "Jesus is Lord" is the most familiar and least understood confession in all of Christianity.

We say it in worship songs. We print it on coffee mugs. We embroider it on throw pillows. We post it on social media with sunset backgrounds and curated fonts. It appears on bumper stickers and T-shirts and church marquees. It is so ubiquitous, so comfortable, so thoroughly domesticated that it has lost virtually all of its original power.

And that loss of power is not accidental. It is, in fact, the most successful act of theological neutralization in the history of the church.

Because in its original context, "Jesus is Lord" was not a worship lyric. It was not a devotional sentiment. It was not a statement of personal spiritual preference. It was a political claim that could—and did—get you killed.

To understand why, you need to understand the world in which the earliest Christians lived. You need to understand what the word Lord meant before it became a hymnal cliché. And you need to understand what it cost to say it.

In the first-century Roman Empire, there was one sentence that every citizen, every subject, every conquered people was expected to affirm. It was not a request. It was the price of participation in Roman society. And the sentence was this:

"Kaiser kyrios." Caesar is Lord.

This was not merely a political statement, though it was certainly that. It was a theological claim. The Roman emperor was not simply a political ruler. He was *divus*—divine. Beginning with Augustus, the imperial cult presented the emperor as a god, or at least as the son of a god, worthy of worship, offering, and absolute allegiance. Temples were built to the emperor. Festivals celebrated his divine status. Incense was burned before his image. The phrase *Kaiser kyrios* was the loyalty oath of the empire—the verbal act of submission that marked you as a good Roman, a loyal subject, a person who knew your place in the cosmic order.

And into that world, the earliest Christians walked with a counter-confession that constituted treason:

"Iesous kyrios." Jesus is Lord.

Same word. Same grammatical construction. Directly and deliberately contradictory. To say "Jesus is Lord" in the first century was to say, simultaneously and necessarily, "Caesar is not Lord." It was not a statement about your personal devotional life. It was a public declaration that the ultimate authority in the universe was not the man on the throne in Rome but the man on the cross outside Jerusalem—and that this crucified man had been raised from the dead and was now seated at the right hand of God, ruling over every principality and power, including the one that thought it ruled the world.

That is what the earliest Christians meant when they said "Jesus is Lord." And the Roman Empire understood perfectly.

Treason in Thessalonica: Acts 17 and the Political Gospel

The book of Acts gives us a window into exactly how the Roman world heard the early Christian message. And what they heard was not a private religion. They heard a political revolution.

In Acts 17, Paul and Silas arrive in Thessalonica. Paul does what he always does: he goes to the synagogue and reasons from the Scriptures, explaining that the Messiah had to suffer, die, and rise again, and that "this Jesus, whom I proclaim to you, is the Christ" (Acts 17:3). Some Jews are persuaded. Some Greeks are persuaded. And a mob forms.

The opponents drag some of the new believers before the city authorities. And the accusation they bring is one of the most revealing sentences in the entire New Testament:

"These men who have turned the world upside down have come here also, and Jason has received them, and they are all acting against the decrees of Caesar, saying that there is another king, Jesus." — Acts 17:6–7

Read that accusation carefully. The opponents of the gospel do not say, "These men are teaching a new philosophy." They do not say, "These men have an interesting private spirituality." They say, "These men are acting against the decrees of Caesar" and "saying that there is another king."

They understood the gospel perfectly. Better, in fact, than many modern Christians do.

The accusation is that the early Christians are proclaiming a rival king. Not a rival spiritual guru. Not a rival moral teacher. Not a rival source of personal peace and inner fulfillment. A rival king—one whose authority supersedes Caesar's, whose kingdom renders the Roman Empire penultimate, whose decrees override the decrees of the most powerful government on earth.

The phrase "turned the world upside down" is itself revealing. The Greek word is *anastatoo*—to disturb, to unsettle, to cause political upheaval. These are not people engaging in quiet spiritual

devotion. They are people whose message has the power to restructure the political order. And the Roman authorities know it.

Luke, the author of Acts, records this accusation without correcting it. He does not say, "Of course, they misunderstood—the gospel is not political." He does not explain that the kingdom of God is purely spiritual and has no implications for earthly power. He simply records the accusation and moves on, because the accusation is effectively correct. The early Christians were proclaiming another king. They

were announcing a kingdom that relativized every earthly government. They were living in a way that undermined the absolute claims of the Roman state.

The difference—and this is the critical distinction for our moment—is in how they were doing it. They were not forming a political party. They were not running candidates. They were not lobbying for legislative influence. They were not building a voting bloc. They were not making alliances with sympathetic Roman officials in exchange for protection and cultural power.

They were worshiping. They were sharing meals. They were caring for the poor. They were telling the truth about who was actually in charge. And the empire found that more threatening than an army.

The Hymn That Dethroned Caesar: Philippians 2

Philippians 2:5–11 is one of the most magnificent passages in the New Testament. It is often called the *Carmen Christi*—the Hymn of Christ—and it may well be the oldest piece of Christian liturgy we possess, predating even Paul's letter. It is a theological masterpiece. And it is an act of political subversion disguised as a worship song.

To hear it the way the Philippians heard it, you need to know one thing about Philippi: it was a Roman colony. Not just a city in the empire—a

colonia, a settlement of Roman military veterans who had been given land as a reward for service. Philippi was proud of its Roman identity. Its citizens had Roman rights. Its public life was saturated with Roman culture, Roman law, and Roman religion—including the imperial cult. To live in Philippi was to live surrounded by reminders that Caesar was lord.

And into that context, Paul writes this:

"Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus, who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men. And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross." —Philippians 2:5–8

This is already a radical claim. Jesus, who possessed divine equality, did not grasp at it—did not use it as a tool of domination, did not use it for power. Instead, He emptied Himself. He became a servant. He submitted to the most humiliating form of execution the Roman Empire had devised—a death reserved for slaves, rebels, and the lowest of criminals.

But it is the next verses that would have sent a shockwave through the Roman colony:

"Therefore God has highly exalted him and bestowed on him the name that is above every name, so that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father." —Philippians 2:9–11

Every knee will bow. Every tongue will confess. Jesus Christ is Lord.

In a Roman colony where every citizen was expected to bend the knee to Caesar, Paul is announcing that there is a name higher than Caesar's. In a city built on imperial loyalty, he is declaring that the ultimate confession of the universe is not Kaiser kyrios but Iesous

Christos kyrios. In a culture that exalted power, military conquest, and political domination, Paul says the one who was exalted above all things is the one who emptied Himself and became a servant and died on a cross.

This is not merely theology. It is a complete inversion of the Roman value system. Rome said greatness comes through power. Paul says greatness comes through service. Rome said the path to lordship is domination. Paul says the path to lordship is self-emptying. Rome said the cross is the ultimate shame—the mark of defeat, powerlessness, and subhumanity. Paul says the cross is the doorway to the highest exaltation in the cosmos.

And the claim that every knee will bow—not just willing knees, not just believing knees, but every knee, in heaven and on earth and under the earth—is a direct challenge to the totality of Caesar's claims. Caesar demanded universal allegiance. Paul says someone else has it. Caesar claimed divine authority. Paul says the actually divine one chose humiliation. Caesar built his empire on the sword. Paul says the true kingdom was built on a cross.

The Philippian Christians would have heard this not as abstract theology but as a manifesto. They would have understood, with perfect clarity, that to sing this hymn was to commit an act of allegiance that put them at odds with the most powerful empire on earth. And they sang it anyway.

The True King of Kings: Revelation's Counter-Imperial Vision

If Acts shows how the Roman world heard the Christian confession, and Philippians shows how Christians sang it, then Revelation shows how they hoped in it—especially under the pressure of active persecution.

The book of Revelation was written during a period of intense conflict between the early church and the Roman state. The precise date is debated, but the political reality is clear: Christians were being pressured—sometimes by social exclusion, sometimes by economic

penalty, sometimes by imprisonment and death—to participate in the imperial cult. To burn incense before the emperor's image. To say

Kaiser *kyrios*. And they were refusing.

Into that context, John writes an apocalyptic vision that is, among many other things, the most sustained piece of political resistance literature in the Bible. And at its climax, John sees the true ruler of the world:

"Then I saw heaven opened, and behold, a white horse! The one sitting on it is called Faithful and True, and in righteousness he judges and makes war... On his robe and on his thigh he has a name written, King of kings and Lord of lords." —Revelation 19:11, 16

King of kings. Lord of lords.

These were not original phrases. They were imperial titles. The Roman emperor styled himself as the supreme ruler over all lesser kings and lords. Revelation takes those titles and reassigns them—not to the man on the throne in Rome, but to the Lamb who was slain. The entire book is structured as a counter-narrative to imperial propaganda. Where Rome says, "We bring peace through military conquest," Revelation says the true peace comes through a slaughtered Lamb. Where Rome says, "The emperor is the savior of the world," Revelation says the savior was crucified by the empire. Where Rome says, "Our kingdom will last forever," Revelation says Babylon—Rome's code name—will fall.

But here is what makes Revelation so important for our discussion: the weapon the King of Kings carries is not a sword wielded in violence. It is a sword proceeding from His mouth—His word, His truth, His declaration of how things really are. The conquering is not done through military force or political maneuvering. It is done through the proclamation of truth and the faithfulness of the saints who refuse to bow to the beast, even when it costs them everything.

The martyrs in Revelation conquer through their testimony and

through the blood of the Lamb (Revelation 12:11). They overcome not by seizing political power but by refusing to surrender their confession. They win not by electing a friendlier emperor but by maintaining their allegiance to a different King. Their political action is worship. Their resistance is faithfulness. Their revolution is the refusal to say "Caesar is lord" even when saying "Jesus is Lord" means death.

That is the political vision of the New Testament. And it looks nothing like what American Christianity has become.

How the Most Dangerous Sentence Became the Safest

So how did we get from there to here? How did "Jesus is Lord"—a confession that overthrew empires, sustained martyrs, and functioned as the most subversive political statement in the ancient world—become a bumper sticker?

The story is complex, but the trajectory is clear, and it begins with Constantine.

In 313 AD, the Emperor Constantine issued the Edict of Milan, ending the persecution of Christians and granting them legal toleration. Within a generation, Christianity went from a persecuted minority faith to the official religion of the Roman Empire. And everything changed.

On one level, this was an extraordinary gift. Persecution ended. Churches could be built. The Scriptures could be copied and distributed without fear. Theological councils could meet to clarify doctrine. The gospel could spread without the constant threat of imprisonment or death.

But on another level, something was lost—something that the church has never fully recovered. When Christianity became the religion of the empire, the confession "Jesus is Lord" lost its edge. Because when Caesar himself claims to be a Christian, saying "Jesus is Lord" no longer implies "Caesar is not." The confession is no longer a counter-claim. It is a reinforcement of the existing order.

Jesus is Lord and Caesar is His representative. The kingdom of God and the kingdom of Rome are on the same side. The cross and the sword serve the same master.

This is what historians call the Constantinian settlement, and its effects have shaped Western Christianity for seventeen centuries. The church gained access to power, protection, and cultural influence. In exchange, it gradually lost the ability to speak prophetically to power—because it was in power. It lost the ability to critique the empire—because it was the empire's religion. It lost the ability to say "Caesar is not lord"—because Caesar was sitting in the front pew.

The domestication deepened over centuries. In medieval Christendom, the church and the state became so thoroughly intertwined that it was virtually impossible to distinguish between them. The pope crowned emperors. Emperors enforced theological orthodoxy. The sword served the altar, and the altar blessed the sword. "Jesus is Lord" no longer functioned as a claim that relativized all earthly power. It functioned as the religious foundation for earthly power.

The Reformation challenged aspects of this arrangement but did not overthrow it. Luther depended on German princes for protection. Calvin shaped civic structures in Geneva. The Church of England was a state church by design. Reformation Christianity, for all its theological radicalism, remained largely Constantinian in its understanding of the relationship between church and political power.

And when European Christians came to America, they brought the Constantinian instinct with them. The specific arrangements varied—the First Amendment formally separated church and state in ways that were genuinely revolutionary. But the cultural assumption persisted: America is a Christian nation. Our government reflects Christian values. Our laws are built on Christian foundations. "Jesus is Lord" means "America is blessed." The confession no longer challenges the nation. It baptizes it.

That is how we arrived at our current moment—where "Jesus is

Lord" can appear on the same flag as a political candidate's name without anyone sensing a contradiction. Where a confession that once meant "I will die before I grant ultimate allegiance to any earthly ruler" now means "My preferred candidate shares my values." Where the most subversive sentence in the history of the world has been reduced to a tribal identifier.

The domestication is complete. And it is killing us.

What We Lost When We Tamed the Confession

When "Jesus is Lord" stopped meaning "Caesar is not," we lost several things that the American church desperately needs to recover.

We lost the ability to critique our own nation prophetically. If "Jesus is Lord" and "America is a Christian nation" are functionally the same confession, then criticizing America feels like criticizing Jesus. Patriotism and discipleship merge. National interest and Kingdom interest become indistinguishable. And the prophetic tradition that runs from Moses to Amos to Jesus—the tradition that says "Thus says the Lord" to the nation's face, calling it to repentance—becomes impossible. You cannot prophetically challenge a system you have sacralized.

The Old Testament prophets stood within Israel but against its unfaithfulness. They loved the nation precisely by refusing to bless its sins. They were patriots of the deepest kind—patriots who cared more about the nation's soul than its comfort, more about its covenant faithfulness than its military success. But their patriotism was subordinated to their loyalty to God. When the two conflicted, God won. Always.

A domesticated church cannot do this. A church that has identified the Kingdom of God with the American project cannot prophetically challenge the American project without feeling like it is challenging the Kingdom of God. And so it remains silent when it should speak, compliant when it should resist, comfortable when it should be grieved.

We lost the independence that makes the church's voice credible. The early church's moral authority came precisely from its independence. When Christians cared for plague victims while Roman elites fled the cities, the world noticed—not because the church was in power, but because it acted with sacrificial love while out of power. When Christians refused to participate in the imperial cult even under threat of death, their testimony carried weight—because there was obviously nothing to be gained by it except suffering.

A church that is aligned with political power loses this credibility. When Christians speak about justice while holding the levers of cultural influence, the world hears self-interest disguised as righteousness. When the church advocates for policies that happen to benefit its own position, even genuinely good policies lose their moral force because the advocacy looks strategic rather than sacrificial. The church's voice is most powerful when it has the least to gain from being heard.

We lost the freedom to hold all political arrangements with open hands. The early church survived—and often thrived—under emperors who were hostile, indifferent, or friendly. It did not depend on the political environment for its vitality. It could function under Nero, under Marcus Aurelius, under Diocletian, under Constantine. Its life was not contingent on having the right person in power, because its life came from the resurrected Christ, not from the sitting emperor.

A domesticated church has lost this flexibility. It has become so intertwined with a particular political arrangement that the loss of that arrangement feels like the loss of the faith itself. When cultural influence wanes, the church panics—not because the gospel is threatened (the gospel cannot be threatened by an election), but because the particular political environment in which the church is comfortable is changing. And the panic reveals the depth of the dependency.

We lost the scandal of the cross as a political statement. In the first century, saying "Jesus is Lord" was scandalous because it claimed that ultimate authority belonged to a crucified man—not a military conqueror, not a political genius, not a wielder of coercive force, but someone Rome had executed as a criminal. The cross was the empire's ultimate statement of power: "We can do this to you." And the resurrection was God's ultimate counter-statement: "Yes, you can. And it does not matter."

When "Jesus is Lord" is domesticated, the scandal of the cross disappears. The crucified Lord becomes a mascot for cultural power. The one who was executed by the state is reimagined as the patron saint of the state. The one who refused political power is invoked to legitimate political power. And the fundamental meaning of the confession—that God's power is made perfect in weakness, that the last shall be first, that the way up is the way down—is quietly discarded in favor of a Jesus who looks a lot like Caesar with a cross necklace.

Recovering the Subversive Edge Without the Culture War Posture

So how do we recover the original power of "Jesus is Lord" without turning it into another weapon in the culture wars? How do we restore the confession's subversive edge without adopting the very posture of power that the confession was meant to overthrow?

This is the question, and it requires extraordinary care. Because the danger on one side is a domesticated faith that challenges nothing. And the danger on the other side is a weaponized faith that challenges everything except itself.

The recovery begins with understanding what kind of Lord Jesus is. And the Philippians hymn gives us the answer: He is the Lord who emptied Himself. He is the Lord who took the form of a servant. He is the Lord who humbled Himself to the point of death. He is the Lord who received the name above every name not by seizing power but by surrendering it. Not by climbing to the top but by descending to the bottom. Not by crushing His enemies but by being crushed for

them.

This means that when we confess "Jesus is Lord," we are not merely saying that Jesus has authority. We are saying that authority itself has been redefined. The nature of lordship has been transformed by the cross. Power that dominates is not the Lord's kind of power. Authority that coerces is not the Lord's kind of authority. A kingdom that requires the weapons of the world to advance is not the Lord's kind of kingdom.

To confess "Jesus is Lord" is therefore to commit yourself to a particular way of engaging the world—a way marked by service rather than domination, by truth-telling rather than propaganda, by enemy-love rather than enemy-destruction, by willingness to suffer rather than willingness to inflict suffering.

That means the recovery of the confession is not accomplished by being louder, angrier, or more politically aggressive. It is not accomplished by "taking back" culture or "reclaiming" institutions or "fighting" for influence. All of those strategies assume that the way to confess Jesus as Lord is to exercise the kind of lordship Caesar exercised—to dominate, to control, to win. But the confession itself declares that the Lord conquered by being conquered. He won by losing. He reigned by serving.

The subversive power of "Jesus is Lord" is recovered when the church lives so differently from the surrounding culture that people have to ask why. When Christians love their enemies so conspicuously that it baffles the tribalized world. When the church serves the poor so lavishly that secular observers cannot explain it by self-interest. When believers speak truth so consistently—to both political parties, to both sides of every cultural divide—that no faction can claim them.

The early church did not conquer Rome by outmaneuvering it politically. It conquered Rome by out-loving it, out-dying it, and out-hoping it. It offered a community that was more compelling than anything the empire could provide—a community where slaves and

masters ate at the same table, where ethnic divisions were healed rather than exploited, where the sick and abandoned were cared for rather than discarded. The confession "Jesus is Lord" was credible because the community that confessed it was visibly different from the world that rejected it.

That is the recovery we need. Not a church that confesses Jesus is Lord and then acts like Caesar is the model. A church that confesses Jesus is Lord and then acts like Jesus is the model—which means service, sacrifice, truth, and love, even when those things bring no political advantage whatsoever.

The Confession That Costs Something

In the early church, to confess "Jesus is Lord" was to accept a cost. It could mean social exclusion—losing your place in the guild, losing business relationships, being shut out of civic life. It could mean economic loss—forefeiting the commercial advantages that came with participating in the imperial cult. It could mean imprisonment. It could mean death.

The early Christians did not confess "Jesus is Lord" because it was convenient or because it aligned with their cultural identity or because it reinforced their political preferences. They confessed it because it was true. And they were willing to pay whatever price that truth demanded.

Now consider the American context. What does it cost to say "Jesus is Lord" in the contemporary United States?

In most settings, the honest answer is: nothing. It costs nothing to say "Jesus is Lord" in a church that already believes it. It costs nothing to post it on social media to an audience that already agrees with you. It costs nothing to wear it on a T-shirt in a culture where Christianity, though declining in influence, is still the dominant religious tradition.

But here is where the confession begins to cost something again: When it means refusing to grant ultimate allegiance to any political

movement. When it means declining to treat a candidate as a savior. When it means speaking truth that your own party does not want to hear. When it means caring for people your tribe has labeled as enemies. When it means losing relationships because you will not subordinate your confession to your politics.

The confession costs something when it actually functions as it was designed to function—as a declaration that relativizes every other claim to ultimate authority.

If "Jesus is Lord" does not challenge your politics, it is not functioning. If it only challenges the other side's politics, it is being weaponized, not confessed. If it sits comfortably alongside your partisan loyalty without creating any tension, then it has been domesticated—tamed and declawed and turned into a mascot for something that is not the Kingdom of God.

The test of whether you are actually confessing "Jesus is Lord" is not whether you say the words. The test is where the confession creates friction. Because if Jesus is actually Lord—if His authority actually supersedes every earthly power—then His lordship will inevitably conflict with your preferred political arrangement at some point. It will demand something of you that your party does not demand. It will prohibit something that your movement celebrates. It will call you to love someone your side has decided to hate.

If your confession of Jesus' lordship never creates friction with your political identity, one of two things is true: either you have perfectly aligned your politics with the Kingdom of God (which no one in history has managed to do), or you have subordinated the lordship of Christ to the lordship of your political tribe.

The early Christians faced a choice: Caesar or Jesus. The choice was clear, the cost was high, and they chose Jesus.

The American church faces a more subtle version of the same choice. Not Caesar or Jesus—but a particular vision of America, or Jesus. A particular political movement, or Jesus. A particular cultural

arrangement that feels safe and familiar and right, or the crucified and risen Lord who transcends every culture, every nation, and every political project.

The choice should be just as clear. But it is not. Because we have been saying "Jesus is Lord" for so long without it costing us anything that we have forgotten what the words mean.

It is time to remember.

It is time to say "Jesus is Lord" and mean it—not as a tribal slogan, not as a political weapon, not as a comfortable affirmation of the status quo, but as the most radical, dangerous, costly, and hopeful sentence a human being can utter.

It is time to confess that the crucified carpenter from Nazareth is the rightful King of the universe—and then to let that confession reshape everything: our politics, our allegiances, our loves, our enemies, our hopes, and our willingness to suffer for the truth.

Because if Jesus is actually Lord, then nothing else can be. Not America. Not a party. Not a candidate. Not a movement. Not an ideology.

And if nothing else can be Lord, then you are free. Free from the tyranny of political tribalism. Free from the fear that the wrong election will undo the Kingdom of God. Free from the desperate need to control the levers of power in order to feel safe.

You are free because the Lord you serve does not need your political project to succeed. He has already conquered. He has already been exalted. He has already been given the name above every name. And every knee will bow—not because the church amassed enough political capital to force compliance, but because the crucified King has been raised from the dead and is seated at the right hand of God.

That is the confession. It cost the early church everything. It should cost us something too.

Key Takeaways

• "Jesus is Lord" was not a private devotional sentiment in the first century—it was a direct, deliberate counter-confession to "Caesar is Lord," and it could get you killed. • Acts 17:6–7 reveals that the Roman world heard the gospel as a political claim: "They are saying there is another king, Jesus." The opponents of the gospel understood its implications better than many modern Christians do. • Philippians 2:5–11, written to a Roman colony saturated with imperial cult, declares that the name above every name belongs not to Caesar but to the crucified servant—inverting the entire Roman value system. • Revelation reassigns the imperial titles "King of kings" and "Lord of lords" to the slaughtered Lamb, and the saints conquer not by seizing power but by maintaining their confession even unto death. • The Constantinian settlement—when Christianity became the empire's religion—domesticated the confession by making "Jesus is Lord" compatible with, rather than subversive of, earthly political power. • We lost four critical things when the confession was tamed: prophetic critique of our own nation, independence that makes the church's voice credible, flexibility to thrive under any political arrangement, and the scandal of the cross as a political statement. • Recovery does not come through louder culture war but through living so differently that the confession becomes visible—through service, enemy-love, truth-telling, and willingness to suffer without political advantage. • The test of whether you actually confess "Jesus is Lord" is not whether you say the words but whether the confession creates friction with your political identity.

Reflection Questions

1\ When you say "Jesus is Lord," does the confession carry any cost in your life? Does it create tension with anything you value—or has it become entirely comfortable? 2\ Can you identify a specific area where the lordship of Christ conflicts with the priorities of your preferred political party or movement? How have you responded to that conflict? 3\ If you were living in first-century Rome, would you refuse to say "Caesar is Lord"? Now ask: Is there a modern equivalent—some loyalty oath to a political tribe—that you might be unwilling to refuse? 4\ Has the confession "Jesus is Lord" ever caused you to

change a political position, or does your politics always determine how you interpret Christ's lordship? 5\ . What would it look like for your church to recover the subversive edge of the confession without adopting a combative culture-war posture? What would change in your worship, your community, your public witness? 6\ . The early church's moral authority came from its sacrificial love while out of power. Does your church's public witness rely more on political influence or on visible, sacrificial love?

Practices

- Personal: For one week, every time you say or think "Jesus is Lord," pause and ask yourself: "What does this confession demand of me right now that I am not currently giving?" Write down what comes to mind.
- Personal: Read Philippians 2:5–11 daily for two weeks. Each day, journal one way the self-emptying pattern of Jesus challenges your current approach to political engagement.
- Family: At dinner, discuss this question together: "If our church lost all political influence tomorrow—no access to legislators, no cultural clout, no media presence—what would our mission look like? Would it change? Should it?"
- Church: Propose a worship service or series that explores the original political context of the earliest Christian confessions. Discuss what it meant to confess Christ as Lord under threat of persecution, and what it should mean for us today.

Sources & Notes

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CHAPTER FIVE

Civil Religion: When a Nation Borrows Sacred Words

"The most dangerous idol is the one that looks like worship."

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The Prayer That Feels Like Scripture

There is a moment in the life of nearly every American church that reveals, with almost surgical precision, how deeply national identity has been woven into the fabric of Christian worship. It usually happens on the Sunday nearest the Fourth of July, or on the Sunday before Memorial Day, or sometimes on the Sunday after a national tragedy. The sanctuary is decorated with flags. The worship set includes a patriotic hymn. Someone reads a passage about God's faithfulness to "this nation." A veteran is honored. A prayer is offered for "our troops" and "our leaders" and "our way of life."

And in that moment, something happens that most people in the room do not notice. The line between worship of God and celebration of nation becomes invisible. The emotional register of the room—the reverence, the gratitude, the sense of being in the presence of something sacred—is identical whether the congregation is singing "Holy, Holy, Holy" or "God Bless America." The tears that fall during a patriotic tribute feel the same as the tears that fall during communion. The lump in the throat when the flag is presented feels the same as the lump in the throat when the cross is lifted.

That emotional fusion—that seamless blending of national feeling and spiritual devotion—is not an accident. It is the product of something that has been growing in American culture for centuries.

And it has a name.

Sociologists call it civil religion.

And if you want to understand how patriotism became a practical savior for millions of American Christians—if you want to understand how "God Bless America" quietly replaced "Thy Kingdom Come" as the functional prayer of the church—you have to understand what civil religion is, where it came from, and why it is so spiritually lethal precisely because it feels so spiritually natural.

What Civil Religion Is—and What It Is Not

The term "civil religion" was given its modern form by sociologist Robert Bellah in a landmark 1967 essay, "Civil Religion in America." Bellah observed that alongside the formal separation of church and state enshrined in the First Amendment, America had developed its own quasi-religious national narrative—a set of beliefs, symbols, rituals, and sacred texts that functioned like a religion even though they were not housed in any particular church or denomination.

This national religion had its own sacred history: the founding of the nation as an act of divine providence, the pilgrims as a new Israel crossing into a promised land, the Revolution as a righteous struggle for God-given liberty, the Civil War as a blood sacrifice that purified the nation, and the world wars as crusades against evil in which America served as God's chosen instrument.

It had its own sacred texts: the Declaration of Independence, the Constitution, the Gettysburg Address, the "I Have a Dream" speech. These documents are treated with a reverence that, in practice, feels canonical—not merely as important political writings but as expressions of transcendent moral truth.

It had its own sacred rituals: the Pledge of Allegiance, the singing of the national anthem, the observance of Memorial Day and Veterans Day, the presidential inauguration with its hand on the Bible and its invocation of God's blessing.

It had its own prophets and saints: Washington, Jefferson, Lincoln, King. These figures are not merely respected as political leaders. They are venerated as moral and spiritual exemplars—men who discerned and enacted God's purposes for the nation.

And it had its own core conviction: that America occupies a special place in God's plan. That this nation, more than any other, has been blessed, guided, and commissioned by divine providence to serve as a beacon of liberty, justice, and moral order in the world.

Now here is what makes civil religion so difficult to identify and so dangerous to confront: most of it is not wrong. At least, not obviously wrong.

It is not wrong to be grateful for the freedoms Americans enjoy. It is not wrong to honor those who sacrificed to defend them. It is not wrong to recognize the genuine influence of Christian thought on the nation's founding documents and moral traditions. It is not wrong to pray for the nation and its leaders. It is not wrong to love your country.

The problem is not that civil religion says false things. The problem is that civil religion assigns sacred weight to national things. It borrows the language, the emotions, and the categories of biblical faith and applies them to a political entity. It takes words that belong to the covenant between God and His people—words like "chosen," "covenant," "providence," "redemption," "sacrifice," "salvation"—and wraps them around a flag.

And once those words are wrapped around a flag, the flag begins to feel holy. The nation begins to feel covenantal. The political project begins to feel redemptive. And any threat to the nation begins to feel like a threat to God's kingdom itself.

That is not patriotism. That is theology. And it is a theology that the Bible explicitly rejects.

The Idol That Speaks the Language of Zion

The prophets of the Old Testament had a particular horror of idolatry that borrowed the language of Yahweh worship. They were alarmed not only by the worship of foreign gods—the Baals and Asherahs of Canaan—but by the subtler and far more dangerous tendency to take the vocabulary of covenant faithfulness and attach it to something other than God.

Isaiah confronted this directly:

"I am the Lord; that is my name; my glory I give to no other, nor my praise to carved idols." —Isaiah 42:8

God's jealousy is not petty. It is protective. He refuses to share His glory because He knows what happens when His people assign sacred status to created things: the created thing begins to demand what only the Creator can rightly receive. It begins to demand ultimate allegiance. Ultimate trust. Ultimate devotion. And the people who give it end up shaped by the idol rather than by the God whose language the idol has borrowed.

This is precisely what civil religion does. It does not present itself as a rival to Christianity. It presents itself as Christianity's ally—its political arm, its cultural expression, its patriotic face. It speaks the language of Zion. It invokes the name of God. It quotes Scripture. It prays publicly. It declares that this nation is "under God."

And because it sounds like faith, it is almost impossible for many Christians to recognize it as a competitor to faith.

But consider what civil religion actually teaches, when you strip away the reverent tone and examine the functional theology:

It teaches that America has a covenant with God—a special, binding relationship in which God has chosen this nation for a unique redemptive purpose. But no New Testament text assigns covenantal election to any modern nation-state. The people of God in the New Testament are not defined by a border but by baptism, not by citizenship but by union with Christ. The covenant community is the church—composed of every tribe, tongue, people, and nation—not

any single country, no matter how historically significant.

It teaches that America's founding was an act of divine providence comparable to the Exodus. But the founding of the United States, however notable, was a political event carried out by fallen human beings with mixed motives, many of whom enslaved other human beings while writing documents about liberty. To narrate the founding as a sacred event on par with God's redemptive acts in Scripture is to confuse political history with salvation history—and to render invisible the victims of the very "providence" being celebrated.

It teaches that national decline is equivalent to spiritual apostasy—that when America loses cultural influence, moral consensus, or global standing, something has gone wrong in the spiritual realm. But the Kingdom of God has never been contingent on the health of any particular nation. The gospel flourished when Rome collapsed. The church grew under Mao. Christianity exploded in the Global South precisely as it declined in Western Europe. National decline is not apostasy. It may, in fact, be the very soil in which the church rediscovers its dependence on God rather than on empire.

It teaches that defending the nation is functionally equivalent to defending the faith. But the faith does not need a nation to defend it. The faith has a Defender. His name is Jesus. And He has never needed a military budget, a Supreme Court, or a congressional majority to preserve His church. He told Peter, "On this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it" (Matthew 16:18). He did not say, "On this constitution I will build my nation, and the gates of secularism shall not prevail against it."

When civil religion teaches these things—and it teaches them not through formal catechesis but through hymns, holidays, political rhetoric, and the slow accumulation of cultural habit—it creates a functional theology that competes with the gospel. It does not announce itself as a rival religion. It wraps itself in the language of the faith and presents itself as the faith's most loyal friend. And that is what makes it so devastatingly effective.

Because the idol that speaks the language of Zion is the idol you never think to question.

America Is Not Israel

This needs to be said plainly, because it is the theological fault line beneath the entire civil religion edifice: America is not Israel.

The United States of America does not occupy a redemptive-historical role analogous to ancient Israel. It has not received a divine covenant. It has not been promised a land by direct revelation. It is not the vehicle through which God is bringing salvation to the world. It is a nation—one of many nations—governed by common grace, subject to common judgment, and populated by citizens who bear the image of God no more and no less than citizens of Brazil, Nigeria, South Korea, or any other country on earth.

This is not anti-American sentiment. It is basic Christian theology. And the failure to affirm it has produced an extraordinary distortion in American Christianity—a distortion in which the fate of the nation is emotionally and theologically conflated with the fate of the church.

The confusion runs deep, and it has deep roots. The Puritans who settled New England did, in fact, use explicitly covenantal language to describe their project. John Winthrop's famous "City on a Hill" sermon drew directly from the rhetoric of Israel's covenant with God, presenting the Massachusetts Bay Colony as a new Israel entering a new promised land with a sacred obligation to live faithfully before God and the watching world.

That language was powerful. It was also, in important ways, theologically mistaken.

Winthrop's use of covenant language was not unique to him; it was part of a broader Puritan conviction that God makes national covenants with particular peoples. And that conviction has had an extraordinarily long life in American Christianity. It echoes through the rhetoric of manifest destiny, through the abolitionist movement,

through the civil rights era, through the religious right, and through contemporary Christian nationalism. The specific content has changed. The structural claim has not: America has a special relationship with God, and that relationship carries obligations and blessings that are analogous to Israel's covenant.

But the New Testament does not support this claim. The New Testament is remarkably uninterested in the spiritual status of nations *qua* nations. Jesus does not establish a national covenant. Paul does not assign covenantal election to Rome or Greece or any other political entity. The book of Acts narrates the gospel crossing every border without sacralizing any of them. The epistles address churches—not countries. And Revelation, far from depicting any nation as God's chosen vessel, portrays all earthly empires as penultimate at best and beastly at worst.

Peter, writing to scattered Christians across Asia Minor, uses language that is directly relevant to this discussion:

"But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession, that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light." —1 Peter 2:9

Notice who the "holy nation" is. It is not Rome. It is not Israel in its political form. It is the church—the community of believers called out of every tribe, tongue, and people. The covenantal language that was once applied to ethnic Israel has been transferred, in the New Testament, to the multi-ethnic, transnational body of Christ. The "chosen race" is not a race at all in the biological or national sense. It is a community constituted by baptism, faith, and the indwelling of the Holy Spirit.

Peter then adds a phrase that should function as a check on every form of civil religion:

"Beloved, I urge you as sojourners and exiles to abstain from the passions of the flesh, which wage war against your soul." —1 Peter

Sojourners and exiles. Not citizens in the ultimate sense. Not people who are at home in any earthly nation. Residents, yes. Participants, yes. Tax-payers and neighbor-lovers and civic contributors, yes. But not people whose deepest identity is national. Not people whose ultimate allegiance is patriotic. Sojourners—people who live in a place without belonging to it in the end. Exiles—people who know that their true citizenship is elsewhere.

Paul says the same thing to the Philippians—who, remember, lived in a Roman colony where imperial identity was everything:

"But our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ." —Philippians 3:20

Our citizenship is in heaven. Not "in addition to" our earthly citizenship. Not "as a spiritual supplement to" our national loyalty. Our primary, defining, identity-shaping citizenship is in heaven. Every other citizenship—American, Roman, British, Chinese—is secondary. Temporary. Penultimate.

This does not mean Christians should be bad citizens. Peter and Paul both instruct believers to honor governing authorities, to pay taxes, to pray for rulers, and to live peaceably within the civic structures of their time. But the posture is always one of loving participation within a clear hierarchy of allegiance. God first. The church's mission first. The Kingdom of Heaven first. And then—within that order, subordinated to that ultimate loyalty—the responsibilities of earthly citizenship.

Civil religion inverts this hierarchy. It takes the secondary loyalty and wraps it in the language of the primary. It makes national identity feel covenantal. It makes patriotic devotion feel like worship. It makes the defense of the nation feel like the defense of the faith. And once that inversion is complete, the sojourner forgets he is a sojourner. The exile forgets she is an exile. And the earthly city begins to feel like the City of God.

Augustine warned against exactly this. In *The City of God*, he drew a sharp distinction between the *civitas Dei*—the City of God—and the

civitas terrena—the earthly city. Both exist simultaneously. Both make claims on the loyalty of their citizens. But they are not the same city. And the Christian's task is to live faithfully within the earthly city while never forgetting that it is not ultimate—that it is passing away, that its glories are temporary, and that no earthly nation, no matter how great, can satisfy the longing of a heart made for the Kingdom of God.

Civil religion collapses this distinction. It tells Christians that the earthly city and the City of God are, in America's case, functionally the same project. And that collapse is the foundation on which Christian nationalism is built.

The Cross and the Flag: A Fusion That Corrupts Both

When the cross and the flag become visually, emotionally, and theologically inseparable, both are corrupted.

The cross is corrupted because it is reduced from a universal symbol of God's self-giving love for the entire world to a tribal symbol of one nation's identity. The cross of Christ is for every people, every nation, every tribe, every tongue. It is the place where God reconciled the world to Himself, not the place where God endorsed a particular political project. When the cross is draped in a national flag—whether literally or emotionally—it loses its universality. It becomes the possession of one tribe. And the gospel it represents is heard by the rest of the world not as good news for all people but as the religious branding of a particular nation's power.

The flag is corrupted because it is elevated from a legitimate symbol of national identity to a sacred object that demands reverence rather than mere respect. A flag is a political symbol. It represents a nation's history, ideals, and common life. It deserves honor. It does not deserve worship. And when the emotional response to the flag

becomes indistinguishable from the emotional response to the cross—when disrespecting the flag feels like blasphemy—something has gone wrong not only theologically but patriotically. Because genuine patriotism includes the freedom to critique, to dissent, to hold the nation accountable to its own highest ideals. A flag that demands the reverence of a sacred object has become an idol—and idols, by their nature, cannot tolerate criticism.

The Exodus command is absolute:

"You shall have no other gods before me. You shall not make for yourself a carved image, or any likeness of anything that is in heaven above, or that is in the earth beneath, or that is in the water under the earth. You shall not bow down to them or serve them, for I the Lord your God am a jealous God." —Exodus 20:3–5

A "carved image" is not limited to a wooden statue. It is anything created—any thing, any institution, any nation, any symbol—that receives the devotion, the trust, and the emotional allegiance that belongs to God alone. When a nation becomes the object of that kind of devotion—when its preservation feels like the preservation of the faith, when its enemies feel like God's enemies, when its success feels like God's vindication—the nation has become a carved image. It has entered the space that belongs only to the Lord. And the Lord has made it clear that He does not share that space.

Answering the Objection: "But Wasn't America Founded on Christian Values?"

This is the most common objection raised whenever someone challenges the civil-religion narrative, and it deserves a careful, honest, non-dismissive answer.

The short answer is: yes, in part. And also: no, in part. And both parts matter.

Yes, Christian thought genuinely influenced the intellectual and moral foundations of the American experiment. The concept of human dignity rooted in the *imago Dei*—that every person is made in

the image of God and therefore possesses inherent, inalienable worth—shaped the Declaration of Independence's assertion that "all men are created equal" and are "endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights." The Reformation's emphasis on the authority of conscience before God contributed to the development of religious liberty. The Puritan work ethic, covenant theology, and emphasis on education shaped the cultural soil in which American institutions grew. To deny this influence is historically dishonest.

But the story is more complicated than the civil-religion version allows. The founders were not uniformly Christian. Some, like Samuel Adams and John Jay, were devout believers. Others, like Thomas Jefferson and Benjamin Franklin, were Deists who respected Christianity's moral structure while rejecting core doctrines like the divinity of Christ and the authority of Scripture. The founding documents are not Christian confessions. They are Enlightenment-era political documents that borrow selectively from Christian and classical sources. The God invoked in the Declaration is "Nature's God"—a deistic concept compatible with Christianity but not identical to the Triune God of the Nicene Creed.

More importantly, the nation that was founded on the principle that "all men are created equal" simultaneously enslaved millions of people made in the image of God. The nation that proclaimed "liberty and justice for all" systematically denied liberty and justice to Indigenous peoples, African Americans, women, and other marginalized groups for centuries. The providential narrative of American founding—the "city on a hill" story—is true only if you ignore the people standing in the hill's shadow.

This is not an attack on America. It is an insistence on telling the truth about America—the full truth, including the parts that complicate the sacred narrative. And it is precisely the kind of truth-telling that civil religion cannot tolerate, because civil religion depends on a simplified, sacralized version of national history that resists complication.

Christians, of all people, should be committed to telling the full truth—because the God we worship is a God of truth, and because the gospel itself is a story that refuses to hide the ugliness of human sin. The Bible does not sanitize Israel's history. It records David's adultery and murder. It exposes Solomon's idolatry. It narrates the injustices of Israel's kings in unflinching detail. The prophets loved Israel precisely by refusing to let Israel tell a flattering lie about itself.

If American Christians cannot bring the same honesty to American history—if we can only tell the story of the nation in hagiographic, providential terms—then we have adopted a standard of truth lower than the Bible's own standard. And that should concern us deeply.

So yes, Christian values influenced the founding. But the founding was also shaped by Enlightenment rationalism, by economic self-interest, by the brutal realities of slavery and colonialism, and by the complex, fallen humanity of the men who designed it. Acknowledging this does not diminish gratitude for the genuine goods the American experiment has produced. It simply refuses to confuse a political founding with a divine covenant.

Healthy Patriotism vs. Covenantal Confusion

The point of this chapter is not to destroy patriotism. It is to save it—from the idolatry that will eventually consume it.

There is a form of patriotism that is entirely compatible with Christian faithfulness. It looks like gratitude for the genuine goods of your nation—its freedoms, its ideals, its opportunities—without attributing those goods to a divine covenant that does not exist. It looks like working for the common good of your fellow citizens—pursuing justice, serving your neighbor, contributing to the health of your community—without treating the nation as the vehicle of God's redemptive purposes. It looks like loving your country the way you love your family: deeply, honestly, with open eyes about its flaws, and with the willingness to confront those flaws precisely because you love it too much to let it persist in self-deception.

This patriotism is modest. It does not claim divine favoritism. It does not treat national symbols as sacred objects. It does not panic when the nation's cultural influence wanes, because it does not confuse cultural influence with the Kingdom of God. It does not demand reverence—it earns respect. And it can hold a flag in one hand and a cross in the other without confusing which one is ultimate.

Covenantal confusion, by contrast, is patriotism that has crossed the line into theology. It is the belief—sometimes explicit, more often felt rather than articulated—that America's relationship with God is structurally analogous to Israel's. That God has made promises to this nation. That the nation's obedience brings blessing and its disobedience brings judgment—not in the general providential sense that applies to all nations, but in the specific, covenantal sense that applied uniquely to Israel in the Old Testament.

This confusion produces a distinctive set of spiritual pathologies:

It makes national decline feel like covenant judgment, which produces not repentance but rage. If America's cultural shifts are signs of divine displeasure, then the people responsible for those shifts are not merely political opponents—they are enemies of God. And you do not negotiate with enemies of God. You crush them. The covenantal logic turns political disagreement into holy war.

It makes patriotic devotion feel like spiritual obedience, which makes criticism of the nation feel like sin. If loving America is part of loving God, then questioning America's mythology is tantamount to questioning God's faithfulness. Dissent becomes heresy. Prophetic critique becomes betrayal. And the tradition of the prophets—who loved Israel enough to tell it the truth—is silenced in the name of a loyalty that God Himself never demanded.

It makes political engagement feel like spiritual warfare in the ultimate sense, which strips politics of its penultimacy and loads it with eschatological weight it cannot bear. If every election is a battle for God's covenant with America, then every election is ultimate. Every loss is catastrophic. Every opponent is demonic. And every

compromise is unthinkable—because you do not compromise in a holy war.

These pathologies are visible throughout the American church. They explain the apocalyptic tone of so much Christian political rhetoric. They explain the inability of many Christians to engage political opponents with any semblance of love or respect. They explain the fusion of political and spiritual identity that makes it impossible for some believers to distinguish between a threat to their party and a threat to their faith.

And they all flow from a single theological error: the belief that America is Israel.

It is not. And the sooner the American church accepts that, the sooner it can recover the freedom to be what it was always meant to be: a sojourning people, a heavenly-citizenized community, a body whose ultimate allegiance is to a King who transcends every nation—including this one.

The Freedom of a Church That Belongs to No Nation

When the church disentangles itself from civil religion—when it stops confusing the American project with the Kingdom of God—it does not lose something. It gains something extraordinary.

It gains the freedom to love America without worshiping it. A church that knows the difference between patriotism and idolatry can celebrate the genuine goods of the nation without sacralizing them, can serve the common good without treating the nation as ultimate, and can grieve the nation's failures without experiencing them as threats to the faith.

It gains the freedom to critique America without guilt. When national identity and spiritual identity are fused, criticism of the nation feels like apostasy. But when the church knows that its citizenship is in heaven, it can bring the full weight of prophetic truth to bear on the nation's sins—its racism, its materialism, its exploitation of the vulnerable—without fearing that it is betraying

God's covenant. Because God's covenant is with the church, not with the nation. And the church serves the nation best by telling it the truth.

It gains the freedom to welcome all nations. A church bound to one nation's identity is, by definition, alienating to people from other nations. But the church of Jesus Christ is, by design, transnational. Its doors are open to every tribe and tongue. Its gospel is for every people. Its Table has seats for every nation. And when the church is visibly and joyfully free from the entanglement of civil religion, it becomes what it was always meant to be: a preview of the Kingdom where every nation gathers before the throne of the Lamb.

It gains the freedom to endure any political outcome without despair. This is perhaps the most important freedom of all. A church that has confused its identity with a nation's fortunes is a church that will be destroyed by that nation's decline. But a church that knows it belongs to a Kingdom that cannot be shaken—a Kingdom secured not by elections but by resurrection—can face any political outcome with sorrow, yes, with concern, yes, but never with despair. Because despair is only possible when the thing you have lost is ultimate. And for the church of Jesus Christ, no nation is ultimate.

The writer of Hebrews knew this. He was writing to a community that was losing everything—social standing, economic security, political protection—and he said to them:

"Therefore let us be grateful for receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, and thus let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence and awe." —Hebrews 12:28

A kingdom that cannot be shaken. Not a nation that cannot be shaken—nations shake all the time. Not an empire that cannot fall—empires fall regularly. A kingdom—God's Kingdom—that is founded on something no political earthquake can touch.

That is the invitation. Not to stop caring about America. Not to abandon civic responsibility. Not to retreat into apolitical passivity. But to stop treating the American project as though it were the

Kingdom of God. To stop wrapping the cross in the flag. To stop borrowing sacred language for national purposes. And to trust that the God who has sustained His church through the fall of Rome, the splintering of Christendom, the rise and fall of empires, and the upheaval of every civilization in history is more than capable of sustaining it through whatever happens to the United States of America.

The church does not need a nation to survive.

The church needs a King.

And it already has one.

His name is Jesus. He is Lord. And His kingdom will have no end.

Let "Thy Kingdom Come" be the prayer of the church. And let "God Bless America" return to what it was always meant to be: a humble request, not a theological confession.

Key Takeaways

- Civil religion is a quasi-religious national narrative—complete with sacred history, sacred texts, rituals, prophets, and a core conviction of divine favor—that borrows the language and emotions of biblical faith and applies them to the nation.
- The danger of civil religion is not that it says false things but that it assigns sacred weight to national things—turning patriotic devotion into something that feels indistinguishable from worship.
- America is not Israel. No New Testament text assigns covenantal election to a modern nation-state. The "holy nation" of 1 Peter 2:9 is the church, not any country.
- Christians are "sojourners and exiles" (1 Peter 2:11) whose primary citizenship is in heaven (Philippians 3:20)—not people whose deepest identity is national.

- The cross-and-flag fusion corrupts both: the cross loses its universality and becomes a tribal symbol; the flag is elevated from a political symbol to a sacred object that cannot tolerate critique.

- Christian values genuinely influenced the American founding, but the

founding was also shaped by Enlightenment rationalism, economic self-interest, and the brutal realities of slavery—and telling the full truth is not anti-American but pro-truth.

- Covenantal confusion—the belief that America has an Israel-like covenant with God—produces spiritual pathologies: political disagreement becomes holy war, national decline feels like divine judgment, and patriotic devotion feels like obedience.

- A church disentangled from civil religion gains extraordinary freedom: to love without worshiping, to critique without guilt, to welcome all nations, and to endure any political outcome without despair.

Reflection Questions

1. When your church sings patriotic songs in worship, does the emotional register feel different from when you sing about Jesus? If not, what does that fusion reveal about how national identity and spiritual identity have merged?

2. Have you ever felt that criticizing America—its history, its policies, its cultural direction—was somehow an act of spiritual disloyalty? Where did that feeling come from, and is it supported by Scripture?

3. Can you distinguish, in your own heart, between healthy gratitude

for America's freedoms and a belief that America occupies a unique, covenantal place in God's redemptive plan? What would change if you let go of the second?

4. If America were no longer a majority-Christian nation—if

Christians were a small, culturally marginal minority—would your faith survive? Would your church's mission change? Should it?

5. Read 1 Peter 2:9–11 slowly. Does the language of "sojourner and

exile" describe how you actually feel in relation to your country? If not, what has made you feel more at home here than Peter thinks you should?

6. How would your political engagement change if you stopped believing

that America's future and the church's future are the same thing?

Practices

- Personal: For one month, pay attention to every time you hear or use

the words "chosen," "covenant," "providence," "redemption," or "sacrifice" in reference to America. Each time, ask: "Is this language being used in a way that the Bible actually supports, or is it borrowing sacred categories for national purposes?"

- Personal: Read 1 Peter 2:9–17 and Philippians 3:17–21 daily for two weeks. Journal each day on one question: "What does it mean, practically, that my primary citizenship is in heaven and not in America?"

- Family: At your next family gathering, ask: "What's the difference between being grateful for America and believing America has a special covenant with God? What changes if we let go of the second belief?" Let everyone speak without correcting.

- Church: Audit your church's worship for one month. Note every instance where national symbols, patriotic songs, or political rhetoric appear in the context of worship. Then ask your leadership team: "Are we clearly communicating the distinction between loving

our country and worshipping it? If a visitor from another nation attended our service, would they feel that the gospel is for them too—or would they feel they had walked into an American church rather than a Christian one?"

Sources & Notes

- Isaiah 42:8—"My glory I give to no other"—the divine jealousy that refuses to share sacred status with any created thing, including nations.
- Exodus 20:3–5—The first and second commandments: no other gods,
no carved images, no devotion given to created things.
- 1 Peter 2:9–11—The church as the "holy nation" and believers as "sojourners and exiles"—covenantal identity transferred from ethnic Israel to the transnational body of Christ.
- Philippians 3:20—"Our citizenship is in heaven"—the primary allegiance of the Christian, written to a Roman colony steeped in imperial identity.
- Hebrews 12:28—"A kingdom that cannot be shaken"—the unshakable
Kingdom as the basis for worship and confidence in the midst of earthly upheaval.
- Matthew 16:18—"The gates of hell shall not prevail against it"—Christ's promise that the church's survival depends on His power, not political protection.
- Robert Bellah, "Civil Religion in America" (Daedalus, 1967)—
The
foundational sociological analysis of America's quasi-religious national narrative.
- Augustine, *The City of God*, especially Books XIV–XIX—The distinction between the City of God and the earthly city, and the

danger of confusing the two.

- Mark Noll, *America's God: From Jonathan Edwards to Abraham Lincoln*

(Oxford, 2002)—On the complex interweaving of Christian theology and American national identity.

CHAPTER SIX

How Christian Nationalism Quietly Rewrites Doctrine

"The most dangerous heresies are not the ones that contradict the faith openly. They are the ones that rearrange it subtly—so that everything sounds right but nothing works the way it should."

'&

The Mutation No One Announced

Christian nationalism does not arrive with a heresy trial. It does not publish a revised creed. It does not convene a council and announce, "We have decided to alter the faith." It does something far more effective: it rearranges the weight of existing doctrines until the structure of the faith has shifted—while all the original vocabulary remains in place.

This is what makes it so difficult to confront and so easy to deny. If you ask a Christian nationalist whether Jesus is Lord, they will say yes. If you ask whether salvation is by grace through faith, they will affirm it. If you ask whether the Bible is authoritative, they will agree enthusiastically. The words have not changed. The doctrinal statements have not been revised. The confessions remain on the church's website, untouched.

But something has shifted underneath. The load-bearing walls of the faith have been quietly relocated. And the result is a structure that looks like historic Christianity from the outside but functions as something else entirely on the inside.

This chapter is about that shift. It is about how Christian nationalism—not as a conscious ideology but as an emotional and

cultural formation—quietly rewrites doctrine at multiple levels. Not by removing doctrines from the confession but by changing which doctrines matter most in the lived experience of the believer. Not by denying the faith but by reshaping its priorities until the faith serves a different master.

The mutation operates at four levels: eschatology, soteriology, ecclesiology, and ethics. Each of these is a foundational pillar of Christian theology. And each of them is being subtly but decisively altered by the gravitational pull of nationalist anxiety.

If that sounds like an overstatement, I ask only that you read carefully and test what follows against your own experience. Because the whole point of a quiet mutation is that it does not feel like a mutation. It feels like faithfulness.

Eschatology Rewritten: When the Horizon of Hope Shrinks

Eschatology is not merely about end-times charts and rapture theories. At its deepest level, eschatology answers the question: Where is history going, and what are we waiting for? It is about the shape of Christian hope—what we believe the future holds, what we believe God is doing in history, and what we believe will ultimately set things right.

Historic Christian eschatology is centered on the return of Christ. The final hope of the church is not a political arrangement, not a cultural golden age, not a restored civilization. It is the personal, visible, triumphant return of Jesus Christ, who will judge the living and the dead, make all things new, and establish a Kingdom that will have no end. That hope is what sustains the church through suffering, sustains it through marginalization, sustains it through every form of cultural loss—because the church's future is not contingent on history cooperating. It is contingent on Jesus keeping His promise.

Paul captured this in Philippians 3:20: "Our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ." The word "citizenship" is deliberately political. Paul is writing to a

Roman colony, to people who took enormous pride in their Roman citizenship. And he is saying: your ultimate political identity is not Roman. It is heavenly. Your deepest allegiance is not to the empire. It is to the returning King.

That does not mean Christians should be indifferent to the present. The New Testament is relentlessly practical about how believers should live in the here and now—serving neighbors, doing justice, caring for the poor, speaking truth. But the emotional center of gravity, the thing that anchors the soul when everything else shakes, is the return of Christ—not the return of a political majority.

Christian nationalism quietly rewrites this.

Under the gravitational pull of nationalist anxiety, the horizon of hope shrinks. It contracts from the cosmic to the national, from the eternal to the electoral. The decisive battle for the future is no longer the return of Christ but the next election. The decisive question is no longer "Will Jesus keep His promise?" but "Will our side win in November?" The emotional energy that should be directed toward "Watch and pray" gets redirected toward "Vote and panic."

This does not happen through a formal theological revision. No one announces, "We have decided that the return of Christ is no longer the center of our hope." It happens through emphasis, through emotional investment, through the slow migration of urgency from one horizon to another.

Consider the evidence. How much time does the average politically engaged Christian spend thinking about the return of Christ compared to the next election? How much emotional energy is directed toward eternal hope compared to political anxiety? When was the last time you heard a sermon on the second coming that produced more visible emotion in the congregation than a sermon touching on politics?

The answers to those questions reveal the rewrite. When the next election feels more urgent than the next advent—when political loss

produces more grief than spiritual complacency—eschatology has been functionally revised. The hope has shrunk. The horizon has contracted. And the result is a faith that cannot endure loss, because it has tied its sense of the future to something that can be taken away in a single Tuesday in November.

This is why fear-shaped Christianity produces believers who live in constant emergency. If your eschatology is centered on the return of Christ, you can suffer political loss without despair, because the decisive event in history has already happened (the resurrection) and the decisive event to come (the return) is guaranteed by the character of God, not by the competence of a political movement. But if your eschatology has been rewritten—if the decisive event is always the next election—then every loss is catastrophic, every setback is existential, and peace becomes impossible.

The emergency never ends. Because there is always another election. Always another threat. Always another crisis that demands total mobilization. And the soul that is formed by permanent emergency is a soul that cannot rest, cannot worship without distraction, cannot trust without visible evidence that "our side" is winning.

That is not Christian hope. That is political anxiety dressed in eschatological clothing. And it produces a people who, as Paul warned, are "without hope and without God in the world" (Ephesians 2:12)—not because they have stopped believing in God, but because they have functionally stopped hoping in Him.

Soteriology Rewritten: When Salvation Becomes National Restoration

Soteriology is the doctrine of salvation. It answers the most fundamental question in all of theology: How are sinful human beings made right with a holy God? And the historic Christian answer—the answer that runs from Paul through Augustine through Luther through the Reformers to the present day—is that salvation is accomplished by the atoning work of Jesus Christ on the cross and

received by grace through faith. It is not earned. It is not legislated. It is not achieved through cultural influence or political dominance. It is a gift, offered to sinners who have nothing to bring except their need.

Paul stated it with crystalline clarity: "For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast" (Ephesians 2:8–9).

Christian nationalism does not openly contradict this. No one stands in a pulpit and announces, "Salvation is actually by political victory." The vocabulary of grace remains. The language of the cross persists. The altar calls continue.

But listen carefully to the emotional language of the movement. Pay attention not to the doctrinal statements but to the actual rhetoric—the words that generate the most passion, the phrases that produce the most urgency, the sentences that people repeat to each other in moments of fear:

"We have to save the country."

"This is our last chance."

"If we don't win, we lose everything."

"Our children won't have a future."

"We need to take our country back."

Each of these sentences, taken individually, might express a legitimate concern. Policies do matter. Laws do shape cultures. The welfare of the next generation is a genuine responsibility.

But taken together, and heard as a system of meaning, something has shifted. The meaning of salvation has migrated. Salvation is no longer primarily about Christ saving sinners from the guilt and power of sin. It is about "our team" saving the nation from cultural collapse. Redemption is no longer a work of the Spirit through the proclaimed gospel. It is a project of cultural control through political

mobilization.

The cross becomes a symbol of "our people" rather than the instrument of God's atoning work for all people. Grace becomes a word we use in worship while our actual emotional life runs on the fuel of power. The gospel shifts from "Repent and believe" to "Panic and mobilize."

This is why Hosea remains so devastatingly relevant. Zannah is not atheism. It is supplementation. "God is good, but we need Egypt too." "Jesus saves, but we need Washington too." That is the logic. And the logic is so reasonable, so practical, so responsible-sounding that it never triggers the alarm systems that are designed to detect heresy. Because it is not a heresy of denial. It is a heresy of addition. It keeps everything and adds the one thing that changes everything: the belief that God's salvation is insufficient without political reinforcement.

The Reformers fought and died over the principle of *solus Christus*—Christ alone. Salvation is through Christ alone. Not Christ plus works. Not Christ plus the sacramental system. Not Christ plus human merit. Christ alone. And now, in a tragic irony, churches that proudly display the five *solas* on their walls are living as though salvation is Christ plus the right president, Christ plus the right Supreme Court, Christ plus the right cultural arrangement.

The *sola* has been quietly abandoned—not on the doctrinal statement, but in the emotional life of the congregation. And the emotional life of the congregation is where theology actually lives.

Ecclesiology Rewritten: When the Church Becomes a Political Caucus

Ecclesiology is the doctrine of the church—what the church is, what it is for, and how it relates to the surrounding culture. And here the mutation may be most visible, because it shows up not in abstract theology but in the lived experience of congregational life.

The New Testament describes the church with extraordinary language. The church is the body of Christ (1 Corinthians 12). It is

the temple of the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 3:16). It is the bride of Christ (Ephesians 5:25–27). It is a "holy nation" and a "royal priesthood" (1 Peter 2:9)—language that deliberately mirrors the terms God used for Old Testament Israel but applies them to a community defined not by ethnicity or geography but by faith in Jesus Christ.

The church is universal. It spans every nation, every language, every culture, and every political system. Paul insists in Galatians 3:28 that in Christ "there is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither slave nor free, there is no male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus." The deepest identity of the church is not national. It is baptismal. The church's unity is not found in shared citizenship but in shared confession: Jesus is Lord.

Christian nationalism rewrites this. It does not deny that the church is universal—not explicitly. But it functionally treats the American church as the church that matters most, American Christianity as the version of the faith that must be preserved at all costs, and the health of American political institutions as the precondition for the health of the global body of Christ.

The result is a church whose boundaries start to look less like baptism and more like voter registration. Where the question "Are you one of us?" is answered not by confession of faith but by political alignment. Where someone who shares your theology but not your politics feels less welcome than someone who shares your politics but could not articulate the gospel.

I have watched this happen in real congregations. I have watched churches where a visitor who expressed doubt about a political candidate was treated with more suspicion than a visitor who expressed doubt about the resurrection. I have watched congregations where the emotional bond between members was forged more by shared political outrage than by shared communion at the Lord's Table. I have watched small groups where the discussion of a political controversy generated more passion, more tears, and more

self-disclosure than any discussion of Scripture ever did.

When that happens, the church has not been destroyed. It has been replaced. The form remains—the building, the worship service, the name on the sign. But the substance has shifted. It is no longer the body of Christ gathered around Word and Sacrament. It is a political caucus that opens with a prayer.

And the most devastating consequence of this ecclesiological mutation is the loss of the church's prophetic independence. A church that has fused its identity with a political movement cannot prophetically critique that movement. It cannot hold its preferred leaders accountable, because accountability would feel like betrayal. It cannot speak truth to power, because it has become the chaplain of power. It cannot say "Thus says the Lord" to the nation, because it has confused the nation's interests with the Lord's purposes.

The Old Testament prophets were able to confront Israel precisely because they stood within the covenant community but outside the political establishment. Amos was a shepherd, not a court prophet. Jeremiah was persecuted by the very government he addressed. Elijah confronted Ahab at enormous personal cost. Their independence was the source of their authority. The moment the prophet becomes the king's chaplain, the prophetic voice dies—because you cannot challenge a system that you depend on for your position.

A church that has merged its identity with a political faction has voluntarily surrendered the most powerful tool in its arsenal: the freedom to say what God says, regardless of what the powerful want to hear.

Ethics Rewritten: When Character Becomes Optional

The final level of mutation is perhaps the most visible and the most damaging to the church's witness: the systematic erosion of moral consistency in the name of political expediency.

Christian ethics—rooted in the character of God revealed in Scripture and embodied in the life of Jesus Christ—has always

insisted that means matter as much as ends. The Bible does not merely ask what you are pursuing; it asks how you pursue it. The good and righteous God does not accept worship that comes through injustice (Amos 5:21–24). He does not bless victory achieved through dishonesty (Proverbs 12:22). He does not honor power maintained through cruelty (Micah 6:8). The method of the work matters to the God who is Himself the standard of the work.

Paul stated this with striking directness in Romans 3:8 when he confronted the idea that we might "do evil that good may come." His response was not a careful "well, it depends on the circumstances." It was condemnation: "Their condemnation is just."

Christian nationalism erodes this. Not by openly arguing that character does not matter—almost no one would say that in plain language. But by creating a system of moral reasoning in which character becomes subordinate to outcomes. In which the question "Is this person honest, kind, just, and self-controlled?" is replaced by the question "Will this person deliver the results we need?"

The mutation works like this: First, a legitimate threat is identified. Moral decline. Cultural hostility to Christianity. Legal threats to religious liberty. The erosion of institutions. The threat is real. No honest observer would deny it entirely.

Second, the threat is escalated to existential status. It is no longer merely a concerning trend. It is the end of everything. The survival of the church, the future of our children, the fate of civilization itself—all of it hangs in the balance.

Third, the existential stakes justify extraordinary measures. Because the threat is total, the response must be total. Normal moral constraints—honesty, consistency, kindness, fairness—become luxuries we cannot afford. We are at war. And in war, you do not stop to ask whether your general is a gentleman. You ask whether he can win.

And so character becomes optional. Dishonesty is reframed as

"fighting back." Cruelty is reframed as "strength." The dehumanization of opponents is reframed as "telling it like it is." Sexual misconduct is excused because "we're not electing a pastor." Corruption is tolerated because "at least he's on our side."

And the moral double standard becomes total. When our leader lies, it is strategy. When their leader lies, it is corruption. When our leader is cruel, it is strength. When their leader is cruel, it is tyranny. The standard is no longer the character of Christ. The standard is tribal loyalty. And tribal loyalty, once it becomes the governing ethical principle, will excuse anything—absolutely anything—that serves the tribe's interests.

This is not merely hypocrisy, though it certainly produces hypocrisy. It is a doctrinal mutation at the level of ethics. It is the functional abandonment of the principle that God cares about how things are done, not merely whether they are accomplished. It is the replacement of Christian moral reasoning—which holds that certain actions are wrong regardless of the outcome—with consequentialist reasoning, which holds that the outcome justifies the means.

And the church has been here before. Every historical moment in which the church has aligned itself with unjust power—the Crusades, the Inquisition, the defense of slavery, the silence during the Holocaust—was defended by exactly this logic: the stakes are too high for moral purity. We cannot afford to be principled right now. The ends justify the means.

And every single time, history has delivered the same verdict: the church that trades its moral integrity for political protection does not preserve itself. It loses itself. And the damage takes generations to repair.

The Colossians Corrective: The Christ Who Holds All Things Together

If Christian nationalism quietly dismantles the architecture of the faith, the antidote is not merely political disengagement. The antidote

is theological reconstruction—a return to the Christ who is, as Paul writes in Colossians, the one in whom "all things hold together" (Colossians 1:17).

Colossians 1:15–20 is one of the most comprehensive statements about the identity and supremacy of Jesus Christ in the entire New Testament. And it is written to a church that is in danger of supplementing Christ—adding other spiritual powers, other sources of security, other mediators between themselves and God. The parallel to our situation is striking.

Paul writes: "He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation. For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities—all things were created through him and for him. And he is before all things, and in him all things hold together" (Colossians 1:15–17).

Notice the political language: thrones, dominions, rulers, authorities. Paul is not speaking abstractly. He is naming the very structures of political power that his readers might be tempted to fear or to trust. And he is saying: Christ created them. Christ precedes them. Christ sustains them. And Christ will outlast them. They are real, but they are not ultimate. They have a place in God's ordering of the world, but that place is subordinate to the one in whom all things hold together.

And then the passage reaches its climax: "And he is the head of the body, the church. He is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead, that in everything he might be preeminent. For in him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross" (Colossians 1:18–20).

In everything he might be preeminent. That is the corrective. Not merely that Christ is important—everyone in the church will affirm that. But that Christ is preeminent. First. Central. Supreme. Not one voice among many. Not one source of security among several. Not

one factor in the equation alongside political power, cultural influence, and legislative strategy. Preeminent. In everything.

The question Christian nationalism forces upon us is whether we actually believe that. Not whether we can affirm it in a doctrinal statement. But whether we live as though it is true. Whether the preeminence of Christ is the functional operating principle of our lives—or whether it is a theological conviction that we hold in theory while our actual decisions, emotions, and allegiances are governed by something else.

Because if Christ is truly preeminent, then no political loss can ultimately threaten us. If Christ truly holds all things together, then the fraying of our preferred cultural arrangement is not the unraveling of reality. If the fullness of God dwells in Christ, then we do not need to find that fullness in a political movement, a cultural institution, or a national identity.

Colossians does not say politics is irrelevant. But it says politics is penultimate. It says the thrones and authorities that feel so powerful, so permanent, so decisive are themselves creatures—made by Christ, sustained by Christ, and accountable to Christ. They will serve their purpose and pass away. And Christ will remain.

A church that has internalized the Colossians vision of Christ does not need Christian nationalism. It does not need the nation to be "Christian" in order to maintain its faith. It does not need political power to feel secure. It does not need cultural dominance to be confident. It has something better. It has a Lord in whom all things hold together—including the things that feel like they are falling apart.

Answering the Objection: "You're Exaggerating"

This is the most common objection I receive, and it deserves a thoughtful response. Because the critic has a point: most Christians who hold nationalist-adjacent views are not consciously rewriting doctrine. They are not sitting in their living rooms thinking, "Today I

will revise my eschatology and subordinate my soteriology to a political agenda." They are sincere. They love Jesus. They are afraid. And they are trying to be responsible in a world that feels increasingly hostile to their faith.

I do not doubt their sincerity. I question the formation.

Because the entire argument of this chapter is that doctrinal mutation does not require conscious intent. It requires only sustained exposure to a narrative that rearranges priorities without announcing the rearrangement. And the narrative of Christian nationalism—that America is uniquely chosen, that political power is the primary means of preserving the faith, that the right leader can restore what has been lost, that the survival of the church depends on the survival of a particular political arrangement—is powerful enough to reshape the soul of a believer without that believer ever realizing what has happened.

Think of it this way. If you immerse yourself in political media for three hours a day and Scripture for fifteen minutes, your soul is being formed primarily by the political media—not because you have chosen to prioritize it theologically, but because formation follows attention. The narrative you spend the most time inhabiting is the narrative that will shape your reflexes, your emotional responses, your instinctive reactions to threat. And if that narrative is one of permanent crisis, existential stakes, and political salvation, then your theology will slowly, silently conform to it—even if your doctrinal statement remains unchanged.

James K. A. Smith has argued persuasively that human beings are shaped more by their practices than by their propositions—more by what they do habitually than by what they believe intellectually. We are, in his phrase, "loving animals" before we are "thinking animals," and our loves are formed by the rituals, habits, and narratives that we inhabit every day.

If that is true—and I believe both Scripture and experience confirm that it is—then the question is not merely "What do you

believe about salvation?" but "What narrative is forming your affections?" Not merely "What is your eschatology?" but "What does your emotional life reveal about where your hope actually resides?"

So no, I am not exaggerating. I am describing a formation that is happening in plain sight—in churches, on social media, at kitchen tables, in the anxious prayers of believers who love God and are terrified of what they see happening in their country. The formation is real. Its effects are measurable. And its consequences are devastating.

But let me be equally clear: the diagnosis is not a condemnation. It is an invitation. Because the same God who named Israel's adultery in Hosea also invited Israel home. The same Christ who rebuked Peter for promoting a theology of power also restored Peter after his denial. The same Spirit who reveals our idolatry also empowers our repentance.

The mutation can be reversed. The doctrine can be recovered. The heart can come home. But only if we are willing to name what has happened—honestly, specifically, and without self-protective rationalization.

Signs Your Theology Has Been Fear-Edited

As a practical tool for self-examination—not for condemning others, but for honest personal inventory—consider these diagnostic questions. They are designed not to produce guilt but to produce clarity. And clarity, as we have said before, is the first gift of repentance.

Does the return of Christ feel less urgent to you than the next election? If the second coming produces less emotional response in you than a midterm result, your eschatology has been rewritten. The church that lives in the light of Christ's return is a church that can endure any political season. The church that lives in the shadow of the next election is a church that will be consumed by every one.

Do you speak about "saving the country" with more passion than you speak about the gospel saving sinners? Listen to your own

language. Not the language you use in church on Sunday morning, but the language you use in conversation, on social media, at the dinner table. Where is the urgency? Where is the fire? If national salvation has more emotional weight than personal salvation, the center has shifted.

Has your view of political opponents moved from "neighbor" to "enemy" to "subhuman"? Fear always dehumanizes. It starts by making the other side wrong. Then it makes them dangerous. Then it makes them evil. And finally, it makes them less than human—objects of contempt rather than bearers of the image of God. If your political engagement has taken you on that trajectory, fear has rewritten your anthropology. You no longer believe, in practice, that every person is made in God's image. You believe that the people on your side are made in God's image, and the people on the other side are obstacles to be defeated.

Can you name a political position you hold that you adopted from your tribe rather than derived from Scripture? This is not a trick question. It is an honesty question. All of us have political positions that we inherited from our cultural context rather than discovered through careful biblical reflection. The test of spiritual maturity is whether we are willing to hold those positions up to the light of Scripture and allow them to be corrected—or whether we have so fused our tribal identity with our faith that the very idea of reexamination feels threatening.

Would your faith survive the complete loss of political power? This is the ultimate question. If every law went against you. If every court ruled contrary to your convictions. If every cultural institution marginalized your voice. If the political project you have invested in collapsed entirely—would your faith in Jesus Christ survive? Would your hope endure? Would your worship continue? Would you still believe that the tomb is empty and the King is coming? If the answer is yes, your faith is in Christ. If the answer is uncertain, something else has been bearing the weight that only Christ should carry.

The Way Forward: Theological Reformation, Not Political Withdrawal

The answer to doctrinal mutation is not political withdrawal. It is theological reformation. The answer is not to stop caring about the world but to start caring about it from the right center—from the preeminence of Christ rather than the supremacy of a political project.

Reformation begins with what the Reformers themselves insisted on: a return to Scripture as the ultimate authority. Not Scripture as filtered through the priorities of Fox News or MSNBC. Not Scripture as curated by a political movement. Not the verses that support your policy preferences while the uncomfortable ones are quietly set aside. Scripture—the whole counsel of God—read honestly, in community, with a willingness to be corrected.

Reformation continues with the recovery of worship as the church's primary political act. When the church gathers to confess that Jesus is Lord, to break bread in remembrance of His death and resurrection, to sing the story of God's faithfulness, to pray for enemies and rulers alike—that is not a retreat from politics. It is the most subversive political act imaginable. It is the declaration that there is a King whose authority supersedes every earthly government, and that this King's people are formed by His story, not by the story the culture is telling.

Reformation means recovering the church's prophetic independence—the freedom to speak truth to every political faction, including the one that many of its members support. A church that cannot criticize its own party is a church that has lost its voice. A church that reserves prophetic speech only for the other side has become a propaganda arm, not a prophetic community. The test of genuine prophetic courage is not whether you can challenge your opponents. That is easy. The test is whether you can challenge your allies. That is costly. And it is precisely the cost that gives the prophetic word its authority.

And reformation means rebuilding the practices that form the soul

around Christ rather than around anxiety. Prayer. Scripture. Sabbath. Fasting. Silence. Confession. Communion. These are the practices that anchor the church's identity in something deeper than the news cycle. They are the spiritual disciplines that create the kind of people who can engage politics without being consumed by it—who can care about the world without making the world their god.

The mutation is real. But the cure is available. And the cure is not a new political strategy. It is an old theological conviction, recovered with fresh urgency:

In Christ all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell. And that fullness is enough.

Key Takeaways

- Christian nationalism does not openly deny doctrine—it rearranges the weight of existing doctrines until the faith's functional center shifts from Christ to political outcomes.
- Eschatology is rewritten when the horizon of hope shrinks from the return of Christ to the next election, producing believers who live in permanent emergency rather than resurrection confidence.
- Soteriology is rewritten when the emotional language of salvation migrates from "Christ saves sinners" to "our side saves the nation"—supplementation, not denial.
- Ecclesiology is rewritten when the church's boundaries begin to track political alignment rather than baptismal confession, and the church loses its prophetic independence.
- Ethics are rewritten when character becomes subordinate to outcomes and the moral double standard of tribal loyalty replaces the consistent standard of Christ's character.
- Colossians 1:15–20 provides the corrective: Christ is preeminent over every throne, dominion, ruler, and authority—they are penultimate; He alone holds all things together.
- Doctrinal mutation does not require conscious intent—it requires only sustained formation by a narrative of political crisis that slowly reshapes priorities without announcing the change.
- The cure is not political withdrawal but theological reformation: a return to Scripture, the recovery of worship as the church's primary political act, and the rebuilding of spiritual practices that anchor identity in Christ.

political anxiety has displaced confidence in Christ. • Family: At a family meal this week, ask each person: "If our preferred political party lost every election for the next twenty years, what would our faith look like? What would change? What should not change?" Listen without correcting. Notice where the conversation reveals assumptions about what preserves the church. • Church: Propose a study, sermon series, or small-group conversation on the question: "How do we know when our theology has been shaped more by our political formation than by Scripture?" Include specific diagnostic questions for eschatology, soteriology, ecclesiology, and ethics. Apply the questions to both the political right and the political left.

Sources & Notes

Colossians 1:15–20—The supremacy of Christ over all thrones, dominions, rulers, and authorities, and the reconciliation of all things through the blood of His cross. Philippians 3:20—"Our citizenship is in heaven"—the political language of ultimate allegiance directed away from the earthly city. Ephesians 2:8–9—Salvation by grace through faith, not by works—the principle that Christian nationalism functionally undermines by supplementing Christ with political power. Romans 3:8—Paul's rejection of ends-justify-means reasoning: "Why not do evil that good may come?" Amos 5:21–24—God's rejection of worship that is divorced from justice and integrity. James K. A. Smith, *Desiring the Kingdom* (Baker Academic, 2009)—On how practices and habits form loves and identity more than intellectual propositions do. Andrew Whitehead and Samuel Perry, *Taking America Back for God* (Oxford, 2020)—Sociological research on Christian nationalism as a documented cultural phenomenon distinct from religious devotion. Tim Keller, *Counterfeit Gods* (Dutton, 2009)—On the mechanism by which good things become ultimate things and the diagnostic markers of functional idolatry.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Constantine's Bargain: Protection and Its Price

"The church that gains the world's protection often loses the ability to challenge the world's assumptions."

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The Day Everything Changed

In 313 AD, the Emperor Constantine issued the Edict of Milan, and Christianity's relationship with political power was permanently altered.

Before that edict, to be a Christian was to accept a cost. It meant potential exclusion from civic life. It meant economic disadvantage. It meant social suspicion. It could mean imprisonment. In some periods and some places, it meant death. The early church did not grow because it was convenient or culturally advantageous to be a Christian. It grew because the gospel was so compelling, and the community it produced was so visibly different, that people were willing to risk everything to be part of it.

And then, almost overnight, the entire calculus changed.

Constantine did not merely tolerate Christianity. He favored it. He returned confiscated property to the churches. He exempted clergy from certain taxes and civic duties. He funded church construction. He convened the Council of Nicaea in 325 to resolve theological disputes—with imperial authority backing the proceedings. Within a generation, Christianity moved from the margins to the center of Roman life. By 380 AD, under Emperor Theodosius I, Nicene Christianity became the official religion of the Roman Empire.

For many believers, this felt like vindication. After centuries of suffering, God had finally delivered His people. The prayers of the martyrs had been answered. The church had endured the furnace, and now it was being crowned.

And in many ways, the shift was genuinely good. Persecution ended. The Scriptures could be copied and distributed without fear. Churches could be built openly. Theological councils could meet to clarify doctrine. The gospel could be preached without the constant threat of violence. Hospitals, orphanages, and charitable institutions could be established with public support. The dignity of the human person—an idea the church championed in a world that discarded the weak—began to reshape Roman law.

These were not small things. They were real blessings. And anyone who tells you that Constantine simply "ruined" Christianity in one stroke is offering lazy history and bad theology. God is sovereign over emperors, and the Constantinian moment produced genuine goods that the church should acknowledge with gratitude.

But there was a price.

And the price was so subtle, so gradual, and so wrapped in the language of blessing that it took centuries to fully understand what had been lost.

What Changed When the Church Gained Power

The most important thing that changed was not a doctrine. It was a posture.

When the church was persecuted, it had to rely on spiritual authority. Its leaders were formed in prayer, courage, and suffering. Its community was purified by cost. Hypocrisy was expensive—you did not join a persecuted church for social advantage. The people who gathered for worship in catacombs and house churches did so because they genuinely believed that Jesus was risen, that His kingdom was real, and that His lordship was worth more than their comfort, their careers, and their lives.

That is a particular kind of church. It is lean. It is courageous. It is free—free from the need to please the powerful, free from the fear of losing cultural standing, free from the temptation to confuse the Kingdom of God with the stability of any earthly empire.

When the church became privileged, something shifted at the deepest level of its instincts. It began to rely not on spiritual authority but on institutional authority. It began to assume cultural centrality. It began to fear losing access. It began to make decisions not solely around truth and faithfulness but around stability, influence, and the preservation of its protected position.

This shift did not happen all at once. It happened gradually, almost imperceptibly, the way a person who moves from a small apartment into a mansion slowly begins to feel entitled to the space. At first, the mansion feels like an extraordinary gift. Then it feels normal. Then it feels necessary. And eventually, the thought of returning to the apartment feels not just uncomfortable but threatening—as though the apartment were a punishment rather than the place where your character was formed.

The church's social location changed. And when your social location changes, your instincts change with it.

A church that is out of power asks, "How do we remain faithful?" A church that is in power asks, "How do we remain in power?" Those are very different questions. And they produce very different communities.

The Cross Moves from Shame to Symbol of Empire

Nothing illustrates the shift more vividly than what happened to the cross.

In the first three centuries, the cross was a sign of shame, suffering, and self-giving love. It was the instrument Rome used to execute slaves, rebels, and criminals. To say "Jesus is Lord" while pointing to a cross was to make the most counterintuitive claim in the ancient world: that God's power was revealed not through military

conquest but through voluntary suffering. That the King of the universe had submitted Himself to the empire's most humiliating punishment—and that this submission, not Rome's armies, was the true power that would reshape the world.

The cross was the great inversion. Rome said power flows from the top down. The cross said power flows from the bottom up. Rome said the strong dominate the weak. The cross said the Strong One chose to become weak so that the weak could be made strong. Rome said the cross was defeat. The resurrection said the cross was victory.

And then Constantine put the cross on his soldiers' shields.

According to tradition, before the Battle of Milvian Bridge in 312, Constantine saw a vision of the cross with the words *In hoc signo vinces*—"In this sign, conquer." He ordered the Christian symbol painted on his soldiers' shields, won the battle, and attributed his victory to the Christian God.

Set aside the question of whether the vision was genuine. Focus instead on what happened to the meaning of the cross.

The cross—the instrument of voluntary suffering, the sign of power made perfect in weakness—became a military emblem. A tool of conquest. A symbol painted on shields and carried into battle. The sign that once said "God conquers through self-giving love" now said "God conquers through our army."

The theological implications are staggering. When the cross becomes a symbol of imperial victory rather than sacrificial love, the entire grammar of Christian faith is altered. The church that carried the cross as a sign of its willingness to suffer now carried the cross as a sign of its power to dominate. The church that had been crucified with Christ now crucified in the name of Christ.

This is not a minor aesthetic shift. It is a theological revolution—one that quietly reversed the meaning of the very event at the center of the Christian faith.

The Structural Problem: When the Church's Stability Depends on the Empire's Stability

Here is where Constantine's bargain becomes most relevant to our present moment.

Once the church's institutional stability became tied to the empire's stability, a new and devastating logic took hold: threats to the empire became threats to the church.

This sounds abstract, so let me make it concrete.

Before Constantine, if Rome fell, the church would grieve for the suffering of its neighbors—but it would not grieve for the loss of its own position, because the church had no privileged position to lose. The church's life came from the risen Christ, not from Roman favor. The church could function under any emperor, any regime, any political arrangement, because its vitality was not contingent on its cultural standing.

After Constantine, the church had buildings funded by the state, clergy exempted from taxes, theological councils backed by imperial authority, and a social position that depended on the ongoing favor of political power. Lose the emperor's favor, and you lose your tax exemptions, your buildings, your influence, your legal protections.

And once you have something to lose, your relationship to power fundamentally changes.

The church that has nothing to lose can speak truth without calculation. It can confront the emperor to his face, as Ambrose of Milan confronted Theodosius after the massacre at Thessalonica, because even if the confrontation costs everything, the church's survival does not depend on the emperor's goodwill.

But the church that has everything to lose—buildings, budgets, cultural influence, legal protections, tax-exempt status, access to power—begins to calculate. It begins to ask not only "What is true?" but "What can we afford to say?" It begins to weigh prophetic

faithfulness against institutional survival. And when those two considerations conflict—as they inevitably will—the church that is tied to power will almost always choose survival over truth.

Not because the leaders are wicked. Not because they have consciously chosen cowardice. But because the structural incentives of privilege push toward compliance. When your position depends on the favor of the powerful, you develop an instinct for saying what the powerful want to hear. You may not even notice it happening. But the prophetic edge dulls. The challenging sermon becomes the safe sermon. The hard truth becomes the convenient truth. The church that once said "Thus says the Lord" to the face of the empire begins to say "Thus says the Lord" only when the Lord happens to agree with the empire's agenda.

That is Constantine's bargain. Protection in exchange for compliance. Privilege in exchange for silence. A seat at the table in exchange for not disrupting the meal.

And the most insidious feature of the bargain is that it never feels like a bargain at all. It feels like blessing.

1 Samuel 8 Revisited: Protection as Judgment

We examined 1 Samuel 8 in Chapter Two, but this passage demands a second look in the context of Constantine's bargain, because the structural dynamic is identical.

Israel demands a king. Not because they have rejected God intellectually. Not because they have embraced paganism. But because they are afraid. The Philistines are a real threat. Samuel's sons are corrupt. The nation feels vulnerable. And so the elders come to Samuel and say, "Appoint for us a king to judge us like all the nations" (1 Samuel 8:5).

God's interpretation of this request is devastating: "They have not rejected you, but they have rejected me from being king over them" (1 Samuel 8:7).

The request for a visible, powerful, human protector—even a legitimate one, even one that God Himself will eventually work through—is identified as a rejection of God's invisible kingship. Not because political leadership is inherently evil. But because the motivation is fear-driven replacement of divine trust with human security.

And then God grants the request—but not as a straightforward blessing. He grants it as a judgment. He gives them what they asked for. And what they asked for eventually consumes them.

The parallel to the Constantinian moment is striking. The early church did not need imperial protection to thrive. It had thrived under persecution. It had grown precisely because it was not aligned with power, because its moral authority came from its willingness to suffer, because the community it produced was so compelling that people joined it despite the cost.

And then the church asked for a king like the nations. It accepted imperial favor. It received protection. And over time, the protection reshaped the church's character. The church that had been purified by suffering became softened by comfort. The church that had been sharpened by opposition became dulled by alliance. The church that had spoken truth to power became power's chaplain.

God granted the request. And the gift, over centuries, revealed itself to contain a cost that the church is still paying.

The Medieval Entanglement: When Church and State Became Inseparable

The Constantinian settlement did not remain static. It deepened over centuries into what historians call Christendom—the complete intertwining of church and state that characterized medieval Europe.

In Christendom, the church crowned emperors and emperors enforced theological orthodoxy. The pope claimed authority over kings, and kings claimed divine sanction for their wars. Heresy was not merely a theological error; it was a crime against the state.

Dissent was not merely a spiritual concern; it was a political threat. The sword served the altar, and the altar blessed the sword.

The results were complex. On one hand, Christendom produced extraordinary goods: the preservation of learning, the building of universities, the development of hospitals, the cultivation of art and architecture that still takes the breath away. The claim that Christendom was simply a dark age of religious tyranny is historically illiterate.

But on the other hand, the fusion of church and state produced a Christianity that could not distinguish between serving Christ and serving the empire. When the Crusaders marched to Jerusalem under the sign of the cross, they believed they were serving the Lord. When the Inquisition tortured suspected heretics, it believed it was protecting the faith. When European colonizers subjugated indigenous peoples while planting crosses, they believed they were advancing the Kingdom of God.

The tragedy is not that these were evil people doing evil things. Many of them were sincere believers acting according to the logic of a system that had fused spiritual authority with coercive power. They could not see what they were doing because the fusion had become so total that the distinction between God's work and the empire's work had disappeared.

That is the ultimate cost of Constantine's bargain. Not that it produces consciously wicked Christians, but that it produces Christians who can no longer tell the difference between the Kingdom of God and the kingdom they happen to inhabit. When the fusion is complete, every act of national self-interest can be baptized as divine will. Every war can be a holy war. Every policy can be "God's plan." And the cross—the sign of self-giving love—becomes a weapon.

The Reformation: A Partial Break

The Protestant Reformation challenged aspects of the medieval

arrangement, but it did not overthrow the Constantinian instinct.

Luther depended on German princes for protection. Without Frederick the Wise, the Elector of Saxony, Luther would likely have been executed as a heretic. Luther's survival—and the survival of the Reformation—depended on political patronage. And that dependence shaped Luther's political theology in ways that had long-lasting consequences. His doctrine of the two kingdoms provided a theological framework for distinguishing spiritual and temporal authority, but in practice, the Lutheran churches became deeply intertwined with the German state—a fact that would have devastating consequences in the twentieth century.

Calvin worked to shape civic structures in Geneva, building what many have called a "holy commonwealth." His vision was not a theocracy in the crude sense—Calvin insisted on the distinction between civil and ecclesiastical authority. But Geneva's experiment demonstrated the gravitational pull of the Constantinian instinct: when the church has access to civic power, it is extraordinarily difficult to resist the temptation to use that power to enforce conformity.

The Church of England was a state church by design. The monarch was the head of the church. Political and ecclesiastical authority were structurally fused in a way that made prophetic critique of the state all but impossible from within the established church.

The Reformation produced extraordinary theological gains—the recovery of justification by faith, the authority of Scripture, the priesthood of all believers. But on the question of the church's relationship to political power, the Reformers largely replicated the Constantinian arrangement in Protestant form. The church remained tied to the state. And the instinct—the deep, structural instinct to depend on political protection for the church's survival—remained intact.

The American Experiment: A New Arrangement, an Old Instinct

When European Christians came to America, they brought the Constantinian instinct with them. But the American arrangement was genuinely different—at least on paper.

The First Amendment formally separated church and state in a way that was revolutionary for its time: "Congress shall make no law respecting an establishment of religion, or prohibiting the free exercise thereof." No state church. No official denomination. No religious test for public office. The government would neither sponsor nor suppress religion.

This was, in many ways, a gift to the church. The separation meant that the church's authority would have to be earned, not imposed. It meant that Christianity would have to persuade rather than coerce. It meant that the church's growth would depend on the power of the gospel and the quality of its community rather than on legal compulsion.

And for much of American history, the church thrived under this arrangement. The great revivals that shaped American Protestantism—the First Great Awakening under Edwards and Whitefield, the Second Great Awakening, the explosive growth of evangelical Christianity in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries—were not produced by legislation. They were produced by preaching, prayer, and the mysterious work of the Holy Spirit. The church grew not because it had political access but because it had spiritual authority.

But the Constantinian instinct persisted beneath the surface. While the First Amendment separated church and state institutionally, the cultural assumption that America was a "Christian nation" remained deeply embedded. The structures were separated, but the hearts were still entangled.

For as long as American culture broadly aligned with Christian values—as long as the Ten Commandments hung in courtrooms, as long as prayer was expected in public schools, as long as Christian moral assumptions shaped the legal and cultural reality—the entanglement was invisible. You could not see the dependency

because you did not need to. The chariot and the faith were moving in the same direction. There was no friction.

But when American culture began to shift—when prayer was removed from public schools, when the sexual revolution reshaped social norms, when secularization accelerated, when Christianity moved from cultural majority to cultural contest—the dependency was suddenly exposed.

And the church panicked.

Not because the gospel was threatened. The gospel cannot be threatened by a Supreme Court decision. Not because the Spirit had been quenched. The Spirit does not require cultural privilege to do His work. But because the cultural position the church had grown accustomed to—the comfortable assumption that America and Christianity were naturally allied—was eroding.

And the panic revealed the truth: the church's confidence had been resting not on the resurrection but on cultural privilege. Not on Christ but on Constantine's bargain—the American version.

The buildings were different. The emperors wore different clothes. But the bargain was the same: protection in exchange for alignment. Privilege in exchange for usefulness. A seat at the table in exchange for not upsetting the arrangement.

And now that the arrangement is changing, we are discovering how deeply we depended on it.

Answering the Objection: "Isn't Political Favor a Blessing?"

At this point, someone will push back: "But God does bless nations through favorable governance. Isn't it a good thing when rulers support the church? Wasn't Constantine's conversion an answer to prayer? Isn't it right to thank God when political conditions are favorable to the gospel?"

Yes. Absolutely.

It is a good thing when governments protect religious liberty. It is a good thing when laws reflect justice. It is a good thing when rulers support the common good. Paul instructs Timothy to pray for kings and all who are in authority, "that we may lead a peaceful and quiet life, godly and dignified in every way" (1 Timothy 2:2). Favorable governance is something to pray for and be grateful for.

But there is a vast difference between receiving a blessing and depending on it.

The Israelites in the wilderness received manna every morning. It was a gift. It was provision. It was grace. But if they tried to hoard it—if they tried to stockpile it out of fear that God might not provide tomorrow—it rotted (Exodus 16:20). The gift was meant to be received daily, with open hands and trust. The moment they tried to secure it, to guarantee it, to make it permanent, it became a source of decay.

Political favor is like manna. When it comes, receive it gratefully. Use it wisely. Steward it for the good of your neighbor and the advance of justice. But do not hoard it. Do not build your identity around it. Do not let it become the foundation of your confidence. Because it can be taken away. And if your faith cannot survive without it, then your faith was never in the God who provides—it was in the provision itself.

The question is not whether political favor is a blessing. The question is whether you can flourish without it.

Can your church worship with joy if the tax exemptions are revoked? Can your community maintain its mission if the cultural wind turns hostile? Can your faith remain steady if the government is indifferent—or even opposed—to your convictions?

If the answer is yes, then political favor is being held with open hands. It is a gift received, not a god worshiped.

If the answer is no—if the loss of political favor would feel like the loss of the faith—then Constantine's bargain has done its work.

The church has become dependent on the very thing it was never meant to need.

How to Live Without Privilege—and Without Bitterness

So what does it look like for the American church to disentangle from Constantine's bargain? What does it look like to hold political favor with open hands? What does it look like to be the church without cultural privilege?

It does not look like bitterness. The church that has lost privilege and responds with resentment, victimhood, and nostalgia for a vanished golden age has not actually escaped the bargain. It is still defined by the privilege—it has simply moved from enjoying it to mourning it. The emotional center has not changed. The church is still oriented around cultural power rather than around Christ.

It does not look like withdrawal. The church that responds to cultural marginalization by retreating into isolation, building walls around its community, and refusing to engage the public square has confused faithfulness with fear. The early church did not withdraw from Roman society. It participated in it—paying taxes, serving neighbors, praying for rulers—while refusing to grant Rome ultimate status. Engagement without ultimacy is the model, not retreat.

It looks like the rediscovery of the church's original power source.

The early church did not have tax exemptions. It did not have political access. It did not have cultural centrality. It did not have legal protections. It did not have buildings, budgets, or media platforms.

What it had was the Holy Spirit.

What it had was a community of believers whose love for one another was so visible, so radical, and so countercultural that the watching world could not explain it.

What it had was a message so powerful that it turned the Roman Empire upside down—not through political maneuvering but through

proclamation, service, and the willingness to suffer.

What it had was a crucified and risen Lord whose resurrection guaranteed that no earthly power—not Rome, not Nero, not the gates of hell—could ultimately prevail against it.

That is still what the church has. None of it depends on political favor. None of it requires cultural privilege. None of it can be granted or revoked by any government on earth.

The question is whether we believe it.

Because if we genuinely believe that the Holy Spirit is sufficient—that the gospel is powerful enough, that the community of Christ is compelling enough, that the resurrection is real enough—then the loss of cultural privilege is not a crisis. It is a clarification. It strips away the scaffolding and reveals whether the building can stand on its own.

And the church of Jesus Christ can stand on its own. It has always been able to stand on its own. It was designed to stand on its own. It was born in a manger, grew under persecution, and conquered the most powerful empire in history without a single political alliance.

We do not need Constantine's bargain.

We need the Spirit of the living God.

And the Spirit has never needed an emperor's permission to do His work.

Key Takeaways

- Constantine's Edict of Milan (313 AD) produced genuine goods—the

end of persecution, the freedom to build churches, the ability to convene theological councils—but it also initiated a structural shift that changed the church's instincts about power.

- When the church gained privilege, it moved from relying on spiritual

authority to relying on institutional authority—and began to fear losing access more than losing faithfulness.

- The cross—once a sign of voluntary suffering and self-giving love—was placed on soldiers' shields, transforming its meaning from divine weakness into imperial conquest.

- The most dangerous structural consequence of Constantine's bargain

is this: once the church's stability depends on the empire's stability, threats to the empire become threats to the church—and defending the state becomes "defending the faith."

- The Reformation challenged medieval Christendom theologically but

largely replicated the Constantinian arrangement in Protestant form—Luther depended on princes, Calvin shaped Geneva, the Church of England fused crown and church.

- America's First Amendment separated church and state institutionally, but the cultural assumption that America was a "Christian nation" kept the Constantinian instinct alive beneath the surface.

- Political favor is like manna: receive it gratefully, steward it wisely, but do not hoard it or build your identity around it—because if your faith cannot survive without it, your faith was in the provision, not the Provider.

- The church was born without political privilege, grew without it, and conquered the Roman Empire without it. The Spirit has never needed an emperor's permission to do His work.

Reflection Questions

1. If your church lost its tax-exempt status tomorrow, how would your

congregation respond? Would it feel like an inconvenience or a

catastrophe? What does the intensity of the reaction reveal about where your church's confidence actually rests?

2. Can you identify a time when your church or its leaders softened a

prophetic truth in order to maintain political access or cultural respectability? What was the cost of that silence?

3. What would your faith look like if Christianity had no cultural privilege in America—no special legal protections, no assumed moral authority, no political influence? Would anything essential change about your relationship with Christ?

4. How has the assumption that America is a "Christian nation" shaped

your expectations about what the church should look like and how it should relate to political power?

5. The early church thrived under persecution because its identity came

from the resurrection, not from cultural standing. Where does your church's identity actually come from? How would you know?

6. Is there a difference between gratitude for political favor and dependence on it? Where are you on that spectrum?

Practices

- Personal: Spend one week meditating on what the church was before Constantine—no buildings, no budgets, no political access, no cultural privilege. Read Acts 2:42–47 and Acts 4:32–35 each morning. Ask God: "Is there anything in these passages that my church has lost because of our comfort? What would it look like to recover it?"

- Personal: Write down every political or cultural "protection" you rely on for your sense of spiritual security—tax exemptions,

legal protections, cultural respectability, political allies. Then ask honestly: "If every one of these were taken away, would my faith in Christ remain?" Pray through the list. Surrender each one to God with open hands.

- Family: At a family dinner, discuss this question: "What would our family's faith look like if we lived in a country where Christianity had no political privilege at all? What would stay the same? What would change?" Let everyone answer honestly.

- Church: Propose a study or discussion series on the history of the church's relationship to political power—from the early church through Constantine through the Reformation to the American experiment. Ask: "What did the church gain in each transition? What did it lose? And where are we now?"

Sources & Notes

1 Samuel 8:1–22—Israel's demand for a king, God's interpretation as rejection of His kingship, and the warning about what the king will take. 1 Timothy 2:1–2—Paul's instruction to pray for rulers, that believers may lead peaceful lives. Exodus 16:19–20—The hoarding of manna and its decay as a parable of grasping at God's provision. John 15:18–20—Jesus' warning that the world will hate His followers, and that suffering is normative for the church. Augustine, *The City of God*, especially Books XIV–XIX—On the two cities, the relativization of earthly power, and the proper ordering of Christian hope. Peter Leithart, *Defending Constantine* (IVP Academic, 2010)—A careful defense that acknowledges both genuine goods and structural risks of the Constantinian settlement. Craig Carter, *Rethinking Christ and Culture* (Brazos Press, 2006)—On the Constantinian shift and its ongoing effects on Western Christianity's posture toward power. Stanley Hauerwas, *Resident Aliens* (Abingdon Press, 1989)—On the church as a colony whose primary political witness is being the church rather than managing the state.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Germany's Warning: Baptized Nationalism and Moral Catastrophe

"The church that trades its integrity for protection does not preserve itself. It loses itself."

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A Nation Looking for a Savior

Germany in the 1920s and early 1930s was a nation in agony. The humiliation of the Versailles Treaty had stripped the country of territory, military capacity, and national pride. The Weimar Republic, Germany's experiment with parliamentary democracy, was riddled with instability—coalition governments rose and fell with dizzying speed, hyperinflation destroyed the savings of ordinary families, and the Great Depression of 1929 delivered an economic blow that left millions unemployed and desperate.

For German Christians—and Germany was an overwhelmingly Christian nation, both Protestant and Catholic—the crisis felt not merely economic or political. It felt civilizational. It felt like the moral foundations of their society were crumbling. Sexual permissiveness in Berlin's cabarets scandalized traditional believers. Marxist movements threatened the church's social position. Secularism was advancing in universities and public institutions. The old certainties of Christendom—church, family, moral consensus—seemed to be disintegrating under the weight of modernity.

The fear was real. The threats were not imaginary. Moral decline was not a figment of conservative paranoia. The cultural ground genuinely was shifting under the feet of German Christians, and the

institutions they had trusted to maintain social order were visibly failing.

And into that fear stepped a man who promised restoration.

Adolf Hitler did not initially rise to power by attacking Christianity. He rose by presenting himself as its defender. He invoked providence. He spoke of restoring Germany's soul. He promised to protect the church, defend the family, restore national greatness, and push back against the moral decay that Christians found so alarming. He offered anxious believers exactly what they wanted: protection without repentance, power without humility, national renewal without self-examination.

And millions of German Christians accepted the offer.

Not because they were uniquely evil. Not because they lacked sincere faith. But because they were afraid. And fear, as we have seen throughout this book, makes the idol feel necessary. Fear makes the chariot look like the only option. Fear makes the strongman's promises sound like the voice of God.

The "German Christians": When Theology Serves the State

The movement known as the *Deutsche Christen*—the "German Christians"—represents one of the most instructive and disturbing episodes in church history. It was not a pagan movement. It was not composed of atheists who infiltrated the church to destroy it from within. It was a movement of sincere Protestants who believed, with genuine conviction, that God was working through Adolf Hitler to restore Germany's Christian soul.

The German Christians argued that national revival and spiritual renewal belonged together. They believed that the German Volk—the people, the nation, the race—was part of God's created order, and that defending the nation was therefore a form of obedience to God. They saw no conflict between loyalty to Christ and loyalty to the Führer. In their theology, the two loyalties reinforced each other.

And that is precisely what made the movement so dangerous. It was not paganism. It was baptized nationalism—a Christianity that had absorbed the nation's story so thoroughly that it could no longer distinguish between God's purposes and Germany's ambitions.

The theological consequences were devastating. The German Christians attempted to remove the Old Testament from Christian worship because it was "too Jewish." They sought to purge the church of pastors with Jewish ancestry. They rewrote hymns to align with Nazi ideology. They adopted the Führerprinzip—the leadership principle—into church governance, arguing that the church, like the state, needed a single strong leader rather than democratic structures. They draped the cross in the swastika and called it faithfulness.

The doctrine was quietly, systematically rewritten. Not all at once. Not through a single dramatic act of apostasy. But gradually, under the pressure of national crisis, through the slow accommodation of theology to political necessity, one compromise at a time.

That is how it always happens. Not with a bang but with a thousand small concessions, each one feeling reasonable at the time.

Barmen: The Line That Had to Be Drawn

Not every German Christian accepted the fusion. In May 1934, representatives of the Confessing Church—a movement of Protestants who rejected the German Christians' capitulation—gathered in the city of Barmen to draft what would become one of the most important theological documents of the twentieth century: the Barmen Declaration.

The Barmen Declaration did not address specific political policies. It did not endorse a political party or call for armed resistance. What it did was far more fundamental: it drew a theological line. It declared that Jesus Christ, as He is attested in Holy Scripture, is the one Word of God whom we must hear, trust, and obey in life and in death. And it explicitly rejected the claim that the church should recognize "other events, powers, historic figures,

and truths as God's revelation" alongside or apart from Jesus Christ.

In other words, Barmen said: the church has one Lord. Not two. Not Christ and the Führer. Not the gospel and the national destiny. Not Scripture and the ideology of the state. One Lord. One Word. One source of ultimate authority. And any theology that supplements Christ with a political savior—no matter how urgent the crisis, no matter how compelling the leader, no matter how real the threat—is a false theology.

Karl Barth, the primary author of the declaration, understood that the German church's failure was not primarily political. It was theological. The church had not merely made a strategic error in aligning with Hitler. It had committed a doctrinal error—a failure to maintain the exclusive lordship of Christ over every sphere of life, including national identity and political allegiance.

Dietrich Bonhoeffer, who would eventually be executed by the Nazis for his involvement in a conspiracy against Hitler, put it even more starkly. He argued that the church had entered a crisis not because the state was attacking it, but because the church had surrendered its own identity. It had become so entangled with the national project that it could no longer speak a word from God that the nation did not want to hear. It had lost the one thing that made it the church: the freedom to proclaim Christ as Lord over and against every earthly power.

The Confessing Church was a minority. Most German Protestants either actively supported the German Christian movement or quietly accommodated themselves to the new order. The pastors who resisted paid a steep price—imprisonment, exile, execution. The majority who cooperated were not punished by the state. They were rewarded with stability, institutional survival, and the comfortable illusion that they were being faithful.

History has rendered its verdict on who was actually faithful.

The Moral Catastrophe: How the Church Lost Its Voice

The consequences of the German church's compromise extend far beyond politics. What happened in Germany between 1933 and 1945 was not merely a political failure. It was a moral catastrophe of civilization-altering proportions—and the church's complicity in that catastrophe remains one of the most devastating indictments in Christian history.

The Holocaust was enacted in a nation with a Christian majority. The laws that stripped Jewish citizens of their rights, that segregated them, that deported them, that ultimately murdered six million of them—these laws were enacted in a country where Sunday church attendance was the cultural norm. Pastors who preached sermons about loving your neighbor on Sunday watched Jewish neighbors hauled away on Monday and said nothing. Churches that sang hymns about the justice of God remained silent while injustice was institutionalized at every level of society.

How did this happen? How did a nation of churchgoers become complicit in industrial-scale murder?

The answer is not that Germans were uniquely wicked. The answer is that the church had already surrendered its prophetic independence before the worst atrocities began. By the time the moral crisis demanded courageous resistance, the church had already traded its voice for the security of political alignment. It had already decided that national stability was more important than moral clarity. It had already accepted the premise that the nation's enemies were the church's enemies, and that defending the nation was the same thing as defending the faith.

Once those categories collapsed, the church could not speak. Not because it lacked the theological resources—the Bible is relentless in its defense of the vulnerable, the stranger, the oppressed. But because speaking would have required the church to challenge the very political power it had embraced as its protector. And you cannot prophetically confront a power you depend on for your survival.

That is the price of protection. Not just moral compromise in the

moment, but the loss of the capacity to resist when the moment demands it. The church did not become complicit in the Holocaust overnight. It became complicit one accommodation at a time, one silence at a time, one rationalization at a time—until the accumulated weight of compromise had made prophetic speech unthinkable.

Answering the Objection: "Are You Calling People Nazis?"

This is the objection I need to address directly, because if I do not, everything in this chapter will be dismissed by the people who most need to hear it.

No. I am not calling American Christians Nazis. I am not saying that contemporary Christian nationalism is equivalent to National Socialism. I am not suggesting that supporting a political candidate is the same as supporting genocide. That kind of rhetorical escalation is lazy, manipulative, and morally irresponsible, and it deserves to be rejected whenever it appears—from any direction.

But the rejection of lazy comparison does not excuse us from learning what history teaches.

And what history teaches is not that patriotism produces fascism. It is something more subtle, more uncomfortable, and more directly relevant to our moment: when fear combines with theological confusion, churches can rationalize alliances that later horrify them.

The German Christians who supported Hitler did not wake up one morning and decide to become complicit in atrocity. They made a series of smaller decisions—each one seemingly reasonable, each one driven by a legitimate concern—that cumulatively led them to a place they never intended to go. They believed their moment was exceptional. They believed the stakes justified the compromise. They believed that this time, the ends would justify the means. They believed they were being responsible, prudent, realistic.

Every generation tells itself the same story: "This time is different. This time the stakes are higher. This time compromise is necessary. This time we have to hold our nose and make the

pragmatic choice."

And history keeps rendering the same verdict: the church that trades its integrity for protection does not preserve itself. It loses itself.

The lesson of Germany is not "you are Nazis." The lesson of Germany is "you are not immune." No generation of Christians is immune to the seduction of political power. No church is so theologically sophisticated, so culturally aware, so spiritually mature that it cannot be led astray by fear. The German church was one of the most educated, most theologically rich, most historically rooted churches in the world—and it failed catastrophically.

If they could fall, so can we. And the first step toward falling is the conviction that you cannot.

The "Lesser of Two Evils" and Moral Anesthesia

One of the most common defenses for political compromise in the American church is the "lesser of two evils" framework. The reasoning is straightforward: in a fallen world, choices are rarely pure. Christians must often choose between imperfect options. Voting is not ordination. Supporting a candidate is not a declaration that they are morally righteous. It is simply a pragmatic calculation about which option will produce less harm.

That reasoning is not wrong in itself. Christians do live in a fallen world. Choices are often between imperfect options. Moral purity in political decision-making is not always available, and pretending otherwise is its own kind of self-deception.

What is dangerous is when "lesser evil" becomes moral anesthesia—when it stops functioning as a sober acknowledgment of fallenness and starts functioning as a blanket excuse for tolerating whatever your preferred side does.

When we stop calling evil "evil" because it is our side's evil. When we begin defending behavior we would condemn in our

opponents. When we excuse corruption, cruelty, and dishonesty because the person committing them delivers the policy outcomes we want. When we find ourselves constructing elaborate justifications for conduct that, in any other context, we would recognize as disqualifying.

At that point, we are not navigating moral complexity. We are recalibrating morality around outcomes. We are doing precisely what Paul warned against when he wrote:

"Why not do evil that good may come?"—their condemnation is just. —Romans 3:8

Paul's answer to ends-justify-means reasoning is not qualified. It is condemnation. God never said, "Break My commands if it helps your cause." God never said, "Moral integrity is negotiable when the political stakes are high enough." God never said, "Character matters in private life but not in public leadership."

And here is where the German parallel becomes directly instructive—not as a one-to-one comparison, but as a pattern.

The German Christians who supported Hitler did not begin by supporting genocide. They began by accepting the premise that Germany's crisis was so severe that normal moral standards could be temporarily suspended. They began by telling themselves that the ends—national restoration, economic recovery, the defense of Christian civilization—justified tolerating a leader whose methods were sometimes distasteful. They began by calling evil "necessary" and cruelty "strength" and ruthlessness "leadership."

And with each accommodation, the moral threshold dropped. Each compromise made the next compromise easier. Each rationalization expanded the category of what was "acceptable." Until the church found itself standing in a place it never intended to stand—complicit in horrors it never imagined it would tolerate—and unable to explain how it got there.

The "lesser of two evils" framework is spiritually dangerous not

because it acknowledges moral complexity, but because it can train the conscience to tolerate more and more evil over time. It can function as a ratchet that only turns in one direction—toward greater accommodation, greater excuse-making, greater moral numbness—until the Christian who started by reluctantly tolerating imperfection finds themselves enthusiastically defending what they once would have denounced.

The question is not whether you can tolerate imperfection in a political leader. Of course you can. The question is whether your tolerance has a floor—a point beyond which you will say, "This I cannot support, regardless of the political cost." If you cannot name that floor—if there is no behavior, no level of dishonesty, no degree of cruelty that would cause you to withdraw your support—then the "lesser of two evils" framework is no longer functioning as moral reasoning. It is functioning as moral surrender.

Character Matters: Nathan, Elijah, and the Baptist

Another common objection in this conversation is: "Presidents aren't pastors. We are not electing a national chaplain. We are electing someone to govern, and governance requires a different standard than pastoral ministry."

There is a kernel of truth in this. Political leadership and pastoral ministry are different vocations with different qualifications. We should not expect identical character profiles from a head of state and a shepherd of a congregation.

But Scripture does not draw the line where this objection draws it. Scripture consistently holds rulers accountable for justice, integrity, and character—not merely for policy outcomes.

Nathan confronted David—not for a policy failure, but for adultery and murder (2 Samuel 12). Elijah confronted Ahab—not for raising taxes, but for stealing Naboth's vineyard and shedding innocent blood (1 Kings 21). John the Baptist confronted Herod—not for his political platform, but for his sexual immorality—and lost his

head for it (Mark 6:17–29).

In every case, the prophet does not say, "Well, he's not a pastor." The prophet says, "You are a ruler, and God holds rulers accountable for their character, not just their legislation."

Micah summarizes the standard with devastating simplicity:

"He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the Lord require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?" —Micah 6:8

That standard is not limited to clergy. It is addressed to rulers, to nations, to every human being who exercises authority. Justice. Kindness. Humility. If those qualities are absent from a leader—if the leader is characterized instead by injustice, cruelty, and arrogance—then the Christian who supports that leader must at least be honest about what they are tolerating and why.

Political office does not excuse moral corruption. If anything, it raises the stakes, because power magnifies what is already there. A dishonest person with power is more dangerous than a dishonest person without it. A cruel person with authority does more damage than a cruel person without it. Character is not a luxury in leadership. It is a load-bearing wall. And when the wall collapses, everything built on top of it comes down.

So why are parts of the church pretending now that character does not matter?

Because we are afraid. And fear makes us practical in ways that are actually faithless. Fear convinces us that the situation is so dire that we cannot afford the luxury of moral standards. Fear says, "Yes, the leader is flawed, but the alternative is worse." And before long, fear has redefined "flawed" to include things that Scripture calls sin—and we have stopped noticing the shift.

What Germany Teaches About the Cost of Silence

Perhaps the most haunting aspect of the German church's failure

was not what it did but what it did not do. It was not primarily the active collaboration that damns the historical record—though that was real and indefensible. It was the silence. The vast, institutional, Sunday-morning silence of a church that knew something was wrong and said nothing.

Martin Niemöller, the German pastor who initially supported Hitler before becoming one of the most prominent leaders of the Confessing Church, captured this failure in words that have become some of the most quoted of the twentieth century:

"First they came for the socialists, and I did not speak out—because I was not a socialist. Then they came for the trade unionists, and I did not speak out—because I was not a trade unionist. Then they came for the Jews, and I did not speak out—because I was not a Jew. Then they came for me—and there was no one left to speak for me."

The silence was not passive. It was a choice. It was the choice to prioritize institutional survival over prophetic faithfulness. It was the choice to protect the church's relationship with the state rather than protect the people the state was destroying. It was the choice to say, "This is not our concern," about matters that the gospel makes every believer's concern.

And the silence had a theology behind it. The theology said: our primary responsibility is to maintain the church's stability. Our job is to keep the institution running, the congregations intact, the buildings open. If speaking truth would jeopardize our position, then silence is not cowardice—it is stewardship.

That theology is alive and well in the American church today. It is the theology of the pastor who knows something is wrong but will not say it because it would split the congregation. It is the theology of the church leader who privately laments the moral compromises of their political allies but publicly remains silent because speaking would cost them influence. It is the theology that confuses institutional preservation with faithfulness to Christ—and chooses the

institution every time.

But Jesus did not promise to preserve institutions. He promised to build His church. And the church He builds is not defined by buildings, budgets, or political access. It is defined by its willingness to confess Him as Lord—even when confession costs everything the institution holds dear.

"My kingdom is not of this world. If my kingdom were of this world, my servants would have been fighting, that I might not be delivered over to the Jews. But my kingdom is not from the world."
—John 18:36

Jesus said this while standing before Pilate—the representative of the most powerful political authority on earth. And He did not flinch. He did not calculate the political cost. He did not moderate His claims to avoid offending the state. He spoke the truth about the nature of His kingdom, knowing it would lead to His execution.

That is the model. And it is a model that requires the church to value truth more than survival, faithfulness more than stability, and the lordship of Christ more than the approval of any earthly power.

The Pattern We Must Recognize

Let me be precise about what I am asking you to take from this chapter, because precision matters when the stakes are this high.

I am not asking you to accept a facile comparison between the contemporary United States and Nazi Germany. The political situations are different. The institutional structures are different. The specific threats are different. History does not repeat itself in photocopy form.

But history does reveal patterns. And the pattern that the German experience illuminates is this: when a church becomes so entangled with national identity that it cannot distinguish between God's purposes and the nation's ambitions, it loses the ability to resist when resistance is required. When a church accepts political protection at

the cost of prophetic independence, it gains security in the short term and loses its soul in the long term. When a church allows fear to rewrite its theology—making the nation's enemies into God's enemies, the nation's preservation into the church's mission, the nation's leader into God's anointed—it has already departed from the gospel, even if it continues to use the gospel's language.

That pattern is not unique to Germany. It has appeared in every era where the church has traded its independence for the comfort of political alignment. It appeared in Constantine's Rome. It appeared in medieval Christendom. It appeared in colonial Christianity. It appeared in apartheid South Africa. It appeared in the American church's defense of slavery and segregation.

And it is appearing now.

Not in identical form. Not with identical consequences. But with the same underlying dynamic: fear drives the church to seek political protection, protection demands theological accommodation, and accommodation gradually erodes the church's ability to speak truth, pursue justice, and confess Christ as Lord over every earthly power—including the one it has embraced.

The question is not whether this could happen to the American church. The question is whether we are honest enough to recognize where it is already happening, and courageous enough to repent before the cost becomes catastrophic.

Because the road from accommodation to complicity is never as long as we think. And the church that cannot name the idol while it is still being formed will not be able to resist the idol once it is fully established.

Paul's instruction to the Roman church remains as urgent now as it was two thousand years ago:

"Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind, that by testing you may discern what is the will of God, what is good and acceptable and perfect." —Romans

12:2

Non-conformity is not a posture of arrogance. It is the posture of a people who know they serve a King whose kingdom is not of this world—and who refuse to let any earthly kingdom claim the loyalty that belongs to Him alone.

Key Takeaways

- Germany's church did not fall because it abandoned faith—it fell because it fused faith with national identity until the two became indistinguishable, and the church could no longer speak a word the nation did not want to hear.
- Hitler rose not by attacking Christianity but by presenting himself as its defender—offering protection without repentance, power without humility, national restoration without self-examination.
- The Barmen Declaration drew the essential theological line: Jesus Christ is the one Word of God, and no political leader, national destiny, or historical crisis can be recognized as a supplementary source of divine authority.
- The Holocaust was enacted in a majority-Christian nation—not because Christians were uniquely evil, but because the church had already surrendered its prophetic independence before the worst atrocities began.
- The lesson of Germany is not "you are Nazis" but "you are not immune." Every generation of Christians is vulnerable to the seduction of political power when fear combines with theological confusion.
- The "lesser of two evils" framework becomes spiritually dangerous when it functions as moral anesthesia—training the conscience to tolerate more evil over time rather than maintaining a clear moral floor.

- Scripture holds rulers accountable for character, not merely outcomes—Nathan confronted David, Elijah confronted Ahab, John the Baptist confronted Herod. Political office does not excuse moral corruption.

- The church's greatest failure in Germany was not active collaboration but institutional silence—the choice to prioritize stability over truth. That theology of silence is alive in the American church today.

Reflection Questions

1. Can you name a specific moral standard you have relaxed or an ethical concern you have silenced in order to maintain support for a political leader or movement? What drove that decision—conviction or fear?

2. If the Confessing Church in Germany represented those who drew a

line and the German Christians represented those who accommodated, which posture more closely resembles your own—and what would need to change?

3. Is there a "floor" to your political tolerance—a specific behavior or moral failure in a leader that would cause you to withdraw support regardless of the policy benefits? Can you name it?

4. Where has the "lesser of two evils" framework stopped functioning as

sober moral reasoning in your life and started functioning as an excuse for tolerating what you know to be wrong?

5. Has your church spoken prophetically about the moral failures of the

political movement it is most aligned with? If not, what does that silence reveal about where the church's ultimate loyalty lies?

6. What would it cost you—relationally, socially, within your church

community—to speak honestly about the moral compromises you have observed? Is the cost of speaking greater than the cost of silence?

Practices

- Personal: Read the Barmen Declaration this week (it is short—only

a few pages). As you read, ask: "What would a Barmen-style confession say to the American church today? What are the 'other events, powers, and truths' we are tempted to recognize alongside Christ?" Write your own version.

- Personal: Identify one moral compromise you have made for political

reasons—a behavior you excused, a truth you suppressed, a standard you relaxed. Confess it to God. Confess it to a trusted friend. Ask what restoration looks like.

- Family: Discuss this question at a family meal: "What would it look

like for our family to support leaders we agree with politically while still holding them accountable morally? Where have we been silent when we should have spoken?"

- Church: Ask your pastor or small group leader: "How does our church

maintain prophetic independence from the political movements our members support? What safeguards do we have against becoming chaplains to a party rather than prophets to a culture?"

Sources & Notes

- Romans 12:1–2—The call to non-conformity and the renewal of the

mind as the foundation of discernment.

- Romans 3:8—Paul's condemnation of ends-justify-means moral reasoning.
- Micah 6:8—The standard of justice, kindness, and humility applied to all who exercise authority.
- John 18:36—Jesus' declaration before Pilate that His kingdom is not of this world.
- The Barmen Declaration (1934)—The Confessing Church's theological rejection of the fusion of church and state under Nazi ideology.
- Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *The Cost of Discipleship* (1937)—On the difference between "cheap grace" and "costly grace," and the church's responsibility to follow Christ regardless of political cost.
- Eric Metaxas, *Bonhoeffer: Pastor, Martyr, Prophet, Spy* (Thomas Nelson, 2010)—A biographical account of Bonhoeffer's resistance to Nazi co-optation of the German church.
- Robert P. Ericksen, *Complicity in the Holocaust: Churches and Universities in Nazi Germany* (Cambridge, 2012)—On the institutional silence and accommodation of German churches during the Nazi era.

CHAPTER NINE

The Generational Cost: When Hypocrisy Makes the Gospel Unbelievable

"Hypocrisy does not merely make the gospel less attractive. It makes the gospel unbelievable."

'&

The Audience That Never Left the Room

There is a generation watching.

They are sitting in the back pews of churches they are not sure they belong to anymore. They are scrolling through social media feeds where pastors they once trusted share content that sounds more like campaign propaganda than the gospel. They are sitting across the dinner table from parents whose faith they once admired but whose political behavior has become indistinguishable from the tribalism they hear condemned from the pulpit every Sunday.

And they are drawing conclusions.

Not first about politics. Not first about culture. Not first about which party is right or which candidate deserves their vote.

About God.

This is the part of the conversation that pastors and parents need to hear, and it is the part that makes everyone uncomfortable. Because the generational exodus from the church in America is not primarily a story about secularism winning. It is not primarily a story about universities corrupting the young. It is not primarily a story

about social media, pornography, or the seductive power of progressive ideology—though all of those factors are real and should not be dismissed.

It is, at its deepest level, a story about credibility.

When the people who taught you that character matters excuse the most visible character failures because the person in question delivers the right political outcomes—you do not merely question their politics. You question their theology. You question whether they ever believed what they said. You question whether the faith they handed you was real or whether it was always, underneath the Sunday language, a vehicle for something else.

And once that question takes root, it does not go away easily. Because the question is no longer "Is this political position right?" The question becomes "Is any of it true?"

That is the generational cost of what we are doing. And the bill is already coming due.

The Data and the Stories Behind It

The research on religious disaffiliation among young adults in America has been extensive, and the findings are consistent across multiple studies and methodologies. The number of Americans under forty who identify as religiously unaffiliated—the so-called "nones"—has grown dramatically over the past two decades. The Pew Research Center has documented this trend repeatedly. The General Social Survey has tracked it for even longer. The numbers are not in dispute.

What is in dispute is the explanation.

The most common conservative explanation runs something like this: young people are leaving because secular culture is too appealing, because universities undermine faith, because social media exposes them to ideas that erode belief, because the sexual revolution made the church's moral demands inconvenient. In this telling, the problem is entirely external. The culture is corrupting our children.

The solution is more insulation, more apologetics, more cultural engagement, more political power to push back against the secular tide.

There is partial truth in that explanation. The cultural pressures on young believers are real. The intellectual challenges are real. The sexual ethics of historic Christianity do create genuine tension with contemporary cultural norms. None of that should be minimized.

But that explanation, by itself, is dangerously incomplete. Because it conveniently ignores the most uncomfortable factor: the behavior of the church itself.

David Kinnaman's research at the Barna Group, published in books like

unChristian and *You Lost Me*, found something that should have alarmed every church leader in America. Young adults who left the church did not primarily describe the faith as intellectually implausible. They described it as hypocritical. They described it as judgmental. They described it as politically entangled. They described it as more interested in power than in love. They described a faith that said one thing and did another—and they found the contradiction intolerable.

The word that came up again and again in the research was not "false." It was "inauthentic."

That distinction matters enormously. A generation that thinks the gospel is intellectually false might be reached with better arguments. A generation that thinks the church is dishonest at its core requires something far more costly: repentance.

What Hypocrisy Actually Communicates

We tend to think of hypocrisy as a personal moral failing—an individual who says one thing and does another. And it is that. But when hypocrisy becomes systemic—when entire communities normalize a gap between their stated values and their actual behavior

—it communicates something far more devastating than individual moral weakness.

Systemic hypocrisy communicates that the stated values were never real.

When a church preaches that character matters and then rallies behind a leader whose character is visibly, publicly, undeniably deficient—not in the way that all sinners are deficient, but in ways that the church itself would have condemned without hesitation in any other context—the message received by the watching world is not "Christians are imperfect." Everyone already knows that. The message received is: "Character never actually mattered to them. It was always about power."

When a church preaches that truth matters and then tolerates, defends, or celebrates dishonesty because the dishonest person advances their political interests, the message received is not "Christians are navigating a complex world." The message received is: "Truth was always negotiable. It was only a weapon they used against other people."

When a church preaches love for enemies and then dehumanizes, mocks, and demonizes political opponents with language that would shame a high school bully, the message received is not "Christians are passionate about justice." The message received is: "The love they preached was conditional. It only applied to people who agreed with them."

When a church preaches humility and then celebrates arrogance, cruelty, and domination as "strength," the message received is not "Christians value strong leadership." The message received is: "Jesus was a mascot. Power was the real god all along."

This is not a progressive critique. This is not a politically motivated complaint from people who simply dislike conservative politics. This is a theological catastrophe of the first order. Because the gospel's power to persuade depends, in part, on the community

that proclaims it being recognizably shaped by it. When the community is not recognizably different from the tribalized, fear-driven, power-hungry culture around it—when the only distinguishing mark of the church is which political tribe it belongs to rather than whose image it bears—the gospel does not merely lose its appeal. It loses its plausibility.

Jesus said it plainly:

"By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another." —John 13:35

The world was supposed to recognize Christ's people by their love. Instead, an entire generation now recognizes Christ's people by their politics. And that recognition is not leading them toward faith. It is leading them away.

Jesus on Hypocrisy: The Sin He Condemned Most Fiercely

It is worth pausing to notice something about the Gospels that should unsettle every church leader in America: Jesus reserved His most devastating language not for pagans, not for the sexually immoral, not for tax collectors or prostitutes—but for the religious establishment.

Matthew 23 is the longest sustained rebuke in the Gospels. Seven times Jesus pronounces "woe" on the scribes and Pharisees. And the recurring charge is not theological error in the abstract. It is the specific sin of saying one thing and living another:

"The scribes and the Pharisees sit on Moses' seat, so do and observe whatever they tell you, but not the works they do. For they preach, but do not practice." —Matthew 23:2–3

They preach but do not practice. They bind heavy burdens on others but will not lift a finger themselves. They do everything to be seen. They love the places of honor. They love being called "teacher" and "leader." They tithe mint and cumin but neglect justice, mercy, and faithfulness. They clean the outside of the cup while the inside is

full of greed and self-indulgence.

And the metaphor Jesus reaches for is devastating:

"Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you are like whitewashed tombs, which outwardly appear beautiful, but within are full of dead people's bones and all uncleanness." —Matthew 23:27

Whitewashed tombs. Beautiful on the outside. Dead on the inside. Religious performance masking spiritual rot.

Now notice: Jesus does not say the Pharisees' theology is entirely wrong. He even tells the crowd to do what they teach. The content of their teaching is largely correct. What is catastrophically wrong is the disconnect between their teaching and their lives. They have the right words but the wrong character. The right doctrine but the wrong spirit. The right positions but the wrong posture.

And Jesus says this about them:

"You travel across sea and land to make a single proselyte, and when he becomes a proselyte, you make him twice as much a child of hell as yourselves." —Matthew 23:15

That verse should terrify every Christian leader in America. Because Jesus is saying that hypocritical religious leadership does not merely fail to produce disciples. It actively produces the opposite. The converts produced by hypocritical leaders are worse off than they were before—not because the theology is false, but because the hypocrisy teaches them that theology is a tool for manipulation rather than a call to transformation.

When the church normalizes the gap between its words and its behavior, it does not produce a generation that simply drifts away. It produces a generation that is actively inoculated against the gospel—because they have seen what they believe to be the gospel lived out, and what they saw was not good news. It was tribal power dressed in religious language.

If we are producing young people who look at the church and see

not the beauty of Christ but the ugliness of partisan tribalism—if the fruit of our "engagement" is a generation that finds the gospel unbelievable not because of its claims but because of its claimants—then we need to stop blaming the culture and start examining ourselves.

The Specific Hypocrisies That Are Costing Us

Let me be specific, because vague accusations of hypocrisy are easy to dismiss. The hypocrisies that are driving the next generation away are concrete, visible, and well-documented.

The character reversal. For decades, evangelical churches taught that character is the most important qualification for leadership—in the home, in the church, and in public office. This was not a controversial position. It was the position. Sermons were preached about it. Books were written about it. It was the stated reason for political engagement: we need leaders of character, leaders who reflect biblical values, leaders whose personal integrity matches their public promises.

And then, in the span of a single election cycle, that position was abandoned. Not revised. Not qualified. Abandoned. Character stopped being the primary criterion and became an afterthought—something to be excused, explained away, or simply ignored because the political stakes were deemed too high.

The watching generation noticed. And what they concluded was not that the church had made a difficult pragmatic calculation. What they concluded was that the church had never meant it in the first place. The "character matters" conviction was exposed, in their eyes, as a weapon deployed selectively rather than a principle held consistently.

The compassion inversion. The Jesus of the Gospels is consistently portrayed as one who moves toward the vulnerable: the sick, the outcast, the foreigner, the poor, the powerless. The church has historically been at its most beautiful when it has done the same—

building hospitals, establishing schools, feeding the hungry, welcoming refugees, visiting prisoners.

But when political alignment demands hostility toward the vulnerable—when immigrants become "invaders," when the poor become "lazy," when refugees become "threats," when compassion is reframed as weakness and cruelty is celebrated as strength—the watching generation sees a faith that has betrayed its own Savior. They do not see a church navigating complexity. They see a church that has chosen its political tribe over its theological identity.

The truth crisis. Christianity is built on truth claims. The resurrection is either historically true or it is not. The Scriptures are either trustworthy or they are not. The character of God is either faithful or it is not. The entire apologetic enterprise depends on the claim that truth matters—that reality is knowable, that lies are destructive, that integrity in speech reflects integrity of soul.

And then the watching generation sees churches—and church leaders—tolerating, repeating, and sometimes enthusiastically promoting claims that are demonstrably false. Conspiracy theories are shared without scrutiny. Misinformation is spread without correction. Leaders who lie repeatedly and provably are defended not by arguments for their truthfulness but by arguments for why their lying doesn't matter because the other side is worse.

When the community that claims to serve the God of truth becomes a community that tolerates untruth whenever it is politically convenient, the foundation of every other truth claim—including the gospel itself—is undermined. Because if truth is only valued when it serves the tribe, then truth is not actually valued. It is instrumentalized. And a generation that has watched truth be instrumentalized will not easily believe that the truth claims of the gospel are anything different.

The enemy-love gap. Jesus said, "Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you" (Matthew 5:44). This is not an optional addendum to the faith. It is one of the most distinctive and radical

commands in the entire New Testament. It is what sets Christian ethics apart from every other ethical system in the ancient world. It is the command that made pagans stare in astonishment at the early church.

And the watching generation sees a church that has largely abandoned it. Not in theory—no one has officially removed enemy-love from the doctrinal statement. But in practice, political opponents are spoken about with a contempt, mockery, and dehumanization that bears no resemblance to anything Jesus ever modeled. The people we are supposed to love are the people we most visibly hate. And the generation that notices this does not think, "Well, enemy-love is aspirational." They think, "They don't actually believe any of this."

Answering the Objection: "They're Leaving Because of Culture, Not the Church"

This is the objection I hear most frequently from church leaders, and it needs to be addressed with care, because it contains a genuine insight wrapped in a dangerous deflection.

The genuine insight: cultural pressures on young believers are real and significant. The ubiquity of pornography has affected sexual ethics and relational expectations. Social media has created comparison cultures that breed anxiety and dissatisfaction. Universities have, in some cases, created environments hostile to religious conviction. The entertainment industry often portrays Christianity as bigoted, outdated, or irrelevant. The sexual revolution has made the church's teaching on sexuality the most socially costly position a young person can hold. All of this is true.

The dangerous deflection: using these real cultural pressures as a shield against self-examination. Because the logic runs like this: "If young people are leaving because of TikTok and universities, then the church doesn't need to change. The culture needs to change. And the way to change the culture is more political power."

That logic is a closed loop. It starts with the assumption that the

church is fine and the culture is the problem, and it ends by demanding more of the very thing—political power and cultural control—that is alienating the next generation in the first place.

The honest truth is that both factors are at work simultaneously. Cultural pressures are pulling young people away from the church. And the church's own behavior is pushing them. The pull factors are real. But the push factors are the ones we can actually do something about—because they are ours to repent of.

Here is what pastors know in their bones but are often afraid to say out loud: a young person who sees the church living out the gospel with integrity, compassion, honesty, and sacrificial love can withstand enormous cultural pressure. The faith is not so fragile that a college philosophy class can destroy it—if it has been formed by a community that embodies what it preaches. What makes the cultural pressures devastating is not their strength. It is the weakness of the church's witness. When the culture says "Christianity is hypocritical" and the young person's lived experience in the church confirms it, the cultural critique sticks. But when the culture says "Christianity is hypocritical" and the young person's lived experience in the church contradicts it, the critique bounces off.

The church's greatest apologetic has never been its arguments. It has been its life. And when the life of the church validates the world's critique rather than refuting it, no amount of apologetics, youth programming, or political activism will keep the next generation.

The Witness of 1 Peter: Beauty in a Hostile World

The New Testament provides a precise guide for exactly this situation—a situation where the surrounding culture is hostile, skeptical, and predisposed to think the worst of the church. And the strategy it prescribes is not political power. It is visible, undeniable goodness.

The apostle Peter, writing to Christians scattered across a hostile Roman world, does not tell them to seize political influence. He does

not tell them to fight for cultural dominance. He does not tell them to find a sympathetic Caesar. He tells them to live so beautifully that even their critics will be silenced:

"Keep your conduct among the Gentiles honorable, so that when they speak against you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day of visitation." —1 Peter 2:12

Peter's strategy is extraordinary. He does not deny that the world will misrepresent Christians. He assumes it. He expects slander, false accusations, and hostility. But his response is not outrage, not political maneuvering, not culture war. His response is: live so well that the accusation becomes absurd. Let your conduct be the rebuttal. Let your love be the apologetic. Let the sheer quality of your life together make the slander unsustainable.

He continues:

"But even if you should suffer for righteousness' sake, you will be blessed. Have no fear of them, nor be troubled, but in your hearts honor Christ the Lord as holy, always being prepared to make a defense to anyone who asks you for a reason for the hope that is in you; yet do it with gentleness and respect, having a good conscience, so that, when you are slandered, those who revile your good behavior in Christ may be put to shame." —1 Peter 3:14–16

Notice the sequence. First, honor Christ as holy in your hearts—that is, make sure your ultimate allegiance is rightly ordered. Second, be prepared to give a reason for your hope—not for your political platform, not for your cultural agenda, but for your hope. Third, do it with gentleness and respect. Fourth, maintain a good conscience so that the slander has nowhere to land.

This is the early church's strategy for credibility in a hostile world. And it could not be more different from what the American church is currently doing.

We are not giving people a reason for our hope. We are giving them a reason for our outrage. We are not demonstrating gentleness

and respect. We are demonstrating contempt and tribal aggression. We are not maintaining a good conscience. We are excusing behavior that violates our stated convictions because the political stakes feel too high.

And the result is exactly what Peter's strategy was designed to prevent: the watching world—including the watching next generation—has credible grounds for dismissing the church. Not because the gospel is false, but because the community that proclaims it is not living as though it is true.

Titus 2 and the Doctrine That Depends on Living

Paul's letter to Titus provides one of the most striking connections between conduct and doctrine in the entire New Testament. Writing to a young pastor on the island of Crete—a culture that was famously difficult and morally chaotic—Paul instructs Titus to teach sound doctrine. But he ties the teaching to something unexpected: the behavior of the community.

He tells older men to be self-controlled and sound in faith. He tells older women to be reverent in behavior and to teach what is good. He tells younger men to be models of good works. He tells slaves to be trustworthy in every way. And then he gives the reason—and the reason is stunning:

"...so that in everything they may adorn the doctrine of God our Savior." —Titus 2:10

Adorn the doctrine. The Greek word is *kosmeō* which we get "cosmetic." It means to make beautiful, to arrange attractively, to display in a way that draws admiration. Paul is saying that the behavior of the community is what makes the doctrine beautiful to the watching world.

The doctrine, by itself, is true. But truth that is not embodied is not compelling. Truth that contradicts the lives of those who proclaim it is not merely unpersuasive—it is repulsive. The doctrine needs to be "adorned"—dressed in the clothing of a community that actually

lives it—before it becomes attractive to the world.

Now apply this to our moment. What is the American church's conduct currently "adorning"? What does the world see when it looks at us?

If what the world sees is a community defined by political tribalism, moral inconsistency, selective outrage, and a willingness to compromise integrity for political gain—then we are not adorning the doctrine. We are defacing it. We are taking the most beautiful message in the history of the world and making it ugly.

And the generation that sees the ugliness is not wrong to recoil. They are responding to exactly what Paul said they would respond to: the doctrine, when lived badly, repels rather than attracts. The problem is not with the doctrine. The problem is with the community that has made the doctrine unrecognizable.

A Credibility Rebuild Plan

If the diagnosis is credibility loss, then the prescription is not better marketing, more engaging youth programs, or trendier worship services. The prescription is repentance that produces visible, sustained, costly change.

What would a credibility rebuild look like for the American church? It would require at least the following:

Consistency of moral standards regardless of political alignment.

The church must hold the same moral standards for leaders on "its side" as it holds for leaders on the other side. If dishonesty disqualifies an opponent, it must disqualify an ally. If cruelty is condemned in the other party, it must be condemned in ours. If sexual misconduct matters when the other side does it, it must matter when our side does it. This is not political neutrality. It is moral integrity. And it is the bare minimum of prophetic credibility.

Public repentance for specific, named failures. Vague confessions of "imperfection" are not repentance. The watching generation has

seen specific behaviors, specific endorsements, specific compromises. They need to hear specific acknowledgments. "We were wrong to excuse this." "We should not have tolerated that." "We compromised our witness here, and we are repenting of it." The specificity of the repentance must match the specificity of the failure, or it will be dismissed as public relations rather than genuine contrition.

A recovery of the church's independence from partisan identification. The church must become a community that no political party can claim. Not because the church has no political convictions—it does, and it should—but because its convictions are derived from Scripture and the lordship of Christ rather than from a party platform. When the church's positions line up with the left on some issues and with the right on others—when it is consistently inconsistent with every earthly faction because its allegiance is to a heavenly King—then and only then will its prophetic voice regain credibility.

Visible, sacrificial love that cannot be explained by self-interest.

The early church gained credibility by caring for people who could not benefit them—plague victims, abandoned infants, widows, prisoners. The watching generation needs to see the same. They need to see a church that serves immigrants regardless of their legal status, that feeds the hungry regardless of their voting record, that visits prisoners regardless of their crimes, that cares for the poor regardless of whether the poor are "deserving." When the church's love is indiscriminate—when it mirrors the God who "sends rain on the just and the unjust" (Matthew 5:45)—the gospel becomes visible in a way that no sermon, no book, and no political victory can achieve.

Honest engagement with the generation's questions rather than dismissal of their concerns. The next generation is not asking these questions because they are rebellious, lazy, or corrupted by culture. Many of them are asking because they love Jesus and are grieved by what they see. They deserve to be heard, not lectured. They deserve honest answers, not defensive deflections. They deserve a church that

treats their departure as a wound to be healed rather than a betrayal to be punished.

What Is at Stake

Let me be as direct as I can about what is at stake.

We are not merely losing a generation to secularism. We are losing a generation to disillusionment—and disillusionment is far harder to overcome than doubt. A person who doubts the gospel can be reached with evidence, with argument, with testimony, with encounter. A person who is disillusioned with the church has already seen the testimony—and found it wanting. They are not asking "Is this true?" They are saying "I watched people who claimed it was true, and it didn't change them."

That is a different problem. And it requires a different solution.

The solution is not more information. The solution is not better programs. The solution is not political victory that will make the church culturally dominant again so that the next generation has no choice but to participate.

The solution is a church that looks like Jesus.

A church that tells the truth even when it is costly. A church that loves its enemies even when it is ridiculed. A church that holds moral standards consistently even when it is inconvenient. A church that cares for the vulnerable even when there is no political reward. A church that repents publicly even when it is humiliating. A church that would rather lose every political battle than lose its integrity. A church that knows the difference between winning an election and winning a soul.

That kind of church has always been the most powerful apologetic in the world. Not because it is perfect—no church is. But because it is honest about its imperfection, relentless in its pursuit of faithfulness, and visibly shaped by the Savior it proclaims.

The next generation is not looking for a perfect church. They are

looking for a real one. And "real" means a community where the gap between confession and conduct is acknowledged, lamented, and actively closed—not defended, justified, or dismissed.

Paul told the Corinthians that when an unbeliever walks into a faithful assembly and encounters genuine worship and real community, the response should be to fall on their face and declare, "God is really among you" (1 Corinthians 14:25).

When the next generation walks into our assemblies, are they falling on their faces? Or are they walking out the door?

The answer depends not on our doctrine—our doctrine is fine. It depends on whether our lives match what our doctrine claims.

And if they do not, then the most urgent task before the American church is not to win the next election. It is to become the kind of community that makes the next generation say, against all cultural pressure, "God is really among you."

That is the generational cost of hypocrisy: not merely empty pews, but a generation that has concluded the pews were empty of God long before they were empty of people.

And that conclusion, however painful, may be a gift—if we have the courage to hear it as a call to repentance rather than a reason for resentment.

Key Takeaways

- The generational exodus from the church is not primarily a story about secularism winning—it is a story about credibility lost. Young adults describe the church as hypocritical and politically entangled, not merely intellectually implausible.
- Systemic hypocrisy communicates that the church's stated values were never real—that character, truth, love, and humility were always tools for tribal power rather than genuine convictions.
- Jesus reserved His fiercest condemnation for the Pharisees' hypocrisy—not because their theology was wrong, but because the gap between their teaching and their lives made them factories of disbelief (Matthew 23:15).
- The

specific hypocrisies driving the next generation away are concrete: the character reversal, the compassion inversion, the truth crisis, and the abandonment of enemy-love in practice. • Blaming culture alone for the exodus is a dangerous deflection—the pull factors are real, but the push factors (the church's own failures) are the ones we can repent of. • Peter's strategy for credibility in a hostile world is not political power but visible, undeniable goodness—conduct that silences slander because it cannot be denied (1 Peter 2:12). • Paul teaches that the community's conduct "adorns" the doctrine (Titus 2:10)—making it beautiful or ugly depending on whether the lives match the words. • The most urgent task before the American church is not winning the next election but becoming the kind of community that makes the next generation say, "God is really among you."

Reflection Questions

1\ If your children or grandchildren described the faith based solely on how they have seen you engage with politics over the last decade, what would they say Christianity is about? 2\ Can you name a specific moral standard you applied differently to a political leader you supported versus one you opposed? What does the inconsistency reveal about what you actually value? 3\ When a young person tells you they left the church because of hypocrisy, is your first instinct to listen or to explain why they are wrong? What does your instinct reveal? 4\ Has your political engagement over the past five years made the gospel more or less believable to the people watching your life? Be specific about the evidence. 5\ What would it cost you—relationally, socially, politically—to hold the same moral standards for leaders on your side as you hold for leaders on the other side? Are you willing to pay that cost? 6\ If the next generation could ask the church one question and receive an honest answer, what do you think they would ask? Are you prepared to answer it?

Practices

- Personal: Ask a young adult in your life—your child, a college student, a young coworker—this question: "What does the church's political engagement communicate to you about God?" Listen without defending, correcting, or explaining. Write down what you hear. Pray

over it for a week. • Personal: Review your social media activity over the past six months. How much of it reflects the character of Jesus? How much of it reflects political tribalism? Would an unbeliever scrolling through your posts encounter the gospel or a partisan agenda? Delete what does not honor Christ. • Family: At a family meal this week, ask each person: "When you think of our church, do you think of a community shaped by Jesus or a community shaped by politics?" Let everyone answer honestly. Do not argue. Process what you hear together in prayer. • Church: Propose that your church leadership invite a group of young adults—including some who have left—to share honestly about what they have experienced. Do not set the agenda. Do not offer rebuttals. Simply listen, repent of what is true, and commit to specific, visible changes. Let the young adults hold you accountable.

Sources & Notes

Matthew 23:1–39—Jesus' sevenfold woe against the scribes and Pharisees, especially the charge of hypocrisy: "They preach, but do not practice."

John 13:34–35—The new commandment and the world's identification of disciples by their love for one another.

1 Peter 2:11–12; 3:14–16—The strategy of visible goodness in a hostile world as the church's primary apologetic.

Titus 2:1–10—Conduct that "adorns the doctrine" and the connection between community behavior and doctrinal credibility.

1 Corinthians 14:24–25—The unbeliever encountering an real community and declaring "God is really among you."

David Kinnaman, *unChristian* (Baker Books, 2007) and *You Lost Me* (Baker Books, 2011)—Research on the perceptions of young adults toward the church, including the prominence of "hypocritical" as a descriptor.

James Davison Hunter, *To Change the World* (Oxford, 2010)—On faithful presence as the church's mode of cultural engagement rather than political conquest.

Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *The Cost of Discipleship* (Touchstone, 1959)—On the difference between cheap grace and costly grace, and the church's perennial temptation to offer the former.

CHAPTER TEN

Cross and Sword: Two Theologies of Power

"Propaganda can fill arenas. It cannot raise the dead."

'&

The Question Behind Every Question

We have spent nine chapters diagnosing a disease. We have named it

zanah—relocated trust. We have traced it through Israel's alliances, through the crowd's demand for a political messiah, through the domestication of the confession "Jesus is Lord," through the Constantinian bargain, through Germany's catastrophe, through the generational wreckage of hypocrisy. We have watched the same pattern repeat across centuries and continents: fear drives the people of God toward political power, political power promises protection, and the church trades its prophetic soul for a seat at the table.

But beneath every chapter, beneath every historical example and every scriptural text, there has been one question pulsing like a heartbeat:

How does God actually conquer?

That is the question this chapter must answer. Because everything else—every diagnostic marker, every reflection question, every call to repentance—depends on whether we believe God's method of victory is sufficient. If we do not trust the way God conquers, we will inevitably supplement it with the way the world conquers. If we believe that the cross is God's definitive revelation of power, then the

entire posture of the church in relation to political authority changes. If we do not—if we secretly believe the cross was a necessary but insufficient step that must be supplemented by legislation, cultural dominance, and the machinery of coercion—then we will keep running back to Egypt no matter how many times the prophet calls us home.

So this is where the argument arrives at its climax. Not a political strategy. Not a policy recommendation. A theology of power. Specifically, the question of whether the church operates by the logic of the cross or the logic of the sword—and what happens when it confuses the two.

Two Kingdoms, Two Logics

The New Testament does not pretend that political authority is irrelevant or illegitimate. Paul's letter to the Romans includes one of the most discussed passages on government in all of Scripture:

"Let every person be subject to the governing authorities. For there is no authority except from God, and those that exist have been instituted by God\... For he is God's servant for your good. But if you do wrong, be afraid, for he does not bear the sword in vain. For he is the servant of God, an avenger who carries out God's wrath on the wrongdoer." —Romans 13:1, 4

This passage is important, and it is routinely abused in two opposite directions. On one side, it is flattened into an unconditional command to obey whatever the government says—a reading that would have made nonsense of the early church's refusal to worship Caesar, of Peter's declaration that "we must obey God rather than men" (Acts 5:29), and of the entire book of Revelation, which portrays the Roman state as a beast demanding illegitimate worship. On the other side, it is dismissed as situational advice with no enduring theological significance—a reading that ignores Paul's deliberate, theological grounding of political authority in God's ordering of creation.

The passage does something more careful than either extreme allows. It acknowledges that the state has a God-given role: the restraint of evil, the maintenance of order, the protection of the vulnerable through the exercise of coercive force. The state bears the sword. That is its vocation. And within its proper limits, that vocation is legitimate. Christians can affirm this without embarrassment.

But notice what Paul does not say. He does not say the state bears the cross. He does not say the state's method is the church's method. He does not say that because government uses coercion to restrain evil, the church should use coercion to advance the gospel. He does not collapse the distinction between how the state operates and how the church operates.

The state restrains evil through force. The church overcomes evil through witness, service, sacrifice, and the power of the Holy Spirit. These are not the same logic. They are not interchangeable methods. And the confusion of the two—the assumption that the church can or should adopt the state's tools to accomplish the church's mission—is one of the most persistent and destructive errors in the history of Christianity.

Paul himself makes the distinction explicit in his second letter to the Corinthians:

"For though we walk in the flesh, we are not waging war according to the flesh. For the weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh but have divine power to destroy strongholds." —2 Corinthians 10:3–4

The weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh. That sentence should be tattooed on the conscience of every Christian who has ever believed that the church needs the instruments of political coercion to accomplish its mission. Paul is not saying the church does not fight. It fights fiercely. But the weapons are different. The strategy is different. The entire logic of engagement is different.

The state uses the sword. The church uses the word. The state

compels. The church persuades. The state enforces compliance. The church invites transformation. The state punishes wrongdoing. The church absorbs it—and then rises from the dead.

These two logics can coexist. A Christian can affirm the state's legitimate use of force while simultaneously insisting that the church's mode of operation is categorically different. You can support the police while refusing to police the conscience. You can affirm the necessity of national defense while insisting that the church does not need military metaphors to describe its mission—at least, not the kind that involve actual weapons.

The problem arises when the church forgets which logic it operates under. When the church begins to believe that it needs the sword to survive—that without legislative protection, cultural dominance, and political influence, the gates of hell will prevail—it has adopted the state's logic and abandoned its own. It has traded the weapons of divine power for the weapons of the flesh. And in doing so, it has implicitly declared that the cross was not enough.

The Cross as God's Definitive Act of Power

This is where we must stop being sentimental about the cross.

In much of American Christianity, the cross has been reduced to a symbol of personal forgiveness—the mechanism by which individual sinners receive a ticket to heaven. And it is that. The cross is the place where the sins of the world were borne by the sinless Son of God, where the penalty that justice demanded was paid in full, where the wrath of God against human rebellion was absorbed by the one person who did not deserve it. That is glorious, and it is true, and it is the heart of the gospel.

But the cross is more than a mechanism of personal salvation. The cross is God's definitive revelation of how He conquers.

Rome used crucifixion to dominate. It was the empire's most eloquent statement of power: "We can do this to you. We can strip you naked, nail you to wood, and leave you hanging at the

intersection where the most people will see your agony. We can turn your body into a public service announcement about what happens to those who resist." Crucifixion was not merely execution. It was political theater. It was the state's ultimate argument: comply, or this is what awaits you.

And God took Rome's most powerful instrument of domination and turned it into the instrument of redemption.

The resurrection did not come through military revolt. It did not come through political negotiation. It did not come through the careful accumulation of cultural influence. It came through a man hanging on a cross, absorbing the full weight of human evil into Himself, refusing to retaliate, and then walking out of a tomb three days later.

That is how God conquers. Not by exercising superior force. Not by out-coercing the coercers. Not by assembling a more powerful army or winning a more decisive election. God conquers by absorbing evil, bearing its full weight, and refusing to let it reproduce through Him. He breaks the cycle of violence not by winning the fight on evil's terms but by refusing to fight on evil's terms altogether.

Fleming Rutledge, in her magisterial work *The Crucifixion*, argues that the cross is not God's concession to weakness. It is God's revelation of strength. The power of God is not demonstrated by the avoidance of suffering but by the transformation of suffering into the instrument of redemption. The cross does not display God's inability to fight back. It displays His refusal to fight back on the terms the world offers—because fighting on the world's terms would reproduce the very evil He came to destroy.

Paul understood this with devastating clarity:

"For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God\... For the foolishness of God is wiser than men, and the weakness of God is stronger than men." —1 Corinthians 1:18, 25

The cross is foolishness to the perishing because it does not look like power. Power, in the world's estimation, looks like Rome. It looks like chariots. It looks like a congressional majority. It looks like cultural dominance and the ability to enforce your will on those who resist. The cross looks like none of those things. The cross looks like defeat. It looks like weakness. It looks like the end.

And that is precisely why it is the power of God. Because it defeats evil in a way that evil cannot understand, cannot anticipate, and cannot replicate. You can out-fight a warrior. You can out-strategize a politician. You can out-spend an empire. But you cannot defeat a man who is willing to die rather than become what you are. You cannot conquer a community whose response to persecution is forgiveness, whose response to hatred is love, whose response to death is the unshakable confidence that the grave is not the final word.

The early church understood this. That is why they conquered the Roman Empire—not by out-powering it, but by out-dying it, out-loving it, and out-hoping it. They offered something the empire could not provide: a community where love was stronger than fear, where death had been defeated, where the powers of this world had been relativized by the power of a resurrection.

Revelation 5: The Lamb Who Conquered

The book of Revelation provides the most vivid and theologically dense portrait of Christ's mode of conquest in the entire New Testament. And the portrait is deliberately, shockingly subversive.

In Revelation 5, John sees a scroll sealed with seven seals—a scroll that represents God's plan for the redemption of all things. No one in heaven or on earth is found worthy to open the scroll. John weeps. The plan of God seems stuck, the future locked shut.

Then one of the elders speaks:

"Weep no more; behold, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered, so that he can open the scroll and its seven seals." —Revelation 5:5

A lion. The imagery is unmistakable. Power, ferocity, royal authority, military conquest. The Lion of Judah has conquered. John turns to look—expecting, as anyone in the ancient world would, to see a creature of overwhelming strength.

And what does he see?

"And between the throne and the four living creatures and among the elders I saw a Lamb standing, as though it had been slain." — Revelation 5:6

John hears "Lion." He sees "Lamb." He hears the language of military triumph. He sees the evidence of sacrificial death.

This is not a mistake. It is the most important interpretive key in the book of Revelation—and arguably in the entire New Testament. The Lion

is the Lamb. The conqueror is the slain one. The one who has triumphed over every power in the cosmos has done so not by wielding a sword but by being slaughtered. Victory and sacrifice are not opposites. In God's economy, sacrifice is victory. Death is the means of conquest. The Lamb who was slain is the only one worthy to open the scroll and execute God's plan for history.

Richard Bauckham, one of the foremost scholars of Revelation, argues that this Lion-Lamb juxtaposition redefines the concept of power for the entire Christian community. When you hear "power" and expect a lion but see a lamb, the word "power" itself has been transformed. You can no longer use the word the way Rome uses it. You can no longer use the word the way political movements use it. Power, in the Kingdom of God, looks like a slaughtered Lamb standing in the throne room of the universe.

And notice: the Lamb is standing. It has been slain, but it is not dead. It bears the marks of its suffering, but it is alive. This is the resurrection—the vindication of the path of sacrifice. God did not rescue Jesus from the cross. He vindicated Jesus through the cross. The suffering was not a detour on the way to victory. The suffering

was the victory. And the resurrection is the Father's declaration that this is how He conquers, this is how He redeems, this is how He establishes His Kingdom—not through the sword, but through the self-giving love of the Lamb.

Then heaven responds:

"Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!" — Revelation 5:12

Power belongs to the Lamb. Not to the empire. Not to the political machine. Not to the cultural movement that promises to restore Christian influence. Power—real, ultimate, universe-shaping power—belongs to the one who was slaughtered. And the elders and the living creatures do not debate this or qualify it or add footnotes about political strategy. They worship.

That is the theology of power the church is called to embody. And it is a theology that the politically captive church has largely forgotten.

How the Saints Conquer: Revelation 12

If Revelation 5 shows how Christ conquers, Revelation 12 shows how His people do. And the mode of victory is the same.

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death." —Revelation 12:11

Three weapons. Not one of them is a sword.

The blood of the Lamb. The word of their testimony. The willingness to die.

The saints in Revelation do not conquer the dragon by organizing a more effective political coalition. They do not conquer by electing a sympathetic emperor. They do not conquer by accumulating enough cultural capital to marginalize their opponents. They conquer by

holding fast to their confession—"Jesus is Lord"—even when that confession costs them everything.

Their political action is worship. Their resistance is faithfulness. Their revolution is the refusal to say "Caesar is Lord" even when the alternative is death.

This is not passivity. Revelation 12:11 is a victory statement. "They have conquered." The verb is *enikéw* (ἐνίκησεν) they overcame, they prevailed, they won. But the manner of their victory is what stuns the imagination. They won by dying. They prevailed by refusing to save themselves. They overcame the dragon by loving faithfulness more than survival.

Now ask yourself: Does that sound like the American church right now?

Does the church in America look like a community that has conquered its fear of death? Does it look like a people who love not their lives even unto death? Or does it look like a people who are terrified of losing cultural influence, political access, tax-exempt status, and the comfortable assumption that America is "our" country?

A church that is afraid of losing cannot conquer in the manner of Revelation 12. Because Revelation 12's victory depends on the willingness to lose everything except the confession. And a church that has made political power essential to its survival has, by definition, added a requirement that the New Testament never imposes.

The early church did not need a friendly emperor to be faithful. It did not need legislative protection to proclaim the gospel. It did not need cultural dominance to transform lives. It needed the blood of the Lamb, the word of its testimony, and the courage to die.

That is still all it needs.

What Happens When the Church Picks Up the Sword

History provides devastating evidence of what happens when the

church abandons the logic of the cross and adopts the logic of the sword. We do not need to speculate. We only need to remember.

The Crusades were launched in the name of Christ and drenched the Holy Land in blood. The Inquisition used the instruments of state coercion to enforce theological conformity and tortured those who dissented. The wars of religion that followed the Reformation—Catholic against Protestant, Protestant against Protestant—killed millions in the name of doctrines that were supposed to bring peace. The colonial missions of the sixteenth through nineteenth centuries used the cross as a vanguard for imperial conquest, so that to this day, in vast portions of the global South, Christianity is associated with cultural destruction, slavery, and the theft of land.

Every one of these catastrophes occurred when the church adopted the state's logic—when it decided that the way to advance the Kingdom was through coercion, control, and the exercise of political power. Every one of them represents a betrayal of the Lamb's mode of conquest. And every one of them did incalculable damage to the credibility of the gospel.

The argument is not that every Christian who engages in politics is heading toward the Crusades. That is a caricature, and caricatures do not persuade. The argument is that there is a structural logic at work: when the church treats political power as essential to its mission, the methods of political power inevitably reshape the church's character. You cannot wield the sword without being shaped by the sword. You cannot adopt the state's tools without absorbing the state's instincts.

Jesus warned about this in the most direct terms possible:

"Put your sword back into its place. For all who take the sword will perish by the sword." —Matthew 26:52

He said this to Peter—the same Peter who had confessed Him as the Christ, the same Peter who would later deny Him, the same Peter who would eventually die a martyr's death. Peter reached for the

sword because he wanted to protect Jesus. The motive was understandable. The love was genuine. The instinct was human and even admirable.

And Jesus rebuked it. Not because defending the innocent is always wrong. But because in that moment, the sword represented an alternative to the cross. It represented the belief that what God was about to accomplish through suffering could be improved upon by violence. It represented the same temptation that had followed Jesus from the wilderness to Caesarea Philippi to Gethsemane: bypass the cross, take the shortcut, fight the battle on the world's terms.

The church that picks up the sword may win battles. It may secure cultural influence. It may preserve its tax exemptions and its social respectability and its access to the halls of power. But it will lose something far more valuable than anything it gains: it will lose its resemblance to Jesus. And a church that no longer resembles Jesus is no longer the church, regardless of how many seats it holds in Congress.

The Church That Chooses the Cross

So what does it look like, practically, for the church to operate by the logic of the cross rather than the logic of the sword? What does cross-shaped power look like in the real world, in real communities, in real political engagement?

It looks like a church that tells the truth when truth is costly. The politically captive church has learned to be silent when silence is strategic—to overlook the sins of its preferred leaders, to mute its prophetic voice when speaking up might jeopardize access. A cross-shaped church tells the truth to both parties, both movements, both sides of every cultural divide. It speaks with the specificity that makes everyone uncomfortable, because the prophetic tradition does not deal in vague generalities. Nathan did not say to David, "Some people have done some bad things." He said, "You are the man." A church that cannot name specific sins in its own political tribe has been captured by that tribe.

It looks like a church that loves its enemies visibly and concretely. Not in theory. Not in sermon illustrations. In practice. It means Christians across the political divide worshiping together, serving together, and refusing to allow political disagreement to become relational destruction. It means caring for people your party has labeled as threats. It means pursuing the good of communities that did not vote the way you did. It means demonstrating, in the flesh, that baptism creates a deeper bond than voter registration.

It looks like a church that serves the vulnerable without leveraging that service for political gain. When the church cares for the poor, visits the prisoner, feeds the hungry, and welcomes the stranger, it must do so because Jesus commanded it—not because it produces good optics, not because it builds a platform, not because it positions the church as a useful partner for whatever administration happens to be in power. Service that is contaminated by political strategy is no longer service. It is marketing. And the watching world can tell the difference.

It looks like a church that suffers without retaliating. This is the hardest and most essential mark of cross-shaped power. When the church is criticized, marginalized, mocked, or legally constrained, its response reveals which theology of power it actually holds. If the response is outrage, litigation, political retaliation, and the mobilization of cultural warfare, the church is operating by the sword's logic. If the response is patient endurance, continued faithfulness, undiminished love, and the quiet confidence that the tomb is empty—that is the logic of the cross.

Peter, the same disciple who once reached for the sword, eventually learned the difference:

"For to this you have been called, because Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, so that you might follow in his steps. He committed no sin, neither was deceit found in his mouth. When he was reviled, he did not revile in return; when he suffered, he did not threaten, but continued entrusting himself to him who judges

justly." —1 Peter 2:21–23

When He was reviled, He did not revile in return. When He suffered, He did not threaten. He entrusted Himself to the one who judges justly.

That is cross-shaped power. It is not weakness. It is the most radical form of strength available to human beings: the strength to absorb evil without reproducing it, to endure suffering without becoming the kind of person who inflicts it, to trust that God's judgment is more reliable than your retaliation.

And it is the only kind of power that the resurrection vindicates.

Answering the Objection: "This Sounds Like Surrender"

Let me anticipate the strongest objection to everything I have written in this chapter. Someone is reading this and thinking: "This is naive. This is pie-in-the-sky idealism. This is the theology of people who have never had to protect their families, their churches, or their communities from real threats. In the real world, you need power. In the real world, the cross does not stop legislation. In the real world, you cannot love your enemies into policy change."

I want to take that objection seriously, because it is not trivial. Real evil exists. Real injustice exists. Real threats to religious liberty, to the vulnerable, to the common good—these are not imaginary. And the Bible itself affirms that the state has a role in restraining evil through the exercise of force. Romans 13 is in the canon. It is not going away.

But notice what the objection assumes. It assumes that the only alternative to political power is passivity. It assumes that if the church does not wield the sword, it must be sitting on its hands. It assumes that the options are either political dominance or total withdrawal.

That is a false binary. And it is the false binary that has trapped the American church for decades.

The early church was not passive. It was the most active, most

transforming, most culturally disruptive movement in the history of the ancient world. It fed the hungry. It cared for plague victims when Roman elites fled the cities. It welcomed slaves and masters to the same table. It created communities of radical equality, sacrificial generosity, and stubborn hope in the face of imperial power. It told the truth about who was really in charge. And it did all of this without a single seat in the Roman Senate.

The early church did not have political power. It had something better: spiritual authority. And spiritual authority came not from its proximity to the throne but from its proximity to the cross.

So the question is not whether the church should act. Of course it should act. The question is whether the church's action must take the form of political domination in order to be effective. And the New Testament's answer is no. The church's most powerful action has always been its witness—its willingness to live so differently, love so extravagantly, speak so truthfully, and die so courageously that the watching world cannot explain it by any category other than "God is among them."

That is not surrender. That is the most dangerous thing the church can be. Because a church that operates by the logic of the cross cannot be controlled by the logic of the sword. A church that does not need political power cannot be manipulated by the promise of political power. A church that has already died—that has taken up its cross and followed Jesus into death and resurrection—has nothing left to lose. And a church with nothing left to lose is, paradoxically, the most powerful force on earth.

Repent from Trusting, Not from Voting

So here is the call. And it is a call to repentance—not the kind of repentance that withdraws from the world, but the kind that reorders the soul.

Repent from trusting. Not from voting.

Repent from the belief that the church needs political power to

survive. It does not. The church was born without it, grew without it, and has repeatedly been purified by losing it.

Repent from the belief that the right president, the right Congress, the right Supreme Court composition can secure what only Christ can secure. They cannot. They never could. Every political arrangement in history has been temporary. The Kingdom of God is not.

Repent from the fear that drives you to compromise your integrity for political outcomes. Fear is not a strategy. Fear is a confession that you have forgotten who is on the throne. And the one on the throne is not sitting in the Oval Office. He is seated at the right hand of God, and every knee will bow to Him—not because the church amassed enough political capital to force compliance, but because He is the risen Lord of the universe.

Repent from the contempt that your political engagement has produced. If your involvement in politics has made you crueler, more tribal, more willing to dehumanize people made in the image of God—then your politics have been discipling you more effectively than your faith. The fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. If your political engagement is producing rage, contempt, and self-righteousness, the root is diseased, no matter how righteous the cause.

Repent from the substitution—the quiet, gradual, fear-driven replacement of Christ as the center of your hope with a political project, a political leader, or a political vision. Name it. Be specific. Do not spiritualize it. Say what it is. Say, "I have treated this movement as though it were the Kingdom." Say, "I have defended this leader as though he were anointed in a way that no politician is." Say, "I have made winning feel like salvation and losing feel like death."

And then do what Hosea 14 says:

"Assyria shall not save us; we will not ride on horses; and we will say no more, 'Our God,' to the work of our hands." —Hosea 14:3

Put the idol down. Stop calling it wisdom. Stop calling it realism. Stop calling it responsible leadership. Call it what it is: relocated trust. And come home.

Because the God who named the adultery is the same God who heals it:

"I will heal their apostasy; I will love them freely, for my anger has turned from them." —Hosea 14:4

Freely. Lavishly. Without a probationary period. Without a lecture. The God of Hosea does not wait for you to clean yourself up before He welcomes you back. He meets you in your mess. He heals what is broken. He loves you back to life.

That is the God we return to. Not a policy platform. Not a cultural vision. Not a political messiah. The crucified and risen Christ, who has already defeated every power that has ever claimed ultimacy—including the ones you are tempted to trust right now.

What Is Actually Preserved by the Cross

The church's future is not preserved by presidents, congresses, courts, or cultural legislation.

The church's future is preserved by holiness—the kind of holiness that makes the watching world curious about the God who produces it.

The church's future is preserved by prayer—not the kind of prayer that lobbies heaven for partisan outcomes, but the kind that surrenders to the God who is sovereign over every nation, every election, and every empire that has ever risen or fallen.

The church's future is preserved by truth—spoken with courage, with specificity, with consistency to both left and right, and with the willingness to accept the cost of saying what no one wants to hear.

The church's future is preserved by the love of enemies—the one command of Jesus that no political movement on earth has ever been

willing to endorse, the one practice that has no strategic value whatsoever, and the one thing that most clearly marks a community as belonging to the crucified God.

The church's future is preserved by gospel courage—the willingness to proclaim the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ as the decisive event in the history of the world, to call all people to repentance and faith, and to do so without apology, without political calculation, and without the need for any earthly power to validate the message.

These are the weapons of divine power. They are not impressive by the world's standards. They do not fill arenas. They do not trend on social media. They do not produce the rush of adrenaline that comes from political victory.

But they raise the dead.

And a church that can raise the dead does not need to win an election to prove it is alive.

The Closing Word

Propaganda can fill arenas. It cannot raise the dead.

A church that chooses propaganda over resurrection power may keep its influence for a moment. But it will lose its soul.

A church that chooses the cross will lose—in the world's estimation. It will be mocked. It will be marginalized. It will be told it is irrelevant, naive, and weak. It will be tempted, every single day, to pick up the sword and fight the battle on the world's terms.

But the way of Jesus always looks like it is losing right up until Sunday morning.

And then everything changes.

So put down the sword. Pick up the cross. And trust the Lamb.

Because the one who stands between you and destruction is not riding a chariot. He is not occupying an office. He is not building a

coalition.

He is standing in a throne room, bearing the marks of His slaughter, and every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth is singing:

"Worthy is the Lamb who was slain."

That is the power. That is the victory. That is the only King who will never disappoint, never betray, and never need your political project to succeed.

Trust Him.

And let the sword go.

Key Takeaways

- Romans 13 affirms the state's legitimate use of the sword to restrain evil, but Paul never gives the church the sword—the church's weapons are "not of the flesh" but have "divine power to destroy strongholds" (2 Corinthians 10:3–4).

- The cross is not merely the mechanism of personal salvation—it is God's definitive revelation of how He conquers: by absorbing evil rather than retaliating, by suffering rather than coercing.

- Revelation 5 redefines power: John hears "Lion" but sees "Lamb." The

conqueror of the cosmos is the slain one. Victory and sacrifice are the same act in God's economy.

- The saints in Revelation 12 conquer by the blood of the Lamb, the word of their testimony, and the willingness to die—not by political coalitions, cultural dominance, or legislative strategy.

- Every historical catastrophe where the church adopted the sword—Crusades, Inquisition, wars of religion, colonial missions—demonstrates that wielding the state's tools reshapes the church's character.

- The alternative to political power is not passivity—it is

spiritual authority: the church's most transforming moments have come when it had the least political power and the greatest proximity to the cross.

- Repentance means not withdrawing from political engagement but renouncing political trust as ultimate: "Assyria shall not save us."
- The church's future is preserved by holiness, prayer, truth-telling, enemy-love, and gospel courage—weapons that do not fill arenas but can raise the dead.

Reflection Questions

1. When you think about the church's future, does your confidence rest

primarily on the power of the Spirit or on the outcome of the next election? What does your emotional response to political news reveal about which theology of power you actually hold?

2. Can you identify a specific instance where your church or community

adopted the logic of the sword—coercion, manipulation, dehumanization of opponents—while claiming to serve the Kingdom of God? What was the fruit?

3. If the church lost all political influence tomorrow—no access, no

cultural clout, no legislative influence—what would remain? Would it be enough? Does the thought fill you with dread or with freedom?

4. Read 1 Peter 2:21–23 slowly. When you are reviled, do you revile in

return? When you suffer political loss, do you threaten? Or do you entrust yourself to the one who judges justly? Where is the gap

between Peter's description and your actual practice?

5. What would it look like for your church to be the most loving, most

truthful, most generous community in your city—without any political advantage whatsoever? Would that mission feel like enough?

6. Has your political engagement over the past decade made you more

like the Lamb or more like the beast? Be honest about the fruit: patience or rage, humility or contempt, faithfulness or compromise.

Practices

- Personal: Read Revelation 5 every morning this week. Each day, journal one way the Lion-Lamb vision challenges how you think about power, victory, and the church's mission. Ask: "Where have I been expecting a lion when God is sending a lamb?"

- Personal: Identify one area where you have adopted the logic of the

sword—where you have responded to opposition with coercion, contempt, or the desire to dominate rather than serve. Confess it specifically. Ask God to replace the sword with the cross in that area of your life.

- Family: Read Matthew 26:47–56 together—Peter's use of the sword

and Jesus' rebuke. Discuss: Where has our family reached for the "sword" (anger, retaliation, political hostility) when Jesus was calling us to a different response? What would it look like to put the sword back?

- Church: Ask your congregation or small group to articulate the church's mission using only the categories of Revelation 12:11—the blood of the Lamb, the word of testimony, and the willingness to suffer. Does the mission survive this filter? What would need to

change if it does not?

Sources & Notes

Romans 13:1–7—The state's God-given role as "servant" bearing the sword for the restraint of evil. 2 Corinthians 10:3–5—The weapons of the church's warfare: not of the flesh, but divinely powerful for the destruction of strongholds. 1 Corinthians 1:18–25—The word of the cross as the power of God; the foolishness of God wiser than men. Revelation 5:5–14—The Lion who is the Lamb; the redefinition of conquering through sacrifice; the universal worship of the slain one. Revelation 12:11—The saints' mode of victory: the blood of the Lamb, the word of testimony, and the willingness to die. Matthew 26:52—Jesus' rebuke of Peter's sword: "All who take the sword will perish by the sword." 1 Peter 2:21–23—Christ's example of absorbing evil without retaliation, entrusting Himself to the one who judges justly. Hosea 14:1–5—The structure of repentance: confession, renunciation of false saviors, and God's promise to heal apostasy freely. Fleming Rutledge, *The Crucifixion* (Eerdmans, 2015)—On the cross as God's definitive act of power through weakness. Richard Bauckham, *The Theology of the Book of Revelation* (Cambridge, 1993)—On the Lion-Lamb juxtaposition and the reinterpretation of messianic victory. John Howard Yoder, *The Politics of Jesus* (Eerdmans, 1972)—On the political implications of Jesus' rejection of violence and the cross as social ethics. Miroslav Volf, *Exclusion and Embrace* (Abingdon, 1996)—On the theology of embrace, the refusal of violence, and the cross as the model for engaging the "other."

CONCLUSION

Repent, Not Retreat

"The church that refuses to worship the empire does not withdraw from the empire. It haunts the empire."

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The temptation, after everything we have examined, is to leave.

To close the book, close the church door behind you, and walk away from the mess. To decide that if the American church has so thoroughly confused its identity with the nation's identity, then the only honest response is disengagement. Withdrawal. A quiet, dignified retreat into private belief and personal ethics, leaving the public square to the politicians and the culture warriors and whoever else wants the microphone.

I understand that temptation. I have sat with it more mornings than I want to admit.

But retreat is not what the gospel demands. And it is not what this book has been building toward.

The call is not retreat. The call is repentance. And repentance looks nothing like withdrawal.

The Difference Between Repentance and Retreat

Retreat says: the system is broken, so I am leaving. Repentance says: I am broken, and I am staying to be healed.

Retreat is an act of disgust. Repentance is an act of love. Retreat writes off the institution. Repentance grieves what the institution has become while refusing to abandon the people still inside it. Retreat protects the self. Repentance exposes the self to God and asks Him to

do what only He can do.

The prophet Hosea did not retreat from Israel. He married into its brokenness. God did not retreat from the adulterous nation. He pursued it through the wilderness and spoke tenderly to it there. Jesus did not retreat from the temple system that had been corrupted by commerce and political calculation. He walked into the center of it, turned over the tables, and wept over the city that did not recognize the hour of its visitation.

Repentance is not less engaged than activism. It is more engaged. Because repentance begins with the self, it earns the moral authority that external critique never possesses. The person who has named their own complicity in the problem has a credibility that the person who merely diagnoses everyone else's complicity does not.

I have been complicit. Let me be specific.

I have stood in pulpits where the American flag occupied a place of honor that was never theologically warranted, and I said nothing. I have preached sermons that challenged comfortable Christianity in the abstract while avoiding the specific, named, politically charged applications that would have cost me congregants. I have known, in the marrow of my pastoral instinct, that something was wrong with the fusion of faith and national identity in the churches I served, and I chose the path of least resistance more times than I chose the path of faithfulness.

This book is not written from above the problem. It is written from inside it.

What Repentance Looks Like in Practice

Repentance is not a feeling. It is a reorientation. And reorientation produces specific, observable changes.

It means refusing to let any political leader function as a litmus test for Christian faithfulness. When the measure of someone's Christianity becomes their voting record, the gospel has been

replaced. It happened in the fourth century when fidelity to the emperor became the functional test of orthodoxy. It happened in 1930s Germany when party membership became the dividing line between respectable Christians and suspicious ones. It is happening now, and we can see it if we are willing to look.

It means recovering the confession that our citizenship is in heaven. Not as an escape from earthly responsibility, but as the foundation for it. Paul wrote those words to the Philippians while sitting in a Roman prison. He was not disengaged from the empire. He was operating within it by a different set of loyalties. The empire could imprison his body. It could not relocate his allegiance.

It means sitting in the discomfort of political homelessness. The gospel does not fit neatly into any party platform. If your faith aligns perfectly with one political tribe, one of two things is true: either you have discovered the only political movement in history that perfectly embodies the Kingdom of God, or you have unconsciously trimmed your theology to fit your politics. The second option is overwhelmingly more likely.

It means repenting of contempt. This is the hardest one. Political engagement in America has produced a contempt so pervasive that Christians on every side of every debate have learned to see their opponents as enemies rather than as image-bearers. The conservative Christian who mocks the progressive. The progressive Christian who sneers at the conservative. Both have been disciplined more by their political tribe than by Jesus, because Jesus commanded love for enemies, and contempt is love's opposite.

It means learning to lament before we legislate. The prophets of Israel did not begin with policy proposals. They began with grief. They named the sin, wept over it, and then pointed toward the God who heals. The American church has largely skipped the grief and gone straight to the platform. We want action without confession. We want victory without repentance. We want the benefits of prophetic speech without the cost of prophetic tears.

It means holding our institutions loosely while holding our people tightly. The buildings will not last. The denominations will restructure. The programs will evolve or die. But the people in the pews, the pastors in the offices, the teenagers in the back rows who are watching everything we do and deciding whether any of it is real, they are the church. They are what is worth fighting for. Not the brand. Not the influence. Not the cultural position.

Ten Commitments for the Politically Homeless Christian

I am not going to pretend these are easy. They are not a checklist. They are a rule of life for Christians who refuse to let the empire define them but also refuse to abandon the empire to its own devices.

I will remember that my primary identity is in Christ, not in any nation, party, or movement. When those identities conflict, Christ wins without negotiation.

I will vote my conscience, but I will not let my vote become my identity. I will hold my political convictions with conviction and my political tribe with open hands.

I will refuse to demonize those who vote differently than I do. The image of God is not contingent on the ballot.

I will measure my political engagement by the fruit of the Spirit, not by the outcomes of elections. If my politics are making me more angry, more contemptuous, more tribally loyal, and less like Jesus, the problem is not the other side. The problem is me.

I will prioritize the local church over the national platform. The Kingdom advances through gathered communities of worship, service, and proclamation, not through political coalitions.

I will read my Bible more carefully than I read the news. When the news cycle sets my emotional agenda, something has gone wrong in my spiritual formation.

I will name idolatry when I see it, including when it appears in my own mirror. I will extend the same critique to my allies that I

extend to my opponents, because the gospel does not play favorites.

I will sit with people who disagree with me without needing to convert them to my politics. The table of Christ is wider than any party platform.

I will teach my children that America is a gift but not a god. I will raise them to be grateful citizens and loyal Kingdom people, and I will teach them the difference.

I will trust that the crucified and risen Christ is sufficient. That His Kingdom does not depend on any president, any court, any legislation, any cultural tide. That the church has survived every empire that tried to co-opt it, and it will survive this one too. Not by winning the culture war, but by being what it was always meant to be: a community of cruciform love so different from the world around it that the watching world cannot explain it by any category other than God.

The God Who Heals Apostasy

I have spent ten chapters naming a disease. I want to end by naming the cure.

The cure is not a better political strategy. It is not a more sophisticated cultural engagement model. It is not a new coalition or a reformed platform or a smarter brand of Christian activism.

The cure is the same one Hosea prescribed three thousand years ago:

"Return, O Israel, to the Lord your God, for you have stumbled because of your iniquity. Take with you words and return to the Lord; say to him, 'Take away all iniquity; accept what is good, and we will pay with bulls the vows of our lips. Assyria shall not save us; we will not ride on horses; and we will say no more, 'Our God,' to the work of our hands. In you the orphan finds mercy.'" —Hosea 14:1–3

Three movements in that prayer. Three acts of repentance that map directly onto everything this book has described.

First: confession. "Take away all iniquity." Not a general admission of wrongdoing, but a specific acknowledgment that something has gone deeply wrong. We have stumbled. Not the culture. Not the secularists. Not the political opponents. We have stumbled. The American church has relocated its trust, and we need God to remove what we cannot remove ourselves.

Second: renunciation. "Assyria shall not save us; we will not ride on horses; and we will say no more, 'Our God,' to the work of our hands." This is the hardest part. Naming the specific idols. Naming the political alliances we have treated as saviors. Naming the cultural power we have confused with Kingdom power. Naming the human leaders we have invested with a trust that belongs only to God. And saying, out loud, in specific terms: these things will not save us. We will stop pretending they can.

Third: return. "In you the orphan finds mercy." The final word is not about what we renounce. It is about where we go. We go back to the God whose mercy does not depend on our political usefulness or our cultural influence. The God who receives the orphan. The God who does not wait for us to earn our way back but meets us with the same reckless, pursuing, Hosea-shaped love that sent Him after Israel in the wilderness and after us on the cross.

And here is how God responds to that prayer:

"I will heal their apostasy; I will love them freely, for my anger has turned from them. I will be like the dew to Israel; he shall blossom like the lily; he shall take root like the trees of Lebanon." — Hosea 14:4–5

Freely. Not provisionally. Not after a sufficient period of penance. Not once we have demonstrated that we have learned our lesson. Freely.

The God who named our adultery is the same God who heals it. The God who saw the flag go up next to the cross and grieved is the same God who says, "Come home."

That is the invitation. Not to a better political position. Not to a more enlightened cultural stance. Not to a purer form of activism.

Home. To the crucified King who refuses to be anyone's mascot. To the Kingdom that does not depend on the survival of any nation. To the God who calls His people back from every empire they have mistaken for His throne.

The church's future does not depend on winning the culture war. It never did. The church's future depends on the same thing it has depended on since a handful of unarmed, unfinanced, politically powerless followers of a crucified rabbi walked out of an upper room and into an empire that would try to destroy them.

The Spirit. The Word. The willingness to die rather than worship anything other than the risen Christ.

That was enough then. It is enough now. It will be enough when every empire that ever demanded the church's loyalty is dust.

AFTERWORD

A Confession and an Invitation

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I owe you a confession.

I did not write this book from a position of clarity. I wrote it from confusion. From the slow, grinding recognition that the faith I was raised in and the faith I preach and the faith I stake my life on had been tangled up with things that do not belong to it. And that I was part of the tangling.

I grew up without a father. I came to faith as an atheist in college. I did not inherit Christianity from a family legacy or a cultural tradition. I had to fight my way in from the outside, and the thing that drew me was not the institution. It was not the flag in the sanctuary or the political identity of the congregation. It was a person. A crucified and risen person who answered the questions nobody else would take seriously and who did not require me to pretend I was someone I was not.

That Jesus is the one I preach. That Jesus is the one I write about. And that Jesus is the one who kept interrupting me while I worked on this book, asking whether I had included myself in my own indictment.

I have.

Not as a rhetorical strategy. Not as performed humility to earn your trust. As the truth. I have been shaped by the same forces this book describes. I have absorbed civil religion without noticing. I have confused cultural Christianity with the gospel in ways I am still discovering. I have preached the Kingdom while operating by the logic of the empire.

The difference between me and the people I have spent ten chapters diagnosing is not virtue. It is awareness. And awareness is not the same as innocence. Seeing the problem does not mean I have solved it in myself.

I wrote this book because someone needed to say it, and I realized I was someone.

Not the only one. Not the best one. Someone.

If this book has angered you, I understand. Some of it was written to provoke anger, because anger is sometimes the first sign that a nerve has been struck that needed striking. But if your anger is the only thing you walk away with, then I have failed. The goal was never to tear down. The goal was to clear the ground so that something truer could be built.

If this book has grieved you, I understand that too. I have grieved writing it. Some of these chapters cost me sleep. Some of them cost me friendships. Some of them will cost me opportunities that I would have had if I had kept my mouth shut and preached safe sermons to comfortable congregations.

I am not looking for sympathy. I chose this. And I would choose it again.

But I want you to know that the grief is real, because I do not want you to mistake my directness for detachment. I am not detached from the church I have critiqued. I am married to it. I am inside it every Sunday. I counsel its people on Tuesdays. I preach to the same faces week after week, knowing that some of them will hear these words and wonder if I am talking about them.

I am talking about us.

Here is the invitation.

I am not inviting you to leave your church. I am not inviting you to abandon your political convictions. I am not inviting you to become cynical about the American experiment or dismissive of the

people who love this country with genuine devotion.

I am inviting you to hold your faith and your nation in the right order. To let the cross interrogate the flag rather than the other way around. To sit with the discomfort of discovering that some of what you inherited as Christianity was actually something else wearing Christian clothes.

I am inviting you to do the thing the prophets always asked Israel to do: return. Not to a golden age that never existed. Not to a political arrangement that seemed to work for a while. To God. The living God who is not threatened by the decline of any nation and not dependent on the success of any political movement. The God who heals apostasy freely and loves the returning prodigal before the prodigal has cleaned up.

I am inviting you to the table. Not my table. The Lord's table. The one where Republican and Democrat, conservative and progressive, the politically engaged and the politically exhausted all sit down together under the same cross and eat the same bread and drink the same cup and remember that the thing that binds them is not a shared platform but a shared Lord.

That table is the future of the church. Not the voting booth. Not the rally. Not the news cycle. The table.

I will meet you there. Bring your questions. Bring your anger. Bring your grief. Bring the fragments of a faith that feels like it has been used for purposes it was never designed for.

The crucified King is at the head of that table. He has been there since before the first empire tried to claim Him, and He will be there long after the last one falls.

He is enough. He has always been enough.

And that is the thing I most needed to remember while writing this book. So I am saying it one last time, as much to myself as to you.

He is enough.

